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DR. MANMOHAN SINGH
BENGALURU CITY UNIVERSITY

BACHELOR OF COMPUTER APPLICATION (BCA)

ALCHEMY-IV

SEMESTER-IV
GENERAL ENGLISH TEXTBOOK
(As per the State Education Policy 2024)

Chief Editor
Dr. T.N. Thandava Gowda

Editor
Dr. Padmavathy. K

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ALCHEMY – IV *General English Textbook for IV Semester BCA has been prepared by the members of BCA Textbook Committee, Dr. Manmohan Singh Bengaluru City University (BCU).*

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(BCU) First Edition: 2026

FOREWORD

Alchemy IV, the General English textbook for the IV Semester B.C.A. and other undergraduate programmes under the Faculty of Computer Applications, has been meticulously developed to address the linguistic, communicative, and intellectual needs of students in technical and professional streams. In an era defined by rapid technological advancement, the ability to articulate ideas clearly and confidently — in both written and spoken forms — has become as vital as domain-specific expertise.

This textbook seeks to enrich students' literary sensibilities and enhance their overall communicative competence through a well-structured blend of literary content and skill-oriented exercises. The selection of texts — comprising a novella, poems, a short story, and a speech — is complemented by practical modules on email writing, interview and group discussion techniques, report writing, and research skills. These components are thoughtfully curated to reflect real-world scenarios and contemporary professional expectations.

Unit I: Literary Skills introduces learners to diverse literary traditions and perspectives from both global and Indian contexts, nurturing critical thinking, empathy, and cultural literacy. Unit II: Communicative Skills focuses on developing the four foundational language abilities — Listening, Speaking, Reading, and Writing (LSRW) — thereby empowering students with essential tools for academic achievement and career readiness.

I am confident that *Alchemy IV* will serve not only as a robust foundation for effective communication but also as a meaningful catalyst for personal development and intellectual growth. I express my sincere gratitude to the BCA Textbook Committee for their dedication, commitment, and significant contributions to the creation of this syllabus.

Prof. Ramesh B

Hon'ble Vice-Chancellor

Dr. Manmohan Singh Bengaluru City University

PREFACE

The General English syllabus for the Fourth Semester of the Bachelor of Computer Applications (B.C.A.) programme at Dr. Manmohan Singh Bengaluru City University has been thoughtfully designed to nurture both literary appreciation and effective communication skills. Developed in accordance with the State Education Policy 2024, the syllabus strikes a purposeful balance between creativity and practicality, ensuring that language learning remains relevant to the academic and professional aspirations of students.

The literary component features a carefully curated selection of texts — poems, a short story, a speech, and a novella — chosen for their ability to inspire critical reflection, cultural understanding, and aesthetic appreciation. These works not only enhance students' sensitivity to language and expression but also provide insight into diverse human experiences and social contexts.

Complementing this, the language and skill-building component focuses on strengthening students' LSRW (Listening, Speaking, Reading, and Writing) competencies. Through activities such as comprehension exercises, interview and group discussion practice, email writing, and research-based tasks, students gain the communicative confidence and clarity required to excel in both academic settings and real-world professional environments.

This syllabus has been meticulously curated by the Textbook Committee to ensure a holistic, student-centered learning experience. It is my earnest hope that this resource not only meets the curricular objectives but also renders the study of English engaging, meaningful, and intellectually enriching.

I extend my heartfelt gratitude to the Chairperson, the esteemed members of the Textbook Committee, and the publishing team for their dedication, collaboration, and invaluable contributions to the successful realization of this textbook.

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NOTE TO THE TEACHER

*This General English syllabus for the **Fourth Semester B.C.A. programme** has been thoughtfully designed to enhance students' language proficiency while deepening their appreciation of literature. As a teacher, your role is pivotal in transforming the classroom into a space that is both engaging and intellectually enriching.*

Literary Component	40 marks
Communication Skills component	40 marks

Summative-Total	80 marks - written exam

Internal Assessment	
Internal Test	10 marks
Assignment	05 marks
Book Review	05 marks

Formative-Total	20 marks

Suggestions for Teaching:

- **Encourage participation:** *Create opportunities for group discussions, role plays, and presentations to help students gain confidence in spoken English.*
- **Connect literature to real life:** *Relate themes in the texts to current events or students' personal experiences to deepen engagement.*
- **Integrate skills:** *Combine reading and writing tasks with speaking and listening activities for a more holistic learning experience.*
- **Use formative assessments:** *Regular feedback and in-class exercises can help students track their progress and improve continuously.*
- **Foster creativity:** *Encourage students to write their own stories, speeches, and letters as extensions of textbook activities.*

The textbook has been carefully prepared to serve as both a learning resource and a teaching aid. Teachers are encouraged to adapt the materials to suit the needs of their learners, while also maintaining alignment with the academic goals of the program.

We hope this course not only improves students' language skills but also nurtures their confidence, creativity, and critical thinking.

Happy Teaching!

Dr Padmavathy.K
Chairperson
Text book Committee

GENERAL ENGLISH

COURSE DESCRIPTION

English Language course focuses on empowering students with English language skills and also to introduce them to different literary genres. Communication skills workbook focuses on enhancing communication skills through the learning of Comprehension skills, Summary writing, Email, Research skills and Book review. The IV BCA syllabus is offered to equip students with English Language Skills and introduce them different literary genres. The course will be covered with lectures and practical components such as seminars, assignments and Book Reviews.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

- *To improve LSRW (Listening, Speaking, Reading, Writing) competencies.*
- *To develop interpersonal communication abilities.*
- *To familiarize students with drama and dramatists by examining the selected text.*
- *To improve presentation and analytical skills.*
- *To be able to critically analyse, interpret and appreciate literary texts.*
- *To raise awareness of social, cultural, religious, and ethnic diversities.*
- *To facilitate employability in emerging fields such as content writing and interpretation.*
- *To facilitate preparation for competitive examinations.*

COURSE OUTCOMES

At the end of the course the students will have:

- *Acquired LSRW (Listening, Speaking, Reading, Writing) skills.*
- *Equipped themselves with interpersonal communication skills.*
- *Acquainted with significant movements in drama and notable dramatists.*
- *Augmented presentation and analytical skills.*
- *Ability to critically analyse, interpret and appreciate literary texts.*
- *An awareness of social, cultural, religious and ethnic diversities.*
- *Facilitated employability in emerging sectors such as – content writers and interpreters.*
- *Acquired language skills for competitive examinations*

DELIVERY OF CURRICULUM – STRUCTURE

The textbook has two components to equip students with -

- *Literary Skills*
- *Communication Skills*

Literary Skills

This focuses on a thorough and critical comprehension of skills, vocabulary enhancement, and reading proficiency. Students are exposed to various literary genres. Engaging with plays novels, essays, articles and similar texts will enhance their reading proficiency, critical thinking and creative abilities. The teacher will focus on promoting both loud reading and silent reading, elaborating on their advantages. Students are educated about Intensive Reading and Extensive Reading. Intensive reading requires learners to read meticulously with defined learning objectives and tasks. Activities such as reading paragraphs, stories will train the students to acquire the needed skills. In the extensive reading segment, the teacher guides the students with reading materials to explore independently. Short stories, novellas, brief plays, and fables will be made available for students, aiding them in vocabulary development, structural understanding, and acquiring a general comprehension of the content.

Communication Skills

The textbook has exercises designed to enhance the linguistic abilities of students, allowing the students to use language confidently as a means of communication for personal, social, official, professional, and business purposes, with clear and articulatory expression. The four fundamental skills in any language include Listening Skills, Speaking Skills, Reading Skills, and Writing Skills. During the process of language acquisition, learners initially engage with the language through a receptive understanding of its subtleties. Reading and Listening are classified as receptive skills. Following the development of receptive skills, learners advance to productive skills, which involve the active use of language.

Pedagogy

Listening skill can be taught by using ICT tools, web-based learning in Language Lab. Students can be given listening practice by making them listen to pre-recorded audios, songs, interviews, conversations, narratives, news and other listening activities. Along with the use of print media ICT tools should be used to make the students learn pronunciation, modulation of voice and better conversation. Students will learn the language and literature through role plays, presentations and assignments.

CURRICULUM STRUCTURE FOR THE UNDERGRADUATE DEGREE PROGRAMME

**B.C.A. AND OTHER PROGRAMMES UNDER FACULTY OF COMPUTER APPLICATIONS
IV SEMESTER - GENERAL ENGLISH**

Starting year of implementation: 2025-26	Total Credits for the Programme: 04
Subject: GENERAL ENGLISH	Teaching hour per week: 04
Name of the Degree Programme – B.C.A.	Total number of lecture hours/semester 60/64

Contents

IV SEMESTER - GENERAL ENGLISH B.C.A. AND OTHER PROGRAMMES UNDER FACULTY OF COMPUTER APPLICATIONS		60/64 hrs	80 marks	Page no.
UNIT – 1				
LITERARY SKILLS		30 hrs	40 marks	
NOVELLA	Billy Budd, Sailor – Herman Melville	14 hrs	20 marks	1
SHORT STORY	Friends – Grace Paley	4hrs	5 marks	8
SPEECH	My Visionfor Indian – Dr. A.P.J. Kalam	4hrs	5 marks	24
POEM	Refugee Blues – W.H. Auden	4hrs	5 marks	28
POEM	Indian Weavers – Sarojini Naidu	4hrs	5 marks	34

UNIT – II COMMUNICATION SKILLS (LSRW Skills)

	PRESENTATION SKILLS			
<i>LISTENING AND SPEAKING SKILLS</i>	Interview Skills	<i>4 hrs</i>	<i>5 Marks</i>	38
	Group Discussion	<i>4 hrs</i>	<i>5 Marks</i>	44
	Comprehension Passage	<i>3 hrs</i>	<i>10 Marks</i>	50
<i>READING AND WRITING SKILLS</i>	Report Writing <i>(Event and Field Visits)</i>	<i>3 hrs</i>	<i>5 Marks</i>	59
	Summarizing	<i>3 hrs</i>	<i>5 Marks</i>	64
	CORRESPONDENCES Email Etiquette <i>(Request, Permission, Apology, Complaint)</i>	<i>2 hrs</i>	<i>5 Marks</i>	67
	RESEARCH SKILLS Research Questionnaire <i>(Survey/Interview questions to the respondents)</i>	<i>6 hrs</i>	<i>5 Marks</i>	75
	Book Review (For Formative Assessment)	<i>5 hrs</i>	<i>5 Marks</i>	83
Question Paper Pattern				89
Model Question Paper				90

1. Billy Budd, Sailor

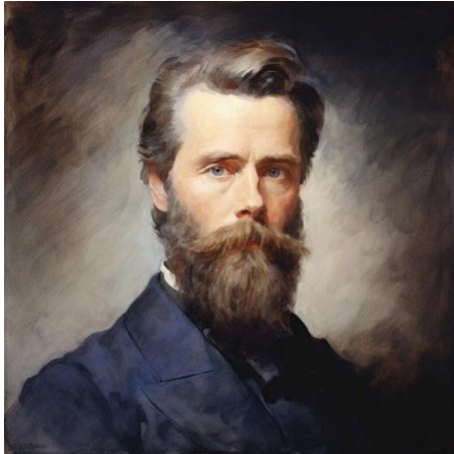
(Novella)

Herman Melville

Pre – Reading Activity:

- Do the institutions uphold or fail moral justice?
- Discuss about the discipline and hierarchy of naval service.

About the Author



Herman Melville was born into a well-off family in New York City. He began writing at an early age, and served on a trans-Atlantic merchant ship at the age of twenty. Following this voyage, he taught for some time, but took to the sea again in 1841. His sea travels and experiences with Polynesian natives greatly influenced his writing, especially his popular book *Typee*, based on his experiences with some natives of the Pacific isles.

After *Typee* he continued to write popular novels depicting life at sea, such as *Omoo* and *White-Jacket*, and, after marrying in 1847, settled down in New York and then in Massachusetts. Melville published *Moby Dick* in 1851, but (although it is regarded today as a classic) it was not a success. His literary career and popularity declined, but Melville continued to write, including *Billy Budd*. Deeply affected by the American Civil War, Melville also turned to writing poetry, though his poems, like his later novels, were also not highly regarded by his contemporaries. Melville died in 1891 in New York City, not a particularly popular author. After his death, though, his reputation was gradually recuperated, and he is now recognized as one of the greatest writers in the history of the United States.

Historical Context of Billy Budd

The events of the story take place during Great Britain's conflict with Napoleonic France, when the British Royal Navy was desperate for sailors to serve on its ships. The story also takes place soon after the Nore Mutiny, when members of the *Sandwich* mutinied against their captain. The danger of mutiny thus looms in the background of the story, affecting many of the characters' thoughts and actions.

About the Novel

Herman Melville's *Billy Budd, Sailor* is a tragic tale set in the late 18th century aboard the British

warship *H.M.S. Bellipotent*. The story follows Billy Budd, a young, innocent, and well-liked sailor who is forcibly recruited from a merchant ship. His beauty, goodness, and simplicity endear him to all except John Claggart, the ship's malicious master-at-arms, who becomes jealous and falsely accuses Billy of plotting mutiny. When confronted by Captain Vere and unable to defend himself because of his stammer, Billy impulsively strikes Claggart, killing him instantly. Though Captain Vere believes in Billy's innocence, he insists on upholding martial law, and Billy is sentenced to death. Billy accepts his fate with grace, blessing Vere before his execution. After his death, Billy becomes a symbol of purity and sacrifice, remembered with reverence by his fellow sailors even as official accounts distort the truth of his story.

Characters

- **Billy Budd** – The protagonist, a young, handsome, and innocent sailor impressed from the merchant ship *Rights-of-Man* into service aboard *H.M.S. Bellipotent*. Known for his goodness, simplicity, and cheerfulness, Billy's fatal flaw is his inability to speak under stress, which leads to tragedy when he accidentally kills Claggart.
- **Captain Edward Fairfax Vere** – The intelligent, disciplined, and duty-bound captain of the *Bellipotent*. He values law and order above personal feeling. Though he sympathizes with Billy and recognizes his innocence, he upholds martial law and orders Billy's execution.
- **John Claggart** – The master-at-arms on the *Bellipotent*, who secretly despises Billy out of envy and malice. Deceptive and manipulative, he falsely accuses Billy of plotting mutiny, ultimately leading to his own death at Billy's hands
- **The Dansker** – An old, experienced sailor who befriends Billy and warns him that Claggart bears ill will toward him. His wisdom contrasts with Billy's innocence.
- **Lieutenant Ratcliffe** – The officer who impresses Billy from the *Rights-of-Man* into naval service. His role introduces Billy to the world of warships and authority.
- **Captain Graveling** – The kind and reluctant captain of Billy's former ship, *Rights-of-Man*, who regrets losing his best sailor to the navy.
- **The Surgeon** – A medical officer aboard the *Bellipotent* who examines Claggart after his death and serves as a rational observer of events.
- **The Chaplain** – The ship's priest who visits Billy before his execution and is deeply moved by his calm acceptance and purity.

- **The Drumhead Court (First Lieutenant, Sailing Master, Captain of Marines)** – The officers who serve as judges during Billy's trial. They are torn between sympathy for Billy and their duty to enforce the law.

Overview of the Novel:

The setting is the last decade of the eighteenth century. The British naval warship H.M.S. *Bellipotent* impresses, or involuntarily recruits, the young sailor Billy Budd, extracting him from duty aboard the *Rights-of-Man*, a merchant ship. Billy's commanding officer, Captain Graveling, though reluctant to let one of his best men go, has little choice in the face of the superior ship's demands. Billy packs up his gear without so much as a protest and follows the boarding officer of the *Bellipotent*, Lieutenant Ratcliffe, across the gangway to his new assignment. After a cheery good-bye to his old mates, Billy settles in quickly among the company of the *Bellipotent*. He proves most industrious and eager in his role as foretopman and soon earns the affection of his more experienced fellow sailors.

Billy is deeply affected by the sight of a violent lashing given to one of the ship's crew. Hoping to avoid a similar punishment, Billy attempts to fulfill his duties in model fashion, but finds himself under constant scrutiny due to various minor infractions. Puzzled by this persecution, Billy seeks out the advice of the Dansker, an aged, experienced sailor. After explaining the situation to him, the Dansker concludes that Claggart, the master-at-arms, holds a grudge against Billy. Refusing to accept this theory, Billy dismisses the Dansker's opinion but continues to wonder pensively about his situation.

Shortly thereafter, at a lunchtime meal, Billy accidentally spills his soup pan in the ship's dining room after a sudden lurch. The contents of the pan trickle to the feet of the passing Claggart, who makes an offhand, seemingly light-hearted remark in recognition of the spill. His comment elicits a stream of obligatory laughter from the ship's company, and Billy interprets the event as proof of Claggart's approval. But Claggart is offended by the accident, and finds it indicative of Billy's contempt for him. He fixates on the accident as proof of Billy's hostility, and his assistant Squeak resolves to increase his surreptitious persecutions of Billy in recompense.

One night, an anonymous figure rouses Billy from his sleep on the upper deck and asks him to meet in a remote quarter of the ship. Confused, Billy mechanically obeys. At the mysterious rendezvous, Billy is puzzled when, after some vague discourse, the unidentified man flashes two guineas in exchange for a promise of cooperation. Without

comprehending the exact details of this solicitation, Billy recognizes that something is amiss, and he raises his stuttering voice and threatens the man with uncharacteristic violence. The conspirator quickly slinks into the darkness, and Billy finds himself confronted with the curious inquiries of two fellow sailors. Unsure of how to explain the situation, Billy explains that he simply happened upon a fellow sailor who was in the wrong part of the ship, and chased the man back to his proper station with a gruff rebuke.

Somewhat later, after a brief skirmish with an enemy frigate, Claggart approaches Captain Vere with news of a rumoured mutiny and names Billy Budd as the ringleader of the rebellion. Vere summons Billy to his cabin and instructs Claggart to repeat his accusation. Upon hearing of this unexpected blot on his character, Billy is rendered speechless. Vere commands Billy to defend himself, but then, noticing Billy's tendency to stutter, softens his approach. Left with no other means of defence, and twisted into a rage at Claggart's outrageous words against him, Billy strikes out in a fury, giving Claggart a swift punch to the forehead.

The blow proves forceful enough to knock Claggart unconscious, and he lies bleeding from the nose and ears as Billy and Vere attempt to revive him. Abandoning this effort, Vere dismisses Billy to a neighboring stateroom until further notice. The ship's surgeon pronounces Claggart dead after a brief examination, and Captain Vere summons a group of his senior officers to the cabin.

In a decisive move, Vere calls a drumhead court consisting of the captain of the marines, the first lieutenant, and the sailing master. Vere, functioning as the main witness, gives a testimony of the relevant events to the jury. Billy remains rather silent during his period of questioning, admitting to the blow but maintaining his innocence of intention and declaring his lack of affiliation with any potential mutiny. The court dismisses Billy again to the stateroom.

During a tense period of deliberation, Vere hovers over the jury. When they seem to be deadlocked, unable to make a decision, Vere steps forward to declare his conviction that the rule of law must supersede the reservations of conscience. He concludes his speech to the jury by insisting that they decide to acquit or condemn in strict accordance with the letter of military law. After a period of further deliberation, the jury finds Billy Budd guilty as charged and sentences him to death by hanging on the following morning.

Captain Vere communicates to Billy the news of his fate and, after a discussion with him

that we do not learn about directly, he withdraws to leave the prisoner by himself. Later that evening, Vere calls a general meeting of the ship's crew and explains the events of the day. Claggart receives an official burial at sea, and all hands prepare to bear witness to Billy's hanging at dawn.

Billy spends his final hours in chains on board an upper gun deck, guarded by a sentry. The ship's chaplain attempts to spiritually prepare Billy for his death, but Billy already seems to be in a state of perfect peace and resignation. As the chaplain withdraws from Billy's company, he kisses him gently on the cheek as a token of good will.

That morning, shortly after four A.M., Billy is hanged in the mainyard of the ship. As the crew watches him being strung up, preparing to die, they hear him utter his last words: "God bless Captain Vere!" The assembled company automatically echoes this unexpected sentiment, and Billy expires with surprising calm as dawn breaks over the horizon.

After Billy's death, the crew begins to murmur, but the officers quickly disperse them to various tasks. Whistles blow and the ship returns to regular business. In the ensuing days, sailors engage in various discussions concerning Billy's fate and the mysterious circumstances of his expiration. On its return voyage, the *Bellipotent* falls in with a French warship, the *Athée*, or *Atheist*. Captain Vere, wounded in the skirmish, eventually dies in a Gibraltar hospital, uttering as his last words, "Billy Budd, Billy Budd."

Finally, the legend of Billy Budd becomes recorded and institutionalized in naval circles. A newspaper reports the incident from afar, implicating Billy Budd as the villainous assailant of an innocent Claggart. The sailors themselves, however, begin to revere Billy's growing legend, treating the spar from his gallows as a holy object, and composing laudatory verse in his memory.

Glossary:

Man-of-war : A powerful naval warship.

Aldebaran : A bright star; used metaphorically for someone standing out among others.

Vainglorious : Proud or boastful.

Regality : Royal quality or dignity.

Homage : Respect or honour shown publicly.

Symmetric : Well-balanced and proportionate in form.

Barbaric : Primitive or uncivilized in a vivid, natural way.

Evinced : Showed or demonstrated clearly.

Dandified : Overly concerned with appearance; showy.

Prowess : Skill or bravery, especially in battle.

Foretopman : A sailor stationed in the upper part of the ship's foremast.

Impressed : Forcibly taken into naval service.

Gangway : A passage or entrance on a ship.

Acquiescence : Acceptance without protest.

Corpulent : Fat or bulky.

Disquietude : Anxiety or uneasiness.

Spirit-locker : A cupboard on a ship where liquor is kept.

Grog : A mixture of rum and water drunk by sailors.

Dismally : Sadly or gloomily.

Celerity : Swiftly or speed.

Cutter : A small boat carried on a larger ship.

Quarterdeck : The upper deck of a ship, reserved for officers.

Vicissitude : A change or variation in circumstances.

Cynosure : A person who attracts attention or admiration.

Rectitude : Moral integrity or righteousness.

Foundling : An abandoned child found and cared for by others.

By-blow : An illegitimate child (born out of wedlock).

Obliquities : Deviations from moral behaviour.

Comprehension:

I. Answer the following questions in about a page each:

1. What role does the Dansker play in guiding or warning Billy Budd?
2. Explain the reasons behind John Claggart's hatred toward Billy Budd.
3. Critically analyze the character of John Claggart.
4. Discuss the significance of Billy Budd's last words, "God bless Captain Vere"!

II. Answer the following questions in about two pages each:

1. Analyze the character of Billy Budd and explain why he is called the “Handsome Sailor”.
2. Discuss the symbolic meaning of Billy Budd’s final words, “God bless Captain Vere”.
3. Analyze the theme of law versus conscience as portrayed in Billy Budd, Sailor.
4. What message does Melville convey about human nature and moral responsibility through the death of Billy Budd?
5. Explain the circumstances leading to Billy Budd’s impressment from the Rights-of-Man to the H.M.S. Bellipotent.

Suggested Reading:

- *Moby-Dick* by Herman Melville
- *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* by Samuel Taylor Coleridge
- *The Tempest* by William Shakespeare

2. Friends

Grace Paley

Pre-Reading:

- What friendship means to you and how friends support each other through life's ups and downs?
- How do people's interpretations of events affect relationships?

About The Author:



Grace Paley (1922–2007) was a renowned American short story writer, poet, teacher, and political activist. Born in the Bronx to Jewish Ukrainian immigrant parents, she grew up immersed in the cultural and social experiences of working-class New Yorkers. Her works often capture the everyday lives, conflicts, and resilience of ordinary people, particularly women.

Paley was known for her realistic and poignant portrayals of relationships, friendship, and social issues. Over her literary career, she published acclaimed collections of short stories, including "The Little Disturbances of Man" (1959), "Enormous Changes at the Last Minute" (1974), and "Later the Same Day" (1985). Her stories were finalists for major literary awards like the Pulitzer Prize and the National Book Award.

In addition to writing, Paley was a dedicated teacher at institutions such as Sarah Lawrence College and Columbia University. She was also a committed activist, opposing war, advocating for women's rights, and promoting peace and social justice throughout her life.

Her writing style is noted for its sharp dialogue, humour, and compassionate insight into human nature, often reflecting her own experiences and political commitments.

About the Text:

"Friends" by Grace Paley is a poignant short story about aging, memory, and enduring female friendship, which centers on three middle-aged women Faith, Ann, and Susan, who visit their friend Selena, who is dying of cancer, in New York. Their reunion prompts reflections on their shared past, the loss of children to war, drugs, and accidents, and the changing dynamics of friendship and motherhood as they age. Through their conversations, the story delves into themes of grief, memory, and resilience, highlighting the everyday struggles of women and the powerful bonds formed through shared adversity.

After visiting Selena, the women realize that this may be their last meeting. The narrative shifts between their memories and present experiences, as each woman contemplates her own family tragedies and the impact of loss on their relationships. The friends support each other emotionally, yet the story honestly depicts misunderstandings and the bittersweet nature of enduring attachments. Ultimately, "Friends" ends with the women leaving Selena behind and reflecting on how their friendships have provided comfort, even in the face of overwhelming challenges

To put us at our ease, to quiet our hearts as she lay dying, our dear friend Selena said, Life, after all, has not been an unrelieved horror—you know, I *did* have many wonderful years with her.

She pointed to a child who leaned out of a portrait on the wall—long brown hair, white pinafore, head and shoulders forward.

Eagerness, said Susan. Ann closed her eyes.

On the same wall three little girls were photographed in a schoolyard. They were in furious discussion; they were holding hands. Right in the middle of the coffee table, framed, in autumn colours, a handsome young woman of eighteen sat on an enormous horse—aloof, disinterested, a rider. One night this young woman, Selena's child, was found in a rooming house in a distant city, dead. The police called. They said, do you have a daughter named Abby?

And with *him*, too, our friend Selena said. We had good times, Max and I. You know that.

There were no photographs of *him*. He was married to another woman and had a new, stalwart girl of about six, to whom no harm would ever come, her mother believed.

Our dear Selena had gotten out of bed. Heavily but with a comic dance, she soft-shoed to the bathroom, singing “Those were the days, my friend . . .”

Later that evening, Ann, Susan, and I were enduring our five-hour train ride to home. After one hour of silence and one hour of coffee and the sandwiches Selena had given us (she actually stood, leaned her big soft excavated body against the kitchen table to make those sandwiches), Ann said, well, we’ll never see *her* again.

Who says? Anyway, listen, said Susan. Think of it. Abby isn’t the only kid who died. What about that great guy, remember Bill Dalrymple—he was a non-cooperator or a deserter? And Bob Simon. They were killed in automobile accidents. Matthew, Jeannie, Mike. Remember Al Lurie—he was murdered on Sixth Street—and that little kid Brenda, who O.D.’d on your roof, Ann? The tendency, I suppose, is to forget. You people don’t remember them.

What do you mean, “you people”? Ann asked. You’re talking to *us*.

I began to apologize for not knowing them all. Most of them were older than my kids, I said.

Of course, the child Abby was exactly in my time of knowing and in all my places of paying attention—the park, the school, our street. But oh! It’s true! Selena’s Abby was not the only one of that beloved generation of our children murdered by cars, lost to war, to drugs, to madness.

Selena’s main problem, Ann said—you know, she didn’t tell the truth.

What?

A few hot human truthful words are powerful enough, Ann thinks, to steam all God’s chemical mistakes and society’s slimy lies out of her life. We all believe in that power, my friends and I, but sometimes . . . the heat.

Anyway, I always thought Selena had told us a lot. For instance, we knew she was an orphan. There were six, seven other children. She was the youngest. She was forty-two

years old before someone informed her that her mother had *not* died in child birthing her. It was some terrible sickness. And she had lived close to her mother's body—at her breast, in fact—until she was eight months old. Whew! said Selena. What a relief! I'd always felt I was the one who'd killed her.

Your family stinks, we told her. They really held you up for grief.

Oh, people, she said, Forget it. They did a lot of nice things for me, too. Me and Abby. Forget it, who has the time?

That's what I mean, said Ann. Selena should have gone after them with an axe.

More information: Selena's two sisters brought her to a Home. They were ashamed that at sixteen and nineteen they could not take care of her. They kept hugging her. They were sure she'd cry. They took her to her room—not a room, a dormitory with about eight beds. This is your bed, Lena. This is your table for your things. This little drawer is for your toothbrush. All for me? she asked. No one else can use it? Only me. That's all? Artie can't come? Franky can't come? Right?

Believe me, Selena said, those were happy days at Home.

Facts, said Ann, just facts. Not necessarily the *truth*.

I don't think it's right to complain about the character of the dying or start hustling all their motives into the spotlight like that. Isn't it amazing enough, the bravery of that private inclusive intentional community?

It wouldn't help not to be brave, said Selena. You'll see.

She wanted to get back to bed. Susan moved to help her.

Thanks, our Selena said, leaning on another person for the first time in her entire life. The trouble is, when I stand, it hurts me here all down my back. Nothing they can do about it. All the chemotherapy. No more chemistry left in me to therapist. Ha! Did you know before I came to New York and met you I used to work in that hospital? I was supervisor in gynaecology. Nursing. They were my friends, the doctors. They weren't so snotty then. David Clark, big surgeon. He couldn't look at me last week. He kept saying, Lena . . . Lena . . . Like that. We were in North Africa the same year—'44, I think. I told him, Davy, I've been

around a long enough time. I haven't missed too much. He knows it. But I didn't want to make him look at me. Ugh, my damn feet are a pain in the neck.

Recent research, said Susan, tells us that it's the neck that's a pain in the feet.

Always something new, said Selena, our dear friend.

On the way back to the bed, she stopped at her desk. There were about twenty snapshots scattered across it—the baby, the child, the young woman. Here, she said to me, take this one. It's a shot of Abby and your Richard in front of the school—third grade? What a day! The show those kids put on! What a bunch of kids! What's Richard doing now?

Oh, who knows? Horsing around someplace. Spain. These days, it's Spain. Who knows where he is? They're all the same.

Why did I say that? I knew exactly where he was. He writes. In fact, he found a broken phone and was able to call every day for a week—mostly to give orders to his brother but also to say, Are you O.K., Ma? How's your new boyfriend, did he smile yet?

The kids, they're all the same, I said.

It was only politeness, I think, not to pour my boy's light, noisy face into that dark afternoon. Richard used to say in his early mean teens, you'd sell us down the river to keep Selena happy and innocent. It's true. Whenever Selena would say, I don't know, Abby has some peculiar friends, I'd answer for stupid comfort, you should see Richard's.

Still, he's in Spain, Selena said. At least you know that. It's probably interesting. He'll learn a lot. Richard is a wonderful boy, Faith. He acts like a wise guy but he's not. You know the night Abby died, when the police called me and told me? That was my first night's sleep in two years. I *knew* where she was.

Selena said this very matter-of-factly—just offering a few informative sentences.

But Ann, listening, said, Oh!—she called out to us all, Oh!—and began to sob. Her straightforwardness had become an arrow and gone right into her own heart.

Then a deep tear-drying breath: I want a picture, too, she said.

Yes. Yes, wait, I have one here someplace. Abby and Judy and that Spanish kid Victor. Where is it? Ah. Here!

Three nine-year-old children sat high on that long-armed sycamore in the park, dangling their legs on someone's patient head—smooth dark hair, parted in the middle. Was that head Kitty's?

Our dear friend laughed. Another great day, she said. Wasn't it? I remember you two sizing up the men. I *had* one at the time—I thought. Some joke. Here, take it. I have two copies. But you ought to get it enlarged. When this you see, remember me. Ha-ha. Well, girls—excuse me, I mean ladies—it's time for me to rest.

She took Susan's arm and continued that awful walk to her bed.

We didn't move. We had a long journey ahead of us and had expected a little more comforting before we set off.

No, she said. You'll only miss the express. I'm not in much pain. I've got lots of painkiller. See?

The tabletop was full of little bottles.

I just want to lie down and think of Abby.

It was true, the local could cost us an extra two hours at least. I looked at Ann. It had been hard for her to come at all. Still, we couldn't move. We stood there before Selena in a row. Three old friends. Selena pressed her lips together, ordered her eyes into cold distance.

I know that face. Once, years ago, when the children were children, it had been placed modestly in front of J. Hoffner, the principal of the elementary school.

He'd said, No! Without training you cannot tutor these kids. There are real problems. You have to know *how to teach*.

Our P.-T.A. had decided to offer some one-to-one tutorial help for the Spanish kids, who were stuck in crowded classrooms with exhausted teachers among little middle-class achievers. He had said, in a written communication to show seriousness and then in personal confrontation to *prove* seriousness, that he could not allow it. And the board of ed itself had said no. (All this no-ness was to lead to some terrible events in the schools and neighbourhoods of our poor yes-requiring city.) But most of the women in our P.-T.A. were independent—by necessity and disposition. We were, in fact, the soft-speaking tough souls of anarchy.

I had Fridays off that year. At about 11 A.M. I'd bypass the principal's office and run up to the fourth floor. I'd take Robert Figueroa to the end of the hall, and we'd work away at storytelling for about twenty minutes. Then we would write the beautiful letters of the alphabet invented by smart foreigners long ago to fool time and distance.

That day, Selena and her stubborn face remained in the office for at least two hours. Finally, Mr. Hoffner, besieged, said that because she was a nurse, she would be allowed to help out by taking the littlest children to the modern difficult toilet. Some of them, he said, had just come from the barbarous hills beyond Maricao. Selena said O.K., she'd do that. In the toilet she taught the little girls which way to wipe, as she had taught her own little girl a couple of years earlier. At three o'clock she brought them home for cookies and milk. The children of that year ate cookies in her kitchen until the end of the sixth grade.

Now, what did we learn in that year of my Friday afternoons off? The following: Though the world cannot be changed by talking to one child at a time, it may at least be known.

Anyway, Selena placed into our eyes for long remembrance that useful stubborn face. She said, No. Listen to me, you people. Please. I don't have lots of time. What I want . . . I want to lie down and think about Abby. Nothing special. Just think about her, you know.

In the train Susan fell asleep immediately. She woke up from time to time, because the speed of the new wheels and the resistance of the old track gave us some terrible jolts. Once, she opened her eyes wide and said, You know, Ann's right. You don't get sick like that for nothing. I mean, she didn't even mention him.

Why should she? She hasn't even seen him, I said. Susan, you still have him-itis, the dread disease of females.

Yeah? And you don't? Anyway, he *was* around quite a bit. He was there every day, nearly, when the kid died.

Abby. I didn't like to hear "the kid." I wanted to say "Abby" the way I've said "Selena"—so those names can take thickness and strength and fall back into the world with their weight.

Abby, you know, was a wonderful child. She was in Richard's classes every class till high school. Good-hearted little girl from the beginning, noticeably kind—for a kid, I mean. Smart.

That's true, said Ann, very kind. She'd give away Selena's last shirt. Oh, yes, they were all wonderful little girls and wonderful little boys.

Chrissy *is* wonderful, Susan said.

She *is*, I said.

Middle kids aren't supposed to be, but she is. She put herself through college—I didn't have a cent—and now she has this fellowship. And, you know, she never did take any crap from boys. She's something.

Ann went swaying up the aisle to the bathroom. First she said, Oh, all of them—just wonderful.

I loved Selena, Susan said, but she never talked to me enough. Maybe she talked to you women more, about things. Men.

Then Susan fell asleep.

Ann sat down opposite me. She looked straight into my eyes with a narrow squint. It often connotes accusation.

Be careful—you're wrecking your laugh lines, I said.

Screw you, she said. You're kidding around. Do you realize I don't know where Mickey is? You know, you've been lucky. You always have been. Since you were a little kid. Papa and Mama's darling.

As is usual in conversations, I said a couple of things out loud and kept a few structured remarks for interior mulling and righteousness. I thought: She's never even met my folks. I thought: What a rotten thing to say. Luck— isn't it something like an insult?

I said, Annie, I'm only forty-eight. There's lots of time for me to be totally wrecked—if I live, I mean.

Then I tried to knock wood, but we were sitting in plush and leaning on plastic. Wood! I shouted. Please, some wood! Anybody here have a matchstick?

Oh, shut up, she said. Anyway, death doesn't count.

I tried to think of a couple of sorrows as irreversible as death. But truthfully nothing in my life can compare to hers: a son, a boy of fifteen, who disappears before your very eyes

into a darkness or a light behind his own, from which neither hugging nor hitting can bring him. If you shout, Come back, come back, he won't come. Mickey, Mickey, Mickey, we once screamed, as though he were twenty miles away instead of right in front of us in a kitchen chair; but he refused to return. And when he did, twelve hours later, he left immediately for California.

Well, some bad things have happened in my life, I said.

What? You were born a woman? Is that it?

She was, of course, mocking me this time, referring to an old discussion about feminism and Judaism. Actually, on the prism of isms, both of those do have to be looked at together once in a while.

Well, I said, my mother died a couple of years ago and I still feel it. I think *Ma* sometimes and I lose my breath. I miss her. You understand that. Your mother's seventy-six. You have to admit it's nice still having her.

She's very sick, Ann said. Half the time she's out of it.

I decided not to describe my mother's death. I could have done so and made Ann even more miserable. But I thought I'd save that for her next attack on me. These constrictions of her spirit were coming closer and closer together. Probably a great enmity was about to be born.

Susan's eyes opened. The death or dying of someone near or dear often makes people irritable, she stated. (She's been taking a course in relationships *and* interrelationships.) The real name of my seminar is Skills: Personal Friendship and Community. It's a very good course despite your snide remarks.

While we talked, a number of cities passed us, going in the opposite direction. I had tried to look at New London through the dusk of the windows. Now I was missing New Haven. The conductor explained, smiling: Lady, if the windows were clean, half of you'd be dead. The tracks are lined with sharpshooters.

Do you believe that? I hate people to talk that way.

He may be exaggerating, Susan said, but don't wash the window.

A man leaned across the aisle. Ladies, he said, I do believe it. According to what I hear of this part of the country, it doesn't seem unplausible.

Susan turned to see if he was worth engaging in political dialogue.

You've forgotten Selena already, Ann said. All of us have. Then you'll make this nice memorial service for her and everyone will stand up and say a few words and then we'll forget her again—for good. What'll you say at the memorial, Faith?

It's not right to talk like that. She's not dead yet, Annie.

Yes, she is, said Ann.

We discovered the next day that give or take an hour or two, Ann had been correct. It was a combination—David Clark, surgeon, said—of being sick unto real death and having a tabletop full of little bottles.

Now, why are you taking all those hormones? Susan had asked Selena a couple of years earlier. They were visiting New Orleans. It was Mardi Gras.

Oh, they're mostly vitamins, Selena said. Besides, I want to be young and beautiful. She made a joking pirouette.

Susan said, That's absolutely ridiculous.

But Susan's seven or eight years younger than Selena. What did she know? Because: People *do* want to be young and beautiful. When they meet in the street, male or female, if they're getting older, they look at each other's faces a little ashamed. It's clear they want to say, excuse me, I didn't mean to draw attention to mortality and gravity all at once. I didn't want to remind you, my dear friend, of our coming eviction, first from liveliness, then from life. To which, most of the time, the friend's eyes will courteously reply, My dear, it's nothing at all. I hardly noticed.

Luckily, I learned recently how to get out of that deep well of melancholy. Anyone can do it. You grab at roots of the littlest future, sometimes just stubs of conversation. Though some believe you miss a great deal of depth by not sinking down down down.

Susan, I asked, you still seeing Ed Flores?

Went back to his wife.

Lucky, she didn't kill you, said Ann. I'd never fool around with a Spanish guy. They all have tough ladies back in the barrio.

No, said Susan, she's unusual. I met her at a meeting. We had an amazing talk. Luisa is a very fine woman. She's one of the office-worker organizers I told you about. She only needs him two more years, she says. Because the kids—they're girls—need to be watched a little in their neighbourhood. The neighbourhood is definitely not good. He's a good father but not such a great husband.

I'd call that a word to the wise.

Well, you know me—I don't want a husband. I like a male person around. I hate to do without. Anyway, listen to this. She, Luisa, whispers in my ear the other day, she whispers, Suzie, in two years you still want him, I promise you, you got him. Really, I may still want him then. He's only about forty-five now. Still got a lot of spunk. I'll have my degree in two years. Chrissy will be out of the house.

Two years! In two years we'll all be dead, said Ann.

I know she didn't mean all of us. She meant Mickey. That boy of hers would surely be killed in one of the drugstores or whorehouses of Chicago, New Orleans, San Francisco. I'm in a big beautiful city, he said when he called last month. Makes New York look like a garbage tank.

Mickey! Where?

Ha-ha, he said and hung up.

Soon he'd be picked up for vagrancy, dealing, small thievery, or simply screaming dirty words at night under a citizen's window. Then Ann would fly to the town or not fly to the town to disentangle him, depending on a confluence of financial reality and psychiatric advice.

How *is* Mickey? Selena had said. In fact, that was her first sentence when we came, solemn and embarrassed, into her sunny front room that was full of the light and shadow of windy courtyard trees. We said, each in her own way, how are you feeling, Selena? She said, O.K., first things first. Let's talk about important things. How's Richard? How's Tonto? How's John? How's Chrissy? How's Judy? How's Mickey?

I don't want to talk about Mickey, said Ann.

Oh, let's talk about him, talk about him, Selena said, taking Ann's hand. Let's all think before it's too late. How did it start? Oh, for God's sake talk about him.

Susan and I were smart enough to keep our mouths shut.

Nobody knows, nobody knows anything. Why? Where? Everybody has an idea, theories, and writes articles. Nobody knows.

Ann said this sternly. She didn't whine. She wouldn't lean too far into Selena's softness, but listening to Selena speak Mickey's name, she could sit in her chair more easily. I watched. It was interesting. Ann breathed deeply in and out the way we've learned in our Thursday-night yoga class. She was able to rest her body a little bit.

We were riding the rails of the trough called Park Avenue-in-the-Bronx. Susan had turned from us to talk to the man across the aisle. She was explaining that the war in Vietnam was not yet over and would not be, as far as she was concerned, until we repaired the dikes we'd bombed and paid for some of the hopeless ecological damage. He didn't see it that way. Fifty thousand American lives, our own boys—we'd paid, he said. He asked us if we agreed with Susan. Every word, we said.

You don't look like hippies. He laughed. Then his face changed. As the resident face-reader, I decided he was thinking: Adventure. He may have hit a mother lode of late counterculture in three opinionated left-wing ladies. That was the nice part of his face. The other part was the sly out-of-town-husband-in-New-York look.

I'd like to see you again, he said to Susan.

Oh? Well, come to dinner day after tomorrow. Only two of my kids will be home. You ought to have at least one decent meal in New York.

Kids? His face thought it over. Thanks. Sure, he said. I'll come.

Ann muttered, She's impossible. She did it again.

Oh, Susan's O.K., I said. She's just right in there. Isn't that good?

This is a long ride, said Ann.

Then we were in the darkness that precedes Grand Central.

We're irritable, Susan explained to her new pal. We're angry with our friend Selena for dying. The reason is, we want her to be present when we're dying. We all require a mother or mother-surrogate to fix our pillows on that final occasion, and we were counting on her to be that person.

I know just what you mean, he said. You'd like to have someone around. A little fuss, maybe.

Something like that. Right, Faith?

It always takes me a minute to slide under the style of her public-address system. I agreed. Yes.

The train stopped hard, in a grinding agony of opposing technologies.

Right. Wrong. Who cares? Ann said. She didn't have to die. She really wrecked everything.

Oh, Annie, I said.

Shut up, will you? Both of you, said Ann, nearly breaking our knees as she jammed past us and out of the train.

Then Susan, like a New York hostess, began to tell that man all our private troubles—the mistake of the World Trade Centre, Westway, the decay of the South Bronx, the rage in Williamsburg. She rose with him on the escalator, gabbing into evening friendship and a happy night.

At home Anthony, my youngest son, said, Hello, you just missed Richard. He's in Paris now. He had to call collect.

Collect? From Paris?

He saw my sad face and made one of the herb teas used by his peer group to calm their overwrought natures. He does want to improve my pretty good health and spirits. His friends have a book that says a person should, if properly nutritioned, live forever. He wants me to give it a try. He also believes that the human race, its brains and good looks, will end in his time.

At about eleven-thirty he went out to live the pleasures of his eighteen-year-old nighttime life.

At 3 A.M. he found me washing the floors and making little apartment repairs.

More tea, Mom? he asked. He sat down to keep me company. O.K., Faith. I know you feel terrible. But how come Selena never realized about Abby?

Anthony, what the hell do I realize about you?

Come on, you had to be blind. I was just a little kid, and *I* saw. Honest to God, Ma.

Listen, Tonto. Basically, Abby was O.K. She was. You don't know yet what their times can do to a person.

Here she goes with her goody-goodies—everything is so groovy wonderful far-out terrific. Next thing, you'll say people are darling and the world is *so* nice and round that Union Carbide will never blow it up.

I have never said anything as hopeful as that. And why to all our knowledge of that sad day did Tonto at 3 A.M. have to add the fact of the world?

The next night Max called from North Carolina. How's Selena? I'm flying up, he said. I have one early-morning appointment. Then I'm cancelling everything.

At 7 A.M. Annie called. I had barely brushed my morning teeth. It was hard, she said. The whole damn thing. I don't mean Selena. All of us. In the train. None of you seemed real to me.

Real? Reality, huh? Listen, how about coming over for breakfast—I don't have to get going until after nine? I have this neat sourdough rye?

No, she said. Oh Christ, no. No!

I remember Ann's eyes and the hat she wore the day we first looked at each other. Our babies had just stepped howling out of the sandbox on their new walking legs. We picked them up. Over their sandy heads we smiled. I think a bond was sealed then, at least as useful as the vow we'd all sworn with husbands to whom we're no longer married. Hindsight, usually looked down upon, is probably as valuable as foresight, since it does include a few facts.

Meanwhile, Anthony's world—poor, dense, defenceless thing—rolls round and round. Living and dying are fastened to its surface and stuffed into its softer parts.

He was right to call my attention to its suffering and danger. He was right to harass my responsible nature. But I was right to invent for my friends and our children a report on these private deaths and the condition of our lifelong attachment.

Glossary:

Cancer	:	A serious illness affecting one of the main characters, Selena, serving as a catalyst for the friends' reunion.
Orphan	:	Selena is described as an orphan, meaning she lost her parents early in life and grew up without maternal support
Rooming house	:	A type of inexpensive shared housing; Selena's daughter, Abby, died in such a place.
Narrator	:	The story is told primarily from Faith's perspective, though it features collective voices of the friends.
Vietnam War	:	: Referenced in the friends' conversation, symbolizes loss and trauma experienced by families during that period.
Resilience	:	The ability to recover from difficult experiences, seen through how the characters manage loss and grief.
Constrict	:	Used in the story to describe the tightening of a character's spirit—a metaphor for emotional hardship or stress.
Mother-figure	:	: The role Selena plays for her friends, sought for comfort and care in times of crisis.
Dialogue	:	: Paley's conversational writing style, using realistic speech to reveal character relationships and inner feelings.

Comprehension:

I. Answer the following questions in about a page each:

1. Describe the main theme of friendship as portrayed in Grace Paley's "Friends."
2. How do the women in the story cope with the loss of their children?
3. What role does conversation and memory play in shaping the relationships among the friends?

4. Explain the significance of Selena's character in the story.
5. Discuss how Grace Paley uses realism and dialogue to convey the complexities of human relationships in "Friends."

II. Answer the following questions in about two pages each:

1. Analyse how Grace Paley uses the characters of Faith, Ann, Susan, and Selena to explore themes of friendship, motherhood, and loss in the story.
2. Discuss the role of memory and conversation in shaping the relationships among the friends in "Friends" and how it contributes to the story's emotional depth.
3. Examine the significance of the setting and the socio-political backdrop (such as references to the Vietnam War) in the story. How do these elements influence the characters' perspectives and interactions?
4. Explore the narrative style of Paley in "Friends" — how does her use of dialogue and multiple viewpoints affect the reader's understanding of the characters and their struggles?

Suggested Reading/Extended Activity:

- "After the Race" by James Joyce (Dubliners)
- "Pretty Mouth and Green My Eyes" by J. D. Salinger
- "True Friendship" by John Cuddeback
- "The Death of a Friendship" by Rachael Smith
- "With Friends Like These" (Jewish Book Council)
- Paula by Sally Berneathy

3. MY VISION FOR INDIA

Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

Pre- Reading :

- What qualities should a country have to be called *developed*?
- India will be a developed nation by 2040—agree or disagree?
- Citizens are more responsible than the government for change – Discuss.
- Science and technology are invaluable to a country's progress. Discuss.

About the Speaker:



Avul Pakir Jainulabdeen Abdul Kalam was born on 15 October 1931, to a Tamil Muslim family in the pilgrimage centre of Rameswaram on Pamban Island, then in the Madras Presidency and now in the State of Tamil Nadu. His father Jainulabdeen Marakayar was a boat owner and imam of a local mosque; his mother Ashiamma was a housewife. Kalam was the youngest of four brothers and one sister in his family. The family was poverty-stricken by the time Kalam was born. As a young boy, he had to sell newspapers to add to the family's meagre income. In his school years, Kalam had average grades but was described as a bright and hardworking student who had a strong desire to learn. He spent hours on his studies, especially mathematics and went on to study physics and aerospace engineering. He spent four decades as a scientist and science administrator, mainly at the Defence Research and Development Organization (DRDO) and Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and was intimately involved in India's civilian space programme and military missile development efforts. He thus came to be known as the Missile Man of India for his work on the development of ballistic missile and launch vehicle technology. He also played a pivotal organisational, technical, and political role in India's Pokhran-II nuclear tests in 1998, the first since the original nuclear test by India in 1974. Kalam was elected as the eleventh president of India in 2002 with the support of both the ruling Bhartiya Janata Party and the then-opposition Indian National Congress. Widely referred to as the "People's President", he returned to his civilian life of education, writing and public service after a single term.

Kalam received 7 honorary doctorates from 40 universities. The Government of India honoured him with the Padma Bhushan in 1981 and the Padma Vibhushan in 1990 for his work with ISRO and DRDO and his role as a scientific advisor to the Government. In 1997, Kalam received India's highest civilian honour, the Bharat Ratna, for his contribution to scientific research and the modernisation of defence technology in India. In 2013, he was the recipient of the Von Braun Award from the National Space Society "to recognise excellence in the management and leadership of a space-related project".

About the speech:

'**My Vision for India**' is one of Dr. A.P.J Abdul Kalam's most inspiring speeches delivered at the Indian Institute of Technology, Hyderabad, 2011. In it, he describes his three visions for India if it has to enter the comity of developed nations. Through this address, Dr. Kalam urges citizens to realise their duties and motivates them to build a stronger India.

SPEECH:

I have three visions for India. In 3000 years of our history people from all over the world have come and invaded us, captured our lands, conquered our minds. From Alexander onwards the Greeks, the Turks, the Moguls, the Portuguese, the British, the French, the Dutch, all of them came and looted us, took over what was ours. Yet we have not done this to any other nation. We have not conquered anyone. We have not grabbed their land, their culture and their history and tried to enforce our way of life on them. Why? Because we respect the freedom of others. That is why my FIRST VISION is that of FREEDOM. I believe that India got its first vision of this in 1857, when we started the war of Independence. It is this freedom that we must protect and nurture and build on. If we are not free, no one will respect us.

We have 10 percent growth rate in most areas. Our poverty levels are falling. Our achievements are being globally recognised today. Yet we lack the self-confidence to see ourselves as a developed nation, self-reliant and self-assured. Isn't this incorrect? MY SECOND VISION for India is DEVELOPMENT. For fifty years we have been a developing nation. It is time we see ourselves as a developed nation. We are among top five nations in the world in terms of GDP.

I have a THIRD VISION. India must stand up to the world. Because I believe that unless India stands up to the world, no one will respect us. Only strength respects strength. We must be strong not only as a military power but also as an economic power. Both must go hand-in-hand. My good fortune was to have worked with three great minds. Dr. Vikram Sarabhai, of the Dept. of Space, Professor Satish Dhawan, who succeeded him and Dr. Brahm Prakash, father of nuclear material. I was lucky to have worked with all three of them closely and consider this the great opportunity of my life.

I was in Hyderabad giving this lecture when a 14 year-old girl asked me for my autograph. I asked her what her goal in life is. She replied: I want to live in a developed India. For her, you and I will have to build this developed India. You must proclaim India is not an underdeveloped nation; it is a highly developed nation.

You say that our government is inefficient. You say that our laws are too old. You say that the municipality does not pick up the garbage. You say that the phones don't work, the railways are a joke, the airline is the worst in the world, and mails never reach their destination. You say that our country has been fed to the dogs and is the absolute pits. You say, say and say. What do you do about it?

Dear Indians, I am echoing J.F. Kennedy's words to his fellow Americans to relate to Indians

“ASK WHAT WE CAN DO FOR INDIA AND DO WHAT HAS TO BE DONE TO MAKE INDIA WHAT AMERICA AND OTHER WESTERN COUNTRIES ARE TODAY.”

Glossary:

Self-reliant : having confidence in and exercising one's own power or judgement.

ISRO : Indian Space Research Organisation

DRDO : Defence Research and Development Organisation

Comprehension

I. Answer the following questions

1. Write about the three main visions of India that Dr. A. P. J. Abdul Kalam talks about in his speech.
2. What does Kalam mean by “only strength respects strength”?
3. Summarise the central message that Dr. Kalam conveys through his speech.
4. Discuss why Kalam believes India should see itself as a *developed* nation, not just a developing one.
5. Explain how Dr. A. P. J. Abdul Kalam describes India’s economic progress, using examples from his speech.
6. Discuss the lessons or values from the speech that the younger generation can adopt to shape a better future for India.
7. How can India retain respect as per the inputs highlighted by the speaker?

4. Refugee Blues

W. H. Auden

Pre- Reading:

- Discuss what it means to be a “refugee”. *Who are refugees, and why do people become refugees? Can you think of examples from history or the present?*
- Explore the idea of “home”. *What makes a place feel like home? How might a person feel if they lose their home and country?*
- Discuss how governments and societies treat people who are outsiders or immigrants. *Do you think all people are treated equally when they seek safety in a new country? Why or why not?*

About The Author:



Wystan Hugh Auden (1907–1973) was an English-born poet, playwright, and essayist, widely regarded as one of the greatest poets of the 20th century. He was known for his sharp intellect, moral insight, and mastery of language. Auden’s poetry often deals with themes of love, politics, war, faith, and the struggles of modern life.

He studied at Oxford University and became associated with other famous writers such as Christopher Isherwood and Stephen Spender. Auden’s early works reflected the political tensions of the 1930s, especially the rise of fascism and the suffering of ordinary people.

In 1939, he moved to the United States, where he continued writing and teaching. Some of his most famous poems include “*Funeral Blues*,” “*September 1, 1939*,” “*The Unknown Citizen*,” and “*Refugee Blues*.”

Auden’s style combines emotional depth with precise form and rhythm. His works remind readers of the importance of compassion, moral responsibility, and humanity in times of crisis.

About the text:

"Refugee Blues" is a powerful and emotional poem written by W. H. Auden in 1939, just before the outbreak of the Second World War. It gives voice to the pain and helplessness of Jewish refugees who fled Nazi Germany but were denied asylum in other countries. The poem captures the deep sorrow of people who have lost their homeland, identity, and safety, and who find "no place" in a world full of fear and prejudice. Written in the rhythm of the blues, a musical form traditionally used to express sadness and suffering, the poem combines simple language with haunting repetition. Each stanza ends with the refrain "my dear," giving the poem a deeply personal and emotional tone. Through vivid imagery such as "old passports," "birds in the trees," and "fish swimming as if they were free" Auden contrasts the cruelty of human society with the freedom of nature. The poem also criticizes the indifference of governments and officials who value documents more than human lives. Ultimately, *"Refugee Blues"* is not just about one group of people; it speaks universally about the pain of exile, loss, and humanity's failure to show compassion to those in need.

Say this city has ten million souls,
Some are living in mansions, some are living in holes:
Yet there's no place for us, my dear, yet there's no place for us.

Once we had a country and we thought it fair,
Look in the atlas and you'll find it there:
We cannot go there now, my dear, we cannot go there now.

In the village churchyard there grows an old yew,
Every spring it blossoms anew:
Old passports can't do that, my dear, old passports can't do that.

The consul banged the table and said,
"If you've got no passport you're officially dead":
But we are still alive, my dear, but we are still alive.

Went to a committee; they offered me a chair;
Asked me politely to return next year:
But where shall we go to-day, my dear, but where shall we go to-day?

Came to a public meeting; the speaker got up and said;
"If we let them in, they will steal our daily bread":
He was talking of you and me, my dear, he was talking of you and me.

Thought I heard the thunder rumbling in the sky;
It was Hitler over Europe, saying, "They must die":
O we were in his mind, my dear, O we were in his mind.

Saw a poodle in a jacket fastened with a pin,
Saw a door opened and a cat let in:
But they weren't German Jews, my dear, but they weren't German Jews.

Went down the harbour and stood upon the quay,
Saw the fish swimming as if they were free:
Only ten feet away, my dear, only ten feet away.

Walked through a wood, saw the birds in the trees;
They had no politicians and sang at their ease:
They weren't the human race, my dear, they weren't the human race.

Dreamed I saw a building with a thousand floors,
A thousand windows and a thousand doors:
Not one of them was ours, my dear, not one of them was ours.

Stood on a great plain in the falling snow;
Ten thousand soldiers marched to and fro:
Looking for you and me, my dear, looking for you and me.

Glossary:

Souls : refers to human beings; emphasizes the city's vast population and shared humanity.

Mansions : large, luxurious houses representing wealth and privilege.

Holes : symbolizes poverty and poor living conditions, contrasting with the rich who live in mansions.

Atlas : a book of maps; represents the lost homeland that now exists only as a name on a map.

Village churchyard: a rural cemetery, symbolizing belonging and rootedness which the refugees have lost.

Yew : an evergreen tree often found in graveyards; symbolizes life, death, and renewal—something denied to the refugees.

Old passports: represents identity, nationality, and belonging; “old” suggests uselessness and rejection.

Consul : government official representing a country abroad; symbolizes authority and bureaucracy.

Committee : an official body or organization; represents delay and indifference toward refugees.

Public meeting: a gathering of citizens; reflects how societies discuss refugees as a “problem” rather than as people.

Steal our daily bread: expression of prejudice; implies refugees are accused of taking locals' jobs or food.

Thunder rumbling in the sky: symbolic of impending war or destruction; may also suggest divine anger or fate.

Hitler over Europe: refers to Adolf Hitler's domination of Europe and persecution of Jews during World War II.

German Jews: the refugees described in the poem; Jewish people fleeing Nazi persecution.

Quay: a platform beside the sea or river for ships to dock; symbolizes departure and unreachable freedom.

Fish swimming as if they were free: shows contrast between the freedom of animals and the captivity of refugees.

Politicians: represents those in power whose decisions affect others' lives, often without empathy.

A thousand floors / windows / doors: symbolizes the many opportunities in the modern world, none of which are open to refugees.

Great plain in the falling snow: suggests vast emptiness, loneliness, and the world's cold indifference.

Ten thousand soldiers: symbol of state power, violence, and persecution.

Looking for you and me: a haunting image showing that the refugees are hunted and have nowhere safe to go.

Comprehension:

I. Answer in about a page each:

1. Discuss how W. H. Auden portrays the theme of displacement and homelessness in "*Refugee Blues*."
2. How does Auden use imagery and symbolism to express the suffering of refugees?
3. What is the significance of the repeated phrase "my dear" in the poem?
4. Analyse the contrast between the natural world and human society as depicted in the poem.
5. Explain how "*Refugee Blues*" reflects the political and historical context of the 1930s and 1940s.
6. What role does repetition play in shaping the tone and rhythm of "*Refugee Blues*"?
7. Examine how Auden evokes empathy and moral awareness in readers through the poem.

Suggested Reading:

- *The Unknown Citizen* by W. H. Auden
- *Do Not Go Gentle into That Good Night* by Dylan Thomas
- *Disabled* by Wilfred Owen
- *The Guest* by Albert Camus
- *The Refugees* by Pearl S. Buck
- *The Tell-Tale Heart* by Edgar Allan Poe

References:

- <https://allpoetry.com/refugee-blues>
- [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/W. H. Auden](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/W._H._Auden)
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5. INDIAN WEAVERS

Sarojini Naidu

Pre-Reading:

- What do you understand by the word weaving? Have you ever seen someone weaving cloth?
- Why do you think weaving is an important art or skill in India?
- Why do people wear different types or colours of clothes for different occasions?
- What meanings do you associate with colours like blue, green, purple, and white?

About the Poet:



Sarojini Naidu (1879-1949) was Born into Bengali family in Hyderabad and studied at the University of Madras. She later went on to study at King's College, London and Cambridge University. Naidu joined the Indian National Movement in the aftermath of the partition of Bengal in 1905 and was the first Indian woman to become the President of the Indian National Congress. She started writing at a very early age and

managed to impress the Nizam of Hyderabad with her play *Meher Munir*. Her first collection of poems titled *The Golden Threshold* was published in 1905. Naidu earned herself the sobriquet *Bharat Kokila* or *the Nightingale of India* owing to the lyrical and songlike quality of her poems.

Indian themes contemporary life and events along with great mountains, rivers, temples, and social milieu of India feature prominently in Naidu's poems and she is widely regarded as an invaluable contributor to the genre of Indian writing in English.

About the Poem:

In *Indian Weavers* Sarojini Naidu makes a reference to the traditional Indian practice of weaving and to its practitioners. The poem also makes use of symbolism and vivid imagery to comment on the important stages of human life and the passage of life itself.

Weavers, weaving at break of day,
Why do you weave a garment so gay? ...
Blue as the wing of a halcyon wild,
We weave the robes of a new-born child.

Weavers, weaving at fall of night,
Why do you weave a garment so bright? ...
Like the plumes of a peacock, purple and green,
We weave the marriage-veils of a queen.

Weavers, weaving solemn and still,
What do you weave in the moonlight chill? ...
White as a feather and white as a cloud,
We weave a dead man's funeral shroud.

Glossary:

weaver : a person who weaves fabric.
halcyon : a tropical Asian and African Kingfisher with brightly coloured feathers.
plumes : long soft feathers of a bird.
Marriage veil : the piece of fine material used by women to conceal the face on their wedding day.
solemn : formal and sincere.
shroud : a sheet used to wrap the dead for burial.

Comprehension:

I. Answer the following in about a page each:

1. How does the poet convey the passage of a day in the poem? What does this tell you about the lives and work of the Weavers?
2. Comment on the significance of the poet's use of colours in the poem.
3. How does the description of the garment change with the person or occasion it is meant for? why?
4. Elaborate on the poet's use of symbolism in the poem.
5. Explain the relationship between the three stanzas and the three stages of human life that the poet talks about.

Suggested Reading

1. **Palanquin Bearers** – Sarojini Naidu
2. **The Harvest Hymn** – Rabindranath Tagore
3. **A Workman's Prayer** – Nissim Ezekiel

UNIT – II
COMMUNICATION SKILL (LSRW Skills)

LISTENING AND SPEAKING SKILLS

Interview Skills

Objectives:

- To understand the meaning and nature of an interview as a structured, goal – oriented conversation between interviewer and interviewee.
- To develop key communication abilities such as clear speaking, active listening, appropriate body language and thinking on one's feet.

An **interview** is a formal and purposeful conversation between an interviewer and a candidate. Its main objective is to evaluate the candidate's knowledge, personality, communication skills, confidence, and suitability for a particular job or academic opportunity. An interview also helps the candidate understand the nature of the work and the expectations of the organization.



Types of Interviews

Interviews can be classified into several types based on the nature of interaction, the number of interviewers, and the purpose of evaluation. The most common types are discussed below.

1. Personal (One-to-One) Interview

This is the most common form of interview where a single interviewer interacts with a single candidate. The focus is on understanding the candidate's educational background, experience, personality, strengths, weaknesses, and suitability for the position. It allows a direct and comfortable conversation.

2. Panel Interview

In a panel interview, two or more interviewers question the candidate. Each interviewer may focus on a different aspect such as technical knowledge, attitude, or communication. The candidate is observed from multiple perspectives, which makes the evaluation more balanced and fairer.

3. Group Interview

In this type, several candidates are interviewed at the same time. They may be asked to discuss a topic, solve a problem collectively, or participate in an activity. The purpose is to

identify leadership qualities, communication skills, listening ability, cooperation, confidence, and how individuals behave in a group situation.

4. Telephonic Interview

A telephonic interview is usually conducted as an initial screening round to save time and resources. The interviewer assesses the candidate's voice clarity, confidence, basic knowledge, and interest. If the candidate performs well, they are usually called for a face-to-face or detailed interview.

5. Online / Video Interview

With the growth of digital technology, interviews are also conducted on video platforms like Zoom, Microsoft Teams, or Google Meet. This type of interview is useful when interviewer and candidate are in different locations. It evaluates communication skills, presentation, and technical readiness.

6. Technical Interview

A technical interview focuses on subject-related knowledge and problem-solving skills. It is common in fields like engineering, computer science, finance, and research. Candidates may be asked to explain concepts, solve problems, or demonstrate practical skills related to the job.

7. HR (Human Resource) Interview

The HR interview mainly evaluates personality, values, work behaviour, attitude, team spirit, adaptability, and motivation. The interviewer tries to understand whether the candidate will fit into the work environment and whether their character aligns with the organisation's culture.

Preparation Before the Interview

1. Research the Company

Know the company's products, values, history, and recent achievements.

2. Understand the Job Role

Read the job description carefully.

3. Prepare Your Resume

Make sure it is:

- Clear
- Updated
- Honest
- Neatly formatted

4. Practice Common Questions

- *Tell me about yourself.*
- *Why should we hire you?*
- *What are your strengths and weaknesses?*

5. Personal Grooming

- Wear clean, neat and formal clothes.
- Maintain good hygiene.

Proper preparation plays a major role in interview success. The candidate should research the company, understand its work culture, products or services, and recent achievements. The job description must be read carefully to know what skills are required. One must prepare a neat, well-structured, and honest resume. Practicing common interview questions like “Tell me about yourself,” “Why should we hire you?” and “What are your strengths and weaknesses?” helps in building clarity and confidence. Wearing neat, clean, and formal clothes and reaching the venue on time also create a positive impression.

Body language is a very important part of the interview. The candidate should greet the interviewer politely, sit with good posture, maintain natural eye contact, and avoid nervous gestures like shaking legs or fidgeting. A calm expression and a pleasant smile reflect confidence. Clear pronunciation, thoughtful responses, and respectful tone enhance communication.

Some tips on Body Language:

	Aspect	What to Do	What Not to Do
1	Posture	Sit straight with your back supported; keep a relaxed and confident posture.	Do not slouch, lean too far back, or sit on the edge of the chair nervously.
2	Eye Contact	Maintain steady and natural eye contact to show confidence and attentiveness.	Avoid staring continuously or looking down or away frequently.
3	Facial Expression	Keep a pleasant expression; smile gently and naturally when appropriate.	Do not frown, look bored, irritated, or overly serious.
4	Handshake <i>(if practiced)</i>	Offer a firm, confident handshake while making eye contact.	Avoid a very weak, sweaty, or excessively tight handshake.
5	Hand Gestures	Use controlled and meaningful hand gestures to support your speech.	Do not wave hands excessively, point fingers, or show restless movements.
6	Listening Skills	Nod occasionally and show interest while the interviewer speaks.	Do not interrupt or appear distracted or impatient.
7	Voice & Tone	Speak clearly, slowly, and confidently with a polite tone.	Avoid talking too fast, too softly, too loudly, or sounding rude.
8	Body Movements	Keep movements minimal and composed.	Do not shake legs, tap fingers, play with pen, or keep shifting in the seat.
9	Appearance & Grooming	Wear neat, clean, and formal clothes suitable for a professional setting.	Do not wear casual, untidy, flashy, or inappropriate clothing.

During the interview, answers should be honest, short, relevant, and positive. The candidate should listen carefully before answering and should not interrupt the interviewer. It is important to avoid exaggeration and not speak negatively about former employers, teachers, or institutions. Showing eagerness to learn, adaptability, and a positive attitude leaves a lasting impression.

To crack interview successfully:

1. Greet the interviewer politely.
2. Listen carefully before answering.
3. Speak clearly and confidently.
4. Keep answers **brief, relevant, and positive**.
5. Avoid criticising previous employers or teachers.
6. Show enthusiasm and willingness to learn.

Here are Some Sample Interview questions:

1. Tell us about yourself

This question appears to be an innocent question, but is well planned. This is an example of open ended question' where the respondents can choose or select aspects of their lives they want to talk about. It can also be noticed that questions like these cannot be answered with a simple 'yes' or 'no'. For example for a question like this, the interviewee could choose to talk about her/his family background (I come from a decent middle class partly orthodox and partly modern family. Both my parents are employed) or her/his education (I am a post graduate in Economics from Bangalore City University and specialized in mathematical economics. I have been a consistent performer / or her/his personality traits (I am an honest, open-minded person who values hard work. I am good team player and possess good communication skills.)

Give a self-introduction as a computer science fresher for the post of Software developer

Hello, my name is [Your Name], and I recently graduated with a Bachelor's degree in Computer Science. During my academic journey, I gained solid foundational knowledge in programming languages such as Java, Python, and C++, along with hands-on experience in data structures, algorithms, and software development projects. I am passionate about problem-solving and have worked on multiple projects involving web development, database management, and basic machine learning.

I am eager to apply my technical skills and enthusiasm to real-world challenges, and I am a quick learner who adapts well to new technologies and team

environments. I am excited about the opportunity to contribute to your company and continue growing as a software developer.

Thank you for considering my application.

These kinds of questions are generally asked at the beginning of the interview and are calculated to make the candidates comfortable (since they are talking about what they know well) and also to observe their communication skills.

Now, try to answer the following questions:

1. During your college years, which was your favourite subject and why?

2. What makes you think you are a good team player?

3. What are your strengths and weaknesses?

4. Which part of your course interested you the most?

5. Where were you educated?

This is an example of a 'close ended' question. Notice that this question does not give you much choice and forces you to answer it in one or two words.

After the interview, politely thanking the interviewer is a sign of good manners. Some candidates also send a short thank-you message or email, which shows professionalism. Overall, **confidence, communication skills, honesty, subject knowledge, and positive body language** are essential for interview success.

Qualities of a Good Interviewee:

- Confidence (not overconfidence)
- Good communication skills
- Respectful attitude
- Awareness and knowledge about the field
- Ability to stay calm under pressure

Therefore, interview skills are not only useful for securing a job but are also important for personal growth, professional development, and building strong human relations.

Group Discussion (GD)

Objectives:

- To train student in teamwork, critical thinking and respectful handling of diverse opinions.
- To exhibit cooperation and basic leadership within the group helping the discussion move logically toward shared outcome.

A Group Discussion (GD) is an oral activity in which a group of students gather to share and exchange ideas on a specific topic. It serves as a collaborative and interactive method of learning. The purpose is not competition, but the free exchange of thoughts, careful listening, and arriving at a shared understanding. Through this process, students learn to articulate their thoughts fluently, listen with empathy, and appreciate different viewpoints. It promotes meaningful communication rather than competitive debate.



Purpose:

Within the English Department, Group Discussions are conducted to help students develop fluency in spoken English and gain confidence in expressing their ideas. They also train students to listen attentively, respond constructively, and speak with courtesy. The activity encourages critical and creative thinking, builds team spirit, and fosters cooperation among learners. It is meant to enrich language skills and communication—not to provoke debate. Additionally, GDs nurture analytical and creative thinking by prompting students to view issues from multiple perspectives. They help learners to respect differences of opinion, to engage in polite disagreement when necessary, and to strengthen teamwork through cooperative participation. The ultimate aim is to enable students to use English effectively and naturally in academic, social, and professional situations.

Unlike debates, where participants argue for or against a motion, group discussions emphasize mutual learning and enrichment of ideas.

Features of a Group Discussion:

A typical group discussion usually consists of six to twelve students seated together in a circle or semi-circle to ensure open communication. A topic is given in advance or announced just

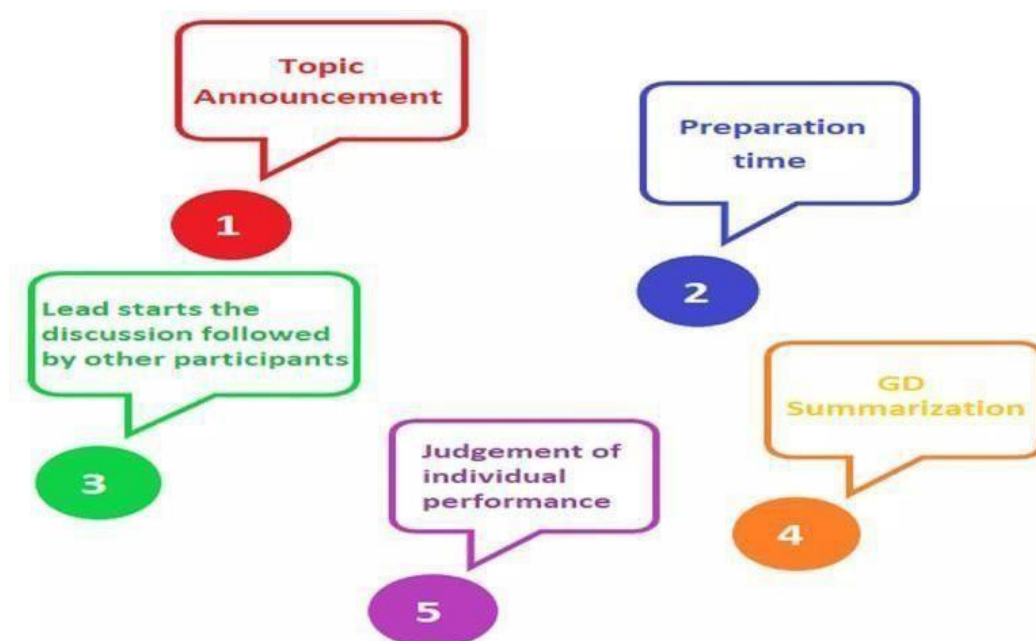
before the session. The subject may relate to social issues, literary themes, moral situations, or current events.

The discussion normally begins with an opening statement from one participant who introduces the topic and sets the tone. Other members then express their opinions, support them with examples or logical reasoning, and respond to one another. Every participant is expected to listen attentively, speak clearly, and maintain a respectful tone. The discussion usually continues for ten to twenty minutes, depending on the topic and group size, and may conclude with a short summary highlighting the key ideas discussed and any collective conclusion reached.

Importance of GD

For admission to some of the universities, B- Schools, campus placements after graduation or for recruitment in a multinational company, one needs to have knowledge of the field and also can work in a group as a leader or as a member. The group discussion technique is a very effective way to judge the candidate's ability to work in a group.

Process of a Group Discussion



The key skills needed to participate effectively in a group discussion:

- **Active Listening:** Paying close attention to others' points of view without interrupting, which helps to build on ideas and respond respectfully.
- **Effective Communication:** Expressing thoughts clearly and logically with proper language and concise articulation.
- **Confidence:** Presenting your opinions assertively and without hesitation to make your arguments convincing.

- **Analytical and Critical Thinking:** Analyzing the topic from multiple angles to provide balanced, thoughtful arguments.
- **Respect and Courtesy:** Allowing others to speak, acknowledging good points even when disagreeing, and maintaining a polite tone.
- **Body Language:** Maintaining positive non-verbal cues like eye contact, nodding, and upright posture to show engagement.
- **Time Management:** Speaking within your allotted time and helping the group manage discussion flow.
- **Leadership and Collaboration:** Opening discussions, encouraging others to speak, synthesizing ideas, and handling disagreements diplomatically.
- **Open-mindedness and Flexibility:** Being receptive to different viewpoints and adapting your stance when necessary.



Roles of Participants:

Every participant in a group discussion plays a part in making the session productive and balanced. The initiator introduces the topic, provides background information, and may suggest how the group might proceed. Contributors form the body of the discussion by presenting arguments, examples, and viewpoints, either supporting or expanding on others' ideas. The moderator, or leader, ensures that the discussion remains calm, orderly, and relevant; this person invites quieter members to speak and prevents any single participant from dominating. Finally, the summariser brings the discussion to a close by restating the main points and presenting the conclusions reached by the group. In actual classroom environments, one student may perform more than one of these roles depending on the flow of conversation.

Role	Description
Initiator	Opens the discussion and introduces the topic
Contributor	Shares ideas, examples, and opinions
Moderator/Leader	Maintains decorum and guides the discussion
Summariser	Concludes by summarizing the main ideas

Do's of participating in a GD

- Think before speaking.
- Pick up clues from the discussion and intelligently add points that come to mind about the topic.
- Back up the points with facts and figures if needed.
- Be gentle and sure in your presentation of views.
- Speak to the point and make sure that points are not repeated.
- Be calm and composed while speaking.
- Listening to others is also an important aspect of participation in the group discussion, so listen to others.
- Have a respectful attitude towards the viewpoints of others.
- Sometimes the discussion may take a hostile turn. In such a case it is a good idea to intervene to make the situation relaxed. This act will show leadership and problem-solving skills.

Don'ts of participating in a GD

- Do not initiate the discussion if the topic is not familiar.
- Do not go overboard in exhibiting knowledge in any case.
- Do not interrupt other members when they are speaking.
- Do not change opinions about the topic just because most of the other participants think differently about the topic.
- Do not feel underconfident if a different speaker has presented the points effectively.
- Do not ask irrelevant questions.
- Do not let personal biases affect the discussion.

Useful Expressions:

To make their speech smooth and polite, students can use expressions such as “In my opinion,” “I agree with your point, but I would like to add,” “That’s an interesting perspective,” “I would like to highlight,” and “To conclude our discussion.” These phrases help maintain the flow and courtesy of the discussion.

Sample Topics:

To make discussions engaging and comprehensive, topics are often chosen from real-life issues, social debates, or areas of personal interest

Some suggested topics for Group Discussion include:

1. Mobile Phones: Advantage or Distraction?
2. Online Classes vs Classroom Learning
3. Is Social Media Making Us Less Social?
4. Women Empowerment in India
5. Is English a Necessity in the Modern World?

Exercises:

1. What is Group Discussion? Write a note on features of Group Discussion.
2. What are the skills required to participate effectively in a Group discussion?
3. How can one participate in Group discussions?
4. State the dos and don’ts of Group discussions.
5. What is the role of a participant in group discussion?

READING AND WRITING SKILLS

COMPREHENSION PASSAGES

OBJECTIVES:

- To enhance critical reading skills by encouraging learners to analyse, interpret, and respond to text-based questions.
- To strengthen vocabulary and contextual understanding through exposure to varied passages.
- To introduce the learners to different types of reading comprehension passages which focus on Factual & Global relevance and Data Compilation.

*"Reading maketh a full man; conference a ready man; and writing an exact man....
Comment."*

- **Francis Bacon**

Reading comprehension is the fundamental skill which is influenced by external factors. The reader's cognitive skills, such as visual processing, processing speed, and reasoning skills, can impact one's ability to comprehend text. Prior knowledge, language fluency, and the ability to make inferences will also play a role in a reader's comprehension.

Reading comprehension involves both text comprehension and vocabulary knowledge. It is essential to know what each word means individually and as a part of the whole, in addition to what the text is trying to convey.

Reading comprehension is essential for many significant aspects of daily life, such as -

- Reading, understanding, and analysing literature from English classes.
- Reading and understanding texts from other course subjects, such as History, Math, or Science.
- Understanding and engaging with current events presented in written form, such as news reports.
- Responding to official correspondence, such as essays, reports, memos, and analyses.
- Taking pleasure in written work in leisure time.

Here are some points to build upon for enhancing comprehension through passages:

- Focus on vocabulary
- Observe the sense of language
- Develop the ability to identify the meanings of phrases or words through multiple readings.
- The gist of the written text
- Infer and conclude based on the context

(Note: All the questions in comprehension are directly related to the passage)

Sample Passage with solved answers

The fear that Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Robots will automate many jobs has been growing as technological change accelerates. Some studies have predicted that 40-50% of US jobs could be automated in the next 20 years, and many people are worried that they could be forced into retirement.

The world has navigated a number of industrial revolutions in the past: First Industrial Revolution - Steam & Mechanical Production - 1700s & 1800s, Second Industrial Revolution - Electricity & Mass Production 1870 to 1914, Third Industrial Revolution - Digital Revolution - 1980s, Fourth Industrial Revolution - AI, Robotics, Networks, Biotechnology, Internet of Things – Today.

Each time, many jobs were lost, but we created new ones and overall employment stayed high after the initial disruption. But this time it feels different, partly due to the fact that real wage growth has been low to flat for many people, meaning their standard of living isn't rising. As we've become more productive through automation and globalisation, the share of GDP that goes to labour has fallen, while the share to capital has risen. Basically, it's better to be an investor rather than a worker - unless you have special skills.

Is the fear overblown? Some experts say yes. I spoke with Ken Goldberg, a UC Berkeley Robotics Professor and Eric Brewer, a VP at Google and UC Berkeley Computer Science Professor, about AI Automation and the Future of Work on a recent podcast. Both felt that the fears around AI and Robotics destroying jobs or worse, leading to the Singularity, where AI takes over, are overblown. The Singularity is a term promoted by Ray Kurzweil which predicts that based on Moore's law and the doubling of computing power per dollar every few years that: by 2023 a \$1,000 computer will have the processing power of 1 human brain; by 2030 the Singularity will occur and runaway AI will emerge; by 2050 a \$1,000 computer will have the processing power of all human brains.

Both Professors feel that predictions like self-driving cars will take much longer to play out, and that while some industries may face big disruptions. The jobs that get automated will be the boring, mundane jobs, which will be replaced by more interesting, creative jobs.

Ken Goldberg in particular, believes "Rather than worrying about an impending Singularity, consider instead the concept of Multiplicity: where diverse combinations of people and machines work together to solve problems and innovate."

They are both hopeful for the future where we all learn new skills faster and live more diverse, rich lives. Eric Brewer shared, "I feel like our kids will grow up in a generation that expects that they can do whatever they want at any time. That's super empowering."

1. What is the main fear people have regarding AI and robots?

Answer: People fear that AI and robots will automate many jobs, potentially forcing workers into unemployment or early retirement.

2. What does history show about the impact of past industrial revolutions on employment?

Answer: Past industrial revolutions caused initial job losses but eventually created new jobs, keeping overall employment high.

3. Why does this wave of technological change feel different to many people?

Answer: Because real wage growth has been low, living standards aren't rising, and a smaller share of GDP is going to labour while more goes to capital.

4. What is the Singularity according to Ray Kurzweil?

Answer: The Singularity is the predicted point when AI surpasses human intelligence, leading to runaway technological growth.

5. What do the professors Ken Goldberg and Eric Brewer believe about fears of AI destroying jobs?

Answer: They believe such fears are overblown and that AI will take longer to disrupt industries than predicted.

Exercise:

I. Read the following passages carefully and answer the following questions.

PASSAGE 1

The blanket of haze over Delhi thickened on Friday morning with the national capital's pollution levels increasing overnight by around 50 points, taking the overall air quality index to 459. A Central Pollution Control Board official said the AQI entered the "severe plus" or "emergency" category late Thursday night, the first time since January this year. According to official data, the overall AQI was 582 at 12.30 am. As part of the emergency measures, the Delhi government has decided to shut schools till November 5 as the air quality in the national capital deteriorated further. If the air quality persists in the "severe plus" category for more than 48 hours, emergency measures such as an odd-even car rationing scheme, banning entry of trucks, construction activities and shutting down schools are taken under the Graded Response Action Plan, the official said.

The hazardous pollution levels forced a number of people to miss morning walks and other activities. Shubhomoy Sikdar, a Delhi-based journalist, said the pollution levels gave him a throat infection and he had to skip his daily sports session. Amanpreet Singh, a resident of Jangpura, said he has been avoiding morning and evening walks and prefers to stay indoors.

The number of masked faces continued to grow as the city remained shrouded in pungent haze for the fourth consecutive day. At 8.30 am, the capital's overall air quality index stood at 459. It was 410 at 8 pm on Thursday. All the 37 air quality monitoring stations across

Delhi recorded the air quality in the severe category on Friday morning. Bawana was the most-polluted area with an AQI of 497, followed by Delhi Technological University (487), Wazirpur (485), Anand Vihar (484) and Vivek Vihar (482). Neighbouring Ghaziabad was the most-polluted city in the country, with the levels of PM2.5 – tiny particulate matter less than 2.5 microns that can enter deep into the lungs -- reaching as high as 493. Greater Noida (480), Noida (477), and Faridabad (432) also breathed extremely polluted air. An AQI between 0-50 is considered "good", 51-100 "satisfactory", 101-200 "moderate", 201-300 "poor", 301-400 "very poor", and 401-500 "severe". Above 500 is the "severe-plus or emergency" category.

Delhi is impatiently hoping for favourable meteorological conditions to blow away the toxic air, as health experts said the hazardous air pollution has become a serious health concern for about 2 crore residents.

"Intake of every 22 micrograms per cubic metre of polluted air is equivalent to smoking a cigarette. So whether the PM2.5 level is 700 or 300 units, the impact is still as bad. People need to take precautions, especially those suffering from asthma, bronchitis or other respiratory illnesses," said Dr Arvind Kumar, lung surgeon at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital here. Weather experts said increased wind speed due to a fresh western disturbance approaching the northern region would help disperse pollutants faster from Saturday.

1. How did the hazardous pollution levels affect residents like Shubhomoy Sikdar and Amanpreet Singh?
2. Which areas in Delhi recorded the highest AQI levels according to the monitoring stations?
3. What does an AQI between 401-500 indicate?
4. What health warning did Dr Arvind Kumar give regarding polluted air?
5. Which neighbouring city recorded the highest PM2.5 levels?

PASSAGE 2

Across the world, organisations are increasingly offering the gift of flexibility to their employees. A study by the Society of Human Resource Management shows that 17% of the organisations in the United States allow sabbaticals. We see this as a rising trend in India, particularly in the last 5 years. Most of these are "leave without pay" and are offered to employees having a strong performance track record.

This is how it works.

Organisations invest a significant amount of resources in the training and development of their employees. The returns on the investments are realised over a long period of time. As the employee keeps performing, there is an increasing acclimatisation and cultural alignment with the beliefs of the organisation. One may be able to spot a pair of trained hands with the competition, but the commitment that a performer brings to work each day is irreplaceable. So, for companies to have a sustainable future, they must retain not

only the top performers but also all the people who meet expectations consistently. When one of the good employees wants a long leave, either to explore a new world of opportunity or deal with something personal, sabbaticals come in handy. By granting a long vacation, an organisation can win a star performer's heart and ensure he/she is in for the long haul.

Sabbaticals do create unpredictability and inject instability into the organisation. Typically, the boss has to find someone to fill in the role vacated by the person going on a sabbatical. Often, the person proceeding on a sabbatical does not offer a long notice period and hence, the replacement has to happen quickly. This further adds to the pressure of finding a replacement. Secondly, such replacements are risky because of the high stakes involved with an external stakeholder such as a key client, a government body or a strategic partner.

For employees, it is a great benefit. They do not have to scratch their heads after they complete their switch-off period. They have the same job and a workplace that recognises them. The risk of not finding a new job is non-existent and hence, the person can easily take the bold step of moving away from the din and bustle of day-to-day work. Sabbaticals give them the space to reflect, the opportunity to shape their dreams and craft the path ahead. People proceed for higher studies, go for medical treatment, take up social work, pursue a passion, write a book, attend to personal emergencies in family and so on without worrying about a place and job to resume after the break.

Sometimes, sabbaticals are misused by people. One could moonlight during that period of time with another organisation in a similar area of work and hence, act against the spirit of taking a sabbatical. Companies try to mitigate the risk by drawing up the terms of the sabbatical such as eligibility in terms of duration of employment, level in the organisation and performance track record; they also define the period of sabbatical considering these factors.

There are hidden costs associated with a sabbatical. For example, employee benefits such as health insurance and accident cover have to continue. Another challenge with a long sabbatical, say six months, is to accommodate the employee in a role which is commensurate with his or her capabilities and commensurate with the pay. Small organisations do not have the elbow room required for a successful sabbatical programme. Many United States and United Kingdom-headquartered multinational companies operating in India offer such programmes. Many large Indian companies and mid-sized progressive companies in India, particularly in the services sector, such as IT, consulting and healthcare, have been offering sabbaticals. This helps the employer brand stand tall in the crowd and attract bright talent.

1. What percentage of organisations in the United States allow sabbaticals according to the Society of Human Resource Management?
2. Why do organisations invest heavily in the training and development of employees?

3. How do sabbaticals help organisations retain top-performing employees?
4. What challenges do managers face when an employee proceeds on a sabbatical?
5. Why are sabbaticals considered a great benefit for employees?

PASSAGE 3

The Amazon rainforest, the largest of its kind in the world, is ablaze, with over 9,500 distinct fires burning through its main basin since August 15. Overall, Brazil has seen more than 76,000 fires ravage the Amazon in 2019, of which around 10,000 have been started in the past few weeks, mainly by loggers and farmers seeking, as they do during the summer months, to clear vast tracts for agricultural or industrial use. However, this annual exercise of planned deforestation appears to have crossed a tipping point this year. There has been an increase of at least 80% in the number of recorded fires compared to the same period in 2018, according to Brazil's National Institute for Space Research (INPE). This week, images of darkening skies above Sao Paulo, more than 2,700 km away from the fires, went viral. The number and intensity of the fires are closely linked to the rate of deforestation. Some reports estimate that in July 2019, the Amazon shrank by 1,345 sq km, up 39% from the same month last year, and a historical record. The flames are not confined just to Brazil either. In neighbouring Bolivia, deadly blazes are devastating forests and farmlands, so much so, that its President, Evo Morales, has put his re-election campaign on hold over the weekend, and, unlike his Brazilian counterpart Jair Bolsonaro, was quick to welcome foreign aid to help fight the fires.

The distinctly political undertones of the crisis in Brazil set it apart. Mr Bolsonaro's critics say that his economic and environmental policies have virtually set the stage for intensifying the degradation of the Amazon's rich biodiversity. They argue that since he came to power this year, he has chipped away at the protections that the rainforest enjoyed, including by weakening the environment ministry when he made Ricardo Salles, found guilty of administrative improprieties for altering a map to benefit mining companies, the Environment Minister; by driving away Norway and Germany, principal donors who have backed protections for the Amazon; by sacking the head INPE over absurd allegations that he was disclosing how rapidly Amazon deforestation was happening; and by attacking both environmental charities, alleging without proof that they started fires to serve certain foreign interests, and indigenous Amazon dwellers. Under intense global pressure, including from the ongoing G-7 meetings of world leaders, Mr. Bolsonaro, a right-wing climate-change sceptic, appears to have relented to an extent, and has authorised 44,000 military troops to help with the firefighting efforts. Even if they succeed, and the Bolsonaro administration ultimately bends to global outrage over the destruction of a critical global ecosystem, the discernible shift in Brazilian public institutions responsible for guarding the future of the Amazon rainforest is a worrying sign of worse things to come.

1. Why do loggers and farmers usually start fires during the summer months?

2. What evidence showed that the Amazon fires were intense enough to affect distant regions like Sao Paulo?
3. How much did the Amazon shrink in July 2019, according to reports?
4. What action did Bolivian President Evo Morales take in response to the fires in his country?
5. Why do critics blame President Jair Bolsonaro's policies for worsening the Amazon crisis?

PASSAGE 4

Cancer drugs need to be powerfully toxic to kill tumour cells. But they also can kill healthy cells, sometimes with brutal side effects. Now, scientists have designed a way to seal cancer drugs inside tiny capsules so the drugs won't harm the healthy cells while travelling through the bloodstream. They hold that medicine securely until they reach a tumour and a remote control "switch" finally triggers the drug's release.

Smaller than bacteria, the capsules are called nanoparticles because their size is measured in nanometres. A magnetic field is the invisible force generated by a magnet. Researchers use a magnetic field to work as that remote control switch. Focusing the field on the cancer site ensures that the medicine is released only where it's needed.

The nanoparticles don't seek tumours out. They do, however, tend to collect at tumour sites. Tumours tend to grow so fast that the blood vessels inside them can't keep up. This causes holes to form in the blood vessels. For a nano-package carrying the medicine, those leaky spots become a doorway from the bloodstream into the tumour. The nanoparticles slip in through those leaks, then accumulate in the tumour.

Nanoparticles can also pile up in unwanted places. One such unhelpful collection point is the liver. This organ acts as a filter, snagging poisons out of the blood. It will also net some nanoparticles. Those caught in the liver could damage that organ if they shed too much of an anti-cancer drug.

For many years, researchers have studied how to make nanoparticles that won't drop their drug cargo at such unwanted sites. Sometimes they relied on a chemical trait of the tumour — or the enzymes it produces — to unlock the particles. But not all cancers have the same chemistry. So the medicine might still leak out to poison cells outside the tumour. The new innovation by Rinaldi's team is the creation of a nanoparticle that won't release its medicine anywhere until it gets very warm. And that warming occurs when the particle is exposed to a magnetic field.

1. What is the main purpose of sealing cancer drugs inside tiny capsules?
2. Why are the capsules called nanoparticles?
3. When do the warming occur?
4. Why blood vessels cannot hold tumour?
5. Which organ is described as an "unhelpful collection point" for nanoparticles?

PASSAGE 5

For generations, companies have been selling fair skin to young Indian women, promising better marriage and employment prospects. However, over the last few years, men have become a favoured target audience. This followed the realisation that the Indian alpha male, denied a choice in male-specific grooming products, had been using women's fairness creams all along. Until the mid-2000s, deodorants and shaving creams were the only grooming products advertised for men. But India's largest consumer goods companies sensed an opportunity and launched a slew of fairness products for male consumers.

In India, as in other parts of the world, light skin is the culturally accepted and endorsed form of beauty, and children absorb this message at a young age. According to a 2015 research report by Nielsen, urban Indian men believe that fair skin can improve professional prospects. The cultural pressure to look fair, argues Kiran Khalap, branding expert and founder at communications consultancy Chlorophyll, is something inherent in our society, not manufactured by companies. "And it is certainly not restricted to India: China and Japan have had skin-whitening products for centuries, well before they met Western 'white' people," he said. However, there is a growing awareness among consumers that companies are exploiting their insecurities, and critics have taken some of the biggest fairness brands and the celebrities who endorse them to task for their casual discrimination.

Earlier this month, Bollywood actor Abhay Deol took to Facebook to trounce his fellow actors who earn millions from endorsing fairness creams. This comes a few years after actress Nandita Das launched the "Dark is Beautiful" campaign to encourage Indians to embrace a wider definition of beauty. These efforts are slowly making a difference, increasing awareness and encouraging consumers to take pride in their natural skin tones. That means Indian companies will eventually have to change their approach. "My sense is that brands will wake up to the new reality, and you will see propositions reworked around clearer skin (and) glow, rather than pure fairness," Leo Burnett's Sinha said.

Rajesh Krishnamurthy, business head for the consumer product division at The Himalaya Drug Company, believes that over time, the men's grooming category will evolve to include a wider range of products, including those for normal skin, just like in the women's skin care category. "Companies are increasingly realising that you cannot continue to mislead consumers anymore; these are educated young men who will question what you sell to them," said Shantanu Deshpande, co-founder and CEO of the male-grooming startup Bombay Shaving Company.

1. What were the main grooming products advertised for men before the mid-2000s?
2. According to the Nielsen 2015 report, why do urban Indian men prefer fair skin?
3. Who is Kiran Khalap?
4. Why did actor Abhay Deol criticise his fellow Bollywood actors?
5. What was the purpose of the "Dark is Beautiful" campaign launched by Nandita Das?

PASSAGE 6

There is an old African proverb that says, “Until the lions have their own historians, histories of the hunt will glorify the hunter.”

As is common knowledge, while the male lion’s mane incites our imagination, it is actually the lionesses that bring in food and ensure the survival of the species. As Renana Jhavwala of SEWA and a member of the UN Secretary General’s High-Level Panel on Women’s Economic Empowerment aptly says, “Women’s work is invisible ... women are at the base of the economic pyramid. Women are stuck on a ‘sticky floor’ of low technology, low productivity, low skills, low earnings and low dignity.” Rural women in the Asia-Pacific region make critical contributions to household production and national food security, yet their contribution is hardly acknowledged.

The credit for the success of Brazil’s conditional cash transfer programme, Bolsa Família, goes to women. The programme rewards families for sending their children to school and taking them for regular health check-ups. This scheme has pulled millions out of poverty. The state tends to believe women are more reliable than men. In Mexico, a similar programme, Oportunidades, is available exclusively to women.

There is strong empirical evidence to suggest that money in the hands of the mother increases expenditure on children. There is a strong positive correlation between women’s status and economic/social development. Policy makers across the world have placed great emphasis on gender equality. The experience suggests that economic development alone is not enough to bring about equality. What is needed is policy action. This is where the importance of women’s political empowerment comes. Democracy in the 21st century is moving towards equity and inclusion. This is the underlying message of citizens’ movements across the world. And with the increasing role of women at the policy level and in institutions of government, democracy can become ‘politics of difference’ and ‘politics of presence.’

1. Who said that “Women’s work is invisible”?
2. What does empirical evidence suggest about money placed in the hands of mothers?
3. What is Brazil’s *Bolsa Família* programme designed to do?
4. What is the underlying message of citizens’ movements in the 21st century?
5. What is the aim of Brazil’s Bolsa Família programme?

REPORT WRITING

(Events and Field Visits)

Objectives:

- Develop the ability to present factual information clearly and logically.
- Enhance formal and coherent writing.
- Enable learners to document events and field experiences effectively.

Introduction:

Report writing is a systematic and structured way of presenting information about an event, investigation, project, or situation. It involves collecting facts and data, organizing them logically, and presenting them in a clear and concise manner for a specific purpose and audience.

A report is generally written in formal language and follows a definite format. It provides a complete, factual, and objective account of an incident or study. Unlike essays, reports are not based on personal opinions or emotions; they are factual and informative. A well-written report serves as an official record and helps in decision-making, evaluation, and future reference.

Purpose of Report Writing

The main purposes of report writing are:

- To record events or findings for future reference.
- To communicate information clearly and accurately to others.
- To analyse and interpret the results of an activity or event.
- To make recommendations or conclusions based on observations.
- To document learning experiences from visits, projects, or activities.

In educational settings, reports help students develop their ability to observe, analyse, and present information systematically.

Characteristics of a Good Report

A good report should have the following features:

- **Clarity:** The ideas should be expressed clearly and logically.
- **Accuracy:** The facts and figures included must be correct and verifiable.
- **Objectivity:** The writer should not include personal opinions or emotions.
- **Conciseness:** Unnecessary details should be avoided.
- **Organization:** Information should follow a logical sequence.
- **Formal Language:** The tone should be professional and impersonal.

- **Presentation:** The report should be neatly formatted with headings and subheadings.

Types of Report Writing:

Reports can be classified based on their purpose and use. The following are the main types of reports commonly written by students and professionals

1. Event Report

An event report provides a detailed account of a programme or activity conducted in an institution or organization. It includes information such as what the event was, when and where it took place, who organized it, who attended it, and what activities were conducted. The purpose is to document the event and highlight its outcomes or achievements.

Example:

- Report on the Annual Day Celebration
- Report on a Workshop or Seminar

2. Field Visit Report

A field visit report records the details of a visit made to a place of educational, industrial, or cultural importance. It focuses on what was observed or learned during the visit. The purpose is to describe the learning experience gained through direct observation and interaction.

Example:

- Visit to a Science Museum
- Visit to a Historical Monument

3. Project Report

A project report presents the results of a study or research conducted on a particular topic.

It includes objectives, methods, findings, and conclusions based on the work done by the student or researcher. The purpose is to communicate the outcome of an academic or research project.

Example:

- Project Report on Waste Management in the Campus
- Project Report on Women Entrepreneurship

4. Newspaper Report

A newspaper report provides factual information about a recent or current event. It answers the five W's and one H — What, When, Where, Who, why, and how — in a concise and engaging way. The purpose is to inform the public about events of local, national, or global importance.

Example:

- Fire Accident in City Market
- Flood Relief Camp Organized in Rural Areas

5. Workplace or Internship Report

This report is written by students after completing a training, internship, or work experience programme. It highlights the tasks performed, skills learned, and overall experience gained. The purpose is to provide a summary of professional exposure and skills acquired.

Example:

- Internship Report at Winpro Company
- Training Report on Banking Procedures

6. Survey or Research Report

A survey or research report presents the data collected from a survey or study. It includes the objective, method, findings, analysis, and conclusions drawn from the research. The purpose is to present facts and analysis based on systematic data collection and observation.

Example:

- Survey Report on Student Reading Habits
- Research Report on the Impact of Social Media on Youth

Sample Reports

1. Report on an Event

Title: Report on the Inauguration of the Language Club

Introduction:

The Department of English, VIN Degree College, organized the inauguration of the Language Club on 20th August 2025 in the college auditorium. The event was presided over by the Principal, Dr. R. Meenakshi, and inaugurated by Prof. S. N. Murthy, Head of the Department of English, ABC Degree College.

Objective:

The event aimed to enhance students' interest in language learning and provide a platform for creative expression.

Programme Details:

The function began with an invocation song followed by a welcome address. The chief guest highlighted the role of language in personality development and career success. The students presented cultural performances and participated in a Word Hunt game. The programme ended with a vote of thanks by the club coordinator.

Outcome:

The event encouraged active student participation and promoted collaborative learning through language-based activities.

Conclusion:

The inauguration of the Language Club was a successful and inspiring event that motivated students to engage in language enrichment programmes.

2. Field Visit Report

Title: Report on Field Visit to Vishvesvaraiah Industrial and Technological Museum, Bengaluru

Introduction:

On 10th September 2025, the Department of Science organized a field visit to the Vishvesvaraiah Industrial and Technological Museum for second-year B.Sc. students. Forty students and two faculty members participated in the visit.

Objective:

The main purpose of the visit was to provide practical exposure to scientific principles and innovations demonstrated in the museum exhibits.

Description:

Students visited different galleries, including those on space, mechanics, and biotechnology. Museum guides explained various models and experiments. Students also interacted with experts and took notes for their project work.

Outcome:

The field visit gave students a better understanding of scientific applications, inspired curiosity, and strengthened their analytical skills.

Conclusion:

The visit was informative and enjoyable. It bridged the gap between classroom learning and practical observation.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Writing personal opinions (e.g., “I liked it very much”).
- Ignoring date, place, or purpose of the event.
- Using casual or emotional language.
- Writing too long without structure.
- Missing conclusion or learning outcome.

Practice Exercises

1. Write a report on a Guest Lecture on Career Opportunities in English conducted by your department. Include date, venue, guest’s name, and key points discussed.
2. Write a report on a Field Visit to a Local Newspaper Office or Printing Press. Include the objective, details of the visit, and learning outcomes.
3. Imagine your college organized a Blood Donation Camp. Prepare a report covering the major highlights, number of donors, and significance of the event.
4. Your college arranged a Field Visit to a Dairy Farm. Write a report covering the purpose of the visit, the production process observed, and the students’ learning experience.
5. Your college celebrated Teachers’ Day to honour the contribution of teachers. Write a report on the programme mentioning the chief guest, events organized, and students’ participation.

6. Write a report on a Field Visit to a Historical Monument such as Hampi or Mysore Palace. Include details of date, location, observations made, and significance of the visit.

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SUMMARIZING

Objectives:

- To strengthen comprehension skills
- To improve clarity and precision in writing
- To reduce verbosity and avoid redundancy

Introduction:

Summarizing is an essential reading and writing skill that helps one understand and express the main ideas of a text in a shorter and clearer form. Every day, we come across large amount of information in books, articles, videos, lectures, and even conversations. A summary allows us to reduce this information to its key points without losing the original meaning.

Summarizing improves our comprehension, helps in revision and note-making, and strengthens communication skills. It also encourages critical thinking, as we must decide which ideas matter most and how to present them logically.

In short, summarizing is not just shortening a text, it is understanding the content deeply and expressing its core meaning clearly and effectively. A summary should be significantly one-third the length of the original passage.

Tips for Effective Summarizing

- Read the text carefully - Understand the passage fully before summarizing.
- Identify key points - Look for main ideas, topic sentences, and important facts.
- Ignore unnecessary details - Skip examples, descriptions, quotes, and repeated ideas.
- Use your own words - Paraphrase the content instead of copying sentences.
- Keep it short - A summary should be much shorter than the original text.
- Maintain the original meaning- Do not add your opinion or change the writer's message.
- Check coherence - Ensure your summary flows logically and clearly.

Common Errors to Avoid in Summarizing

While summarizing text the following are the common errors:

- The word count of precis text must not be more than the original text
- Avoid the use of jargon and complex sentences
- Don't add assumptions and personal ideas
- Avoid using acronyms
- Don't write the sentence in question form
- A sentence must not include all

SAMPLE:

1. **Original Passage:** Exercise in nature is very beneficial for both physical and mental health. In addition to the general benefits of exercise, such as improving cardiovascular health and increasing muscle strength, outdoor activities also provide an opportunity to experience the beauty and tranquillity of nature. It can increase feelings of well-being and reduce stress and anxiety. It is important to embrace the benefits of outdoor exercise and incorporate it into your regular routine. (141 words)

Title: The Benefits of Outdoor Exercise

Precis: Outdoor exercise has benefits for physical and mental health, including increasing well-being and reducing stress and anxiety. It is important to include outdoor exercise in your routine. (56 words)

2. **Original Passage:** One night a holy man, Abu Ben Adhem by name, suddenly woke up from a deep dream of peace and saw in his moonlit room an angel writing something in a book of gold. He did not feel at all frightened. The peaceful face of the angel made Abu bold and he said to the angel, "What are you writing?" The angel looked up and replied in a kind and sweet tone, "I am taking down the names of those who love God." "And is my name one among them?" Asked Abu. But the angel replied, "No, it is not." "I pray thee then," said Abu, "To write me down as one who loves his fellowmen."

The Angel wrote and vanished. The next night the angel came again with a great light which awaked Abu Ben Adhem: and he showed Abu the names of those who had been blessed by the love of God. And behold! the name of Abu was at the top of the list. (166 words)

Title – Abu Ben Adhem and the Angel

Summary- Abu Ben Adhem woke up from a deep dream and saw an angel writing in a book of gold. He asked the angel to write his name down as one who loves his fellowmen, and the next night the angel showed him the names of those blessed by God, with his name at the top of the list. (58 words)

EXERCISE:

Write a summary of the given passages and suggest a suitable title:

1. Mankind in general is not sufficiently acquainted with the import of the word justice. It is generally considered to include the performance of duties that society's laws may mandate. This, I allow, is sometimes the import of the word, and in this sense, justice is distinguished from equity. But justice is still broader and unites all the virtues that can be shown. Justice may be defined as a virtue that urges us to give to every person what is his due.

In this extended sense of the word, it refers to the practice of every virtue that determines reason or should be expected of society. Our duty to our Creator, to each other and to ourselves is fully answered if we give them what we owe them. Thus,

properly speaking, justice is the only virtue in which all the rest have their root.(150words)

2. Charity is a universal duty, which is in every man's power to be sometimes exercised since every assistance given to another from a right motive is an act of charity; and is seldom in such infirmity that he cannot benefit his neighbour in any case. He who cannot relieve the poor can instruct the ignorant, and he who cannot minister to the sick can restore the wicked.

He who can give little help himself may undertake the duty of alms by inciting the greed of others and recommending petitions that he cannot grant, to those who have more power to give. The widow who puts her mite into her treasury and the poor man who brings a cup of cold water to the thirsty will not lose their reward. (143 words)

3. We call beautiful anything that gives us pleasure and that depends on things outside of us. Perhaps most people think the sea is beautiful only when it is blue. If one has been in Italy as a child and has grown up beside the grey North Sea, he will think that grey seas are ugly: and nothing can be so beautiful as the blue Mediterranean.

But suppose a Scotsman who loves Scotland should go to Italy. He might find the blue sea too uninteresting after a while. When he goes home and sees the grey sea again, he will see the sea as beautiful. We are made in different ways, and grey can be as beautiful as blue, just as a baby's cry can be sweeter to someone's ears than the best notes of the greatest singer of all time. Nothing is beautiful or ugly in itself, but thinking makes it so. (172 words)

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CORRESPONDENCES

Objectives:

- To develop professional communication skills.
- To understand structure and format of E-mail.
- To practice digital etiquette and responsible usage.
- To express ideas precisely and professionally.

Email (Electronic Mail) is one of the most widely used written communication tools in the modern digital world. It allows individuals, professionals, and organizations to send and receive messages instantly across the globe. Mastering email communication is essential for both personal and professional success, as it reflects one's clarity, etiquette, and communication skills.

Definition of Email

Email stands for *Electronic Mail*. It refers to the exchange of digital messages across computer networks using the Internet. Each email message typically includes a sender's address, recipient's address, subject line, message body, and attachments.

Emails are transmitted through simple electronic protocols such as SMTP (Simple Mail Transfer Protocol) and received through POP3 or IMAP servers.

Functions of Email

- Sending and receiving text messages instantly.
- Sharing attachments, such as documents, images, or videos.
- Maintaining written records of communications.
- Enabling group discussions through CC (carbon copy) and BCC (blind carbon copy).
- Allowing scheduling and meeting coordination with calendar integration.

Uses of Email

- **Personal Communication:** Staying connected with friends and family.
- **Professional Correspondence:** Communicating with colleagues, clients, and employers.
- **Educational Communication:** Submitting assignments, addressing academic queries, and sharing information.
- **Business Communication:** Sending proposals, order confirmations, invoices, and customer support messages.

Disadvantages of Email

- **Information Overload:** Too many emails may lead to reduced productivity.
- **Spam and Phishing Risks:** Unwanted or fraudulent emails can compromise security.
- **Misinterpretation:** Tone may be misunderstood, leading to communication gaps.
- **Dependency on Internet:** Emails require stable connectivity.
- **Delayed Responses:** Not all messages receive immediate replies, causing delays.

Email Etiquette

Email etiquette refers to the set of principles and guidelines that ensure clarity, Professionalism, and respect in email communication.

Key practices include:

- **Use a professional email address:** Especially for work or academic purposes.
- **Write a clear subject line:** It tells the reader what to expect.
- **Greet properly:** Start with Dear/Hello followed by the person's name or title.
- **Keep it concise:** Avoid unnecessary details.
- **Use correct grammar and punctuation:** A well-written email builds credibility.
- **Avoid emotional or harsh language:** Maintain courtesy at all times.
- **Add a proper closing:** Such as "Regards," "Sincerely," or "Thank you."
- **Proofread before sending:** Check for spelling or factual errors.
- **Avoid using all capital letters:** It can appear as shouting.
- **Use CC and BCC carefully:** Share messages only with necessary recipients.

E-mail format:

1. **Salutation:** The salutation of a formal e-mail is similar to the salutation of a letter.
E.g.: 'To whom it may concern'
 'Dear Hiring manager'
 'Dear Mr/Ms.Smith'. etc.
For a formal salutation, do not use the recipient's first name.
2. **Body:** It is important to remember that an e-mail needs to be concise. The opening sentence can be greeting if the situation allows it.

E.g.: 'I hope all is well with you'

'Thank you for your prompt response etc.'

For most formal e-mails it is best to get straight to the point. At the end of your last paragraph, you should provide a 'Thank you' or 'Call to action' depending on the subject of your e-mail.

3. **Closing:** The closing of a formal e-mail can be the same as the closing to a letter. There are more options for a closing.

- Best regards
- Thank you
- Sincerely
- Faithfully
- Sincerely yours

Types of Emails

The four types of emails are:

- **Request**
- **Permission**
- **Apology**
- **Complaint.**

➤ Request Email:

A request email is written when you need assistance, information, or approval from someone. It should be polite, concise, and specify what you need clearly.

Sample Email 1: Request for Information

Subject: Request for Details Regarding Internship Program

Dear HR Team,

I hope you are doing well. I am writing to request detailed information about the upcoming internship program offered by your organization. Kindly share the eligibility criteria, duration, and application process.

Thank you for your time and assistance.

Regards,

Rahul Mehta

BBA Student, Christ University

Sample Email 2: Request for Appointment

Subject: Request for Meeting Appointment

Dear Professor Rao,

I hope this message finds you well. I would like to request a short meeting to discuss my dissertation outline and receive your feedback. Kindly let me know a convenient time next week.

Thank you for your guidance.

Sincerely,

Ananya Sharma

Sample Email 3: Request for Leave

Subject: Request for Two Days Leave

Dear Supervisor,

I am writing to request leave from November 10 to November 11 due to a family function. I will ensure that all pending work is completed before my leave.

Kindly grant approval.

Best regards,

Vikas Kumar

➤ Permission Email:

Permission emails are written to ask consent for performing a specific action, using content, or accessing information.

Sample Email 1: Permission to Use Data

Subject: Request for Permission to Use Survey Data

Dear Dr. Iyer,

I am conducting a research project on consumer behavior. I kindly request permission to use the data collected during your 2023 survey for academic reference.

Looking forward to your approval.

Warm regards,

Sneha Raj

Sample Email 2: Permission to Conduct Event

Subject: Request for Permission to Organize Cultural Event

Dear Principal,

Greetings. The student council seeks permission to organize a cultural event, "Festiva 2025," on November 20. We assure that all safety and discipline protocols will be maintained.

Awaiting your kind approval.

Sincerely,

Arjun N.

President, Student Council

Sample Email 3: Permission for Field Visit

Subject: Permission for Industrial Visit

Dear Head of Department,

We, the final-year management students, request your permission to organize an industrial visit to Infosys, Mysore, to gain practical exposure to corporate operations.

Kindly approve our proposal.

With regards,

Group Coordinator

Department of Management Studies

➤ Apology Email:

An apology email expresses regret or take responsibility for an error, miscommunication, or inconvenience caused to another person.

Sample Email 1: Apology for Delay in Submission

Subject: Apology for Late Submission of Report

Dear Sir,

I sincerely apologize for submitting the monthly report later than the scheduled deadline. The delay was due to a technical issue with my laptop. I assure this will not recur.

Thank you for your understanding.

Respectfully,

Nikita Jain

Sample Email 2: Apology for Miscommunication

Subject: Apology for Miscommunication Regarding Meeting Schedule

Dear Mr. Verma,

Please accept my sincerest apologies for the confusion caused about yesterday's meeting time. I mistakenly noted the schedule and regret the inconvenience you faced. I will ensure proper coordination in the future.

Best regards,

Karan Patel

Sample Email 3: Apology to Customer

Subject: Apology for Product Delivery Delay

Dear Customer,

We sincerely apologize for the delay in delivering your order placed on October 30. Due to unforeseen logistics issues, the shipment was postponed. Your order will reach you by November 9.

We truly appreciate your patience and understanding.

Warm regards,

Riya Thomas

Customer Support Team

Complaint Email:

A complaint email is sent to express dissatisfaction about a product, service, or experience. It should be polite yet firm and include clear details of the problem.

Sample Email 1: Complaint about Faulty Product

Subject: Complaint Regarding Faulty Bluetooth Speaker

Dear Customer Support,

I purchased a Bluetooth speaker (Order No. #45672) on November 2, and it has stopped working after two days. I request a replacement or refund at the earliest.

Attached are the purchase invoice and product photo.

Kindly look into the matter.

Regards,

Saurabh Nair

Sample Email 2: Complaint About Poor Service

Subject: Complaint About Poor Internet Service

Dear Service Team,

I am facing repeated connection drops and low internet speed despite a high-speed plan. My customer ID is 245678. Please resolve this issue promptly, as it is affecting my work.

Awaiting your swift response.

Sincerely,

Rajeev Menon

Sample Email 3: Complaint About Maintenance Delay

Subject: Urgent Complaint About Apartment Maintenance Delay

Dear Maintenance Manager,

I am writing to express my concern regarding the delay in plumbing repair in Block B–Flat 104. Several requests have been made in the past two weeks with no action taken.

Kindly arrange for immediate repair.

Thank you,

Priya Bhattacharya

Exercises:

1. Write an email requesting information about a new online certification course in Digital Marketing.
2. Draft a permission email to your department head for arranging a campus cleanliness drive.
3. Write an apology email to your senior for missing a project deadline.
4. Compose a complaint email about defective stationery items supplied to your office.

Research Skills

Objective:

- To familiarize the students with basic aspects of research (academic or business) and steps involved in writing assignments and research projects with special focus on the procedure.

Introduction about Research:

A research paper is an investigative written report based on the information compiled from a variety of sources. The purpose of the project can be to investigate, examine, clarify, defend explore or reappraise the subject. The process of research is a vast and voluminous one and preparation of a report involves arranging the information gathered in a condensed and systematic format.

Components of the Research:



Scope of the study:

The components involved in the scope of the study are

- a. How is the area of the research to be defined?
- b. What are the factors to be considered?
- c. What is the time or period of the study?
- d. Who is the target audience?
- e. Generality or Specificity of the study?

Methodology (sourcing of information):

The quality of the project work depends on the methodology adopted for the study. Methodology in turn depends upon the nature of the project work. The main strength of the report comes from the process of collecting, synthesizing and analyzing information which have a bearing on the defined problem.

The research can be exploratory, descriptive, experimental or investigative.

Three important resources that aid research are

1. Study of primary and secondary sources. (wherever applicable)
2. Collection of information through questionnaires, interviews or personal contacts.
3. Analysis of specific/relevant cases.

Data collection can be done through the experimental or a survey method.

The most popular research instrument for collecting data is a questionnaire. The questionnaire is a list of questions asked to the respondents about the specific issue. Inferences are drawn from the responses of the respondents.

Questionnaire

A questionnaire is a research instrument consisting of a series of questions designed to collect data from respondents. It is widely used in surveys, academic research, market studies, and evaluations to gather information about individuals' thoughts, preferences, behaviours, or experiences. Questionnaires are an essential tool in quantitative research, helping researchers gather standardized data from large groups of people.

Types of Questions in a Questionnaire:

The effectiveness of a questionnaire largely depends on the type of questions used. Here are some commonly used question types:

Closed-Ended Questions: These questions provide a set of predefined answer options, making them easy to analyze. Examples include Yes/No questions, multiple-choice questions, and Likert scale questions (e.g., "Strongly Agree" to "Strongly Disagree").

Open-Ended Questions: These questions allow respondents to answer in their own words. They are valuable for gathering qualitative insights, such as opinions, feelings, or experiences.

Rating Scale Questions: These questions ask respondents to rate a statement or item on a numerical or descriptive scale. For instance, “On a scale of 1 to 10, how satisfied are you with our service?”

Ranking Questions: These questions require respondents to rank items in order of preference or importance. An example might be, “Rank the following product features in order of importance.”

Dichotomous Questions: These are simple, two-option questions (e.g., Yes/No, True/False), providing clear-cut answers that are easy to analyze.

Sample Questions:

1. Closed-Ended Questions:

- “How often do you shop with us?”
 - a) Once a week
 - b) Once a month
 - c) A few times a year
 - d) First time
- “Would you recommend our store to a friend?”
 - a) Yes
 - b) No

2. Rating Scale Question:

- “On a scale of 1 to 5, how satisfied are you with the speed of our delivery service?”
(1 being “Very Dissatisfied” and 5 being “Very Satisfied”)

3. Ranking Question:

- “Please rank the following aspects of our store in order of importance to you (1 being most important):”
 - Product Variety
 - Price
 - Customer Service
 - Delivery Speed

4. Open-Ended Question:

- “What could we improve to make your shopping experience better?”

This questionnaire gathers structured, easy-to-analyze data while also allowing respondents to provide detailed feedback. The mix of question types helps capture different aspects of customer satisfaction, from general preferences to specific suggestions.

Interview:

Interviewing important personalities requires thorough preparation, a respectful approach, and skilful questioning to elicit meaningful and insightful responses.

Preparation and Research

- Conduct comprehensive research on the personality's background, achievements, current projects, and public image before the interview.
- Prepare unique angles and avoid cliché questions by understanding the interviewee's interests and potential sensitivities.
- Share interview questions or topics in advance, if possible, to help them feel at ease and provide thoughtful answers.

Questioning Techniques

- Begin with broad, personal, and open-ended questions that help relax the interviewee, such as "What inspired you to pursue your career?" or "What keeps you going in your work?".
- Progress to specific, situational, and behavioural questions to delve into personal experiences, challenges, and decision-making.
- Focus on topics like motivation, values, legacy, defining moments, and influences for deeper insights.
- Encourage storytelling by repeatedly asking for concrete details and anecdotes rather than abstract or formulaic answers.

Creating a Comfortable Atmosphere

- Set a friendly, non-intimidating tone and use empathetic listening to build trust.
- Be sensitive to the interviewee's mood, and let them steer the conversation when appropriate.
- Ensure a respectful environment where personal and sometimes challenging questions are asked tactfully.

Sample Interview Questions for Important Personalities

1. What inspired you to pursue your career?
2. What is your biggest challenge, and how do you overcome it?
3. Who has had the most influence on your life?
4. How do you stay balanced despite success?
5. What legacy do you hope to leave behind?

Best Practices for Interviewers

- Actively listen and follow up on intriguing points or emotions expressed.
- Avoid leading or assumptive questions, and instead let the interviewee do most of the talking (aim for 70%).
- Withhold judgment and remain open-minded throughout the interview.
- Respect privacy and only pursue personal questions if the subject seems comfortable.

These strategies foster engaging, respectful, and revealing conversations, helping interviewers establish credibility and rapport with important personalities while producing valuable content.

Example:

The best five questions for the interview titled "Legacy and Leadership: Dialogue with Mrs. Sudha Murthy," focusing on her inspiring journey, leadership, and philanthropic legacy:

1. What early experiences shaped your values and commitment to social service and leadership?
2. How did you navigate and break gender barriers as India's first woman engineer at Tata Motors, and what lessons do you draw from that journey?
3. Can you share some transformative moments or challenges during your tenure as Chairperson of the Infosys Foundation that defined your approach to philanthropy?
4. Women's empowerment and rural development have been central to your work—what strategies have you found most effective in creating sustainable impact in these areas?
5. Looking ahead, what legacy do you hope to leave behind, and what advice would you give to young leaders aspiring to make a meaningful difference?

These questions invite Mrs. Sudha Murthy to reflect on her personal journey, leadership style, societal impact, and vision for the future, capturing her remarkable legacy and inspiring leadership.

Exercises:

1. Frame any Five close ended questions to the college students(respondents) on College Environment.

2. Frame five open ended questions to examine how digital habits affect students.

3. Frame 5 questions for interviewing the following:

- a. Renowned Film star

- b. Accomplished Women entrepreneur

- c. Cricketer / Sports person

d. Booker Prize Winner Banu Mushtaq.

e. Environmentalist

Sample Questionnaire:

Student satisfaction Survey

Name:

Course:

Year:

1. How likely you recommend this college to your friends and family?

Very likely

Somewhat likely

Neutral

Unlikely

Very unlikely

Ans: Very Likely

2. On a scale of 1 to 5, how satisfied are you with our college environment?

(1 being "Very Dissatisfied" and 5 being "Very Satisfied").

Ans: 1

3. "Please rank the following aspects of our college in order of importance to you (1 being most important):"

Indoor:

Ans: 1

Canteen:

Ans: 1

Cultural Programs:

Ans: 1

Exercise:

1. Frame feedback Questions for the Guest Lecture organized by your department:

[illegible]

2. Frame questions for a customer satisfaction survey on the new online venture you have started on food and beverages:

[illegible]

References:

<https://researchmethod.net/questionnaire/>

<https://www.scribbr.com/methodology/questionnaire/>

<https://microbenotes.com/questionnaire-types-format-questions/>

BOOK REVIEW

Objectives:

- To evaluate students' comprehension and interpretive ability.
- To develop coherent and evaluative writing skills.
- To train students to integrate the study material and the reading skills.

"A book review describes, analyses and evaluates. The review conveys an opinion, supporting it with evidence from the book".

Writing a book review shall not only give insights about a book but also pave the way to form an opinion on the author's views and the context in which the book was written. Usually, Book Reviews are given to develop and practise careful analytical reading. A reviewer's task is to bring together certain features such as accuracy, analytical reading and strong response, which would indicate what the book is about and what it might mean to a reader. In other words, a reviewer will not only highlight the '5Ws and 1H' about a book but also combine the skills of describing what is on the page, analysing how the book tried to achieve its purpose, and expressing your own responses and reactions. Some readers confuse book reviews with book reports, yet writing a book review is a very different process from writing a book report. Book reports focus on the plot of the book. Frequently, the aim of book reports is to demonstrate that the books are read, and they are often done for an assignment. A book review is a completely different task. A book review's purpose is to help people decide whether or not the book would interest them enough to read it.

A good review is more than just a summary of the contents. It should include your view on what the purpose of the book is and who it is intended for, and it should address the context (time and place) in which the book has been written, an evaluation of the author's arguments for strengths and weaknesses, and your identification of any bias in their perspective on the topic. The writers of book reviews have a certain freedom in the content and organisation of their reviews, because, in the end, they are expressions of their own perspective or viewpoint.

Some points and questions which are important in writing a book review are as follows:

- The **Title** catches readers' attention and stimulates their interest, so that they'll continue reading the review. It can be a provocative statement or even a question.
- Prepare a **Synopsis** of the plot so that a reader gets the gist of the storyline. You need to keep a question in mind: Anyone can summarise a plot, but what is your unique take on this book? Simply saying a book was "good" or "bad", or that you liked it or didn't, isn't helpful. Let your reader know '**why**' you think it is a great read, or why you found it disappointing. Let your reader know your rationale for choosing a particular rating. These details will help the readers to form their own opinion. A good summary has three principal requirements:

1. It should be focused on the aspects of the source text or texts that are relevant for your purpose.
 2. It should represent the source material accurately.
 3. It should be condensed source material and be presented in your own words. Summaries that consist of directly copied portions of the original rarely succeed. Such a summary may suggest that you can find potentially important information, but it will likely fail to reveal the extent to which you have understood it.
- **Significant Questions** to be focused:
 1. Who is the author? What is his/her disciplinary background?
 2. What have they published before? Is this building on their previous research or entering a new field?
 3. When was the book written?
 4. How might that affect the perspective taken? Is there, for example, a political, social or economic context that would impact the writing?
 5. What is the main argument in the book? Is it well argued? Are the author's assumptions valid? Is there any obvious bias in the source of evidence they use?
 6. Mention if the book is a part of any series and whether it is necessary to have read other books in the series before this book.
 - **Evaluative Language:**
 1. Carefully chosen language can contribute to the reader's willingness to accept your claims. Writing a good review requires an awareness of evaluative language.
 2. Authors can indicate their attitudes toward a proposition or idea by indicating surprise, disbelief, understanding, and interest.
 3. Authors may also attempt to establish a connection with their readers and bring them into the text through the use of engagement markers. Engagement markers can take a variety of forms, including personal pronouns (e.g., we and you), questions, commands, or directly addressing the reader or readers.
 4. What is the Style of writing:
 - a) the intellectual qualities, e.g., simplicity, clarity
 - b) the "emotional qualities" of the writing, e.g., humour, wit, satire
 - c) the "aesthetic qualities" of the writing, e.g., harmony, rhythm
 - d) the stylistic devices are employed, e.g., symbolism, motifs, parody, allegory
 5. How effective is dialogue?
 - **Praise and Critique:**
 1. What is your view on the book's strengths and weaknesses?
 2. Do you think it's a valuable contribution to the literature in the discipline? What is the book about?
 3. What is the main topic area and scope?
 4. How does it fit with other books that have been published in this area?
 5. What kind of evidence does the author use to prove his or her points? Is the evidence convincing?

6. Give examples of areas where the book did well and areas where it could be improved
7. Discuss Strengths and Weaknesses. Weaknesses are likely to be something the author omitted/did not address in sufficient detail
8. Is the book well-structured, and does it have lucidity?
9. Is the writing style appropriate?
10. Let your audience know your conclusions.

All of the above-mentioned points and questions should be supported by reference to particular passages or chapters that provide evidence to support your views.

General Tips for Writing a Book Review

- **Streamlining:** Pay attention to length and make every word count. Lengthy, incoherent reviews are puzzling and time-consuming to read.
- **Editing:** Make sure you **proofread** spelling and grammar. Correct grammatical mistakes and punctuation as you find them. A review filled with errors may not be taken seriously.
- **Honest and Impartial:** Express your honest opinion. Evaluate without any bias/prejudice.
- **Quotes/Phrases:** Use a few quotes or phrases (keep them short) from the book to illustrate the points you make about the book. They make your review authentic and emphatic.
- **Conclusion:** Make sure you include a conclusion to the review – don't leave it hanging. The conclusion can also be just one sentence.
- **Bibliographic Details:** Most reviews start with a heading that includes all the bibliographic information about the book.
The following format is preferred:
Title, Author, Place of publication: publisher, date of publication, Number of pages.

Example: *Taking Soaps Seriously: The World of Guiding Light*. Michael Intintoli. New York: Praeger, 1984. 248 pp

Sample Book Review (published in Deccan Herald)

Panipat. Vishwas Patil (Translated by Nadeem Khan) New Delhi: Westland Publications Pvt Ltd, 2019 (first published 1988). 650 pp.

Handcuffed by history

The author brings to life the trauma of war by employing an emotionally charged narrative.

Suhasini Srihari, MAR 15 2020, 01:44 IST.

The defeat of the Marathas at Panipat has gone down as a disastrous and shameful event in the annals of Indian history. The publication of Vishwas Patil's Marathi novel Panipat (1988) and its subsequent translations into Hindi and other regional languages went a long way in changing the perspective of its readers towards this historical episode. Although the forces and allies of the Afghan ruler Ahmad Shah Abdali wangled victory, it was evident that the Afghan empire, too, was overwhelmed by the buoyant Maratha forces. Today, the Third Battle of Panipat is seen as an event that reminds us of the resilient and unyielding spirit of the Maratha soldiers. In a sense, it encapsulates an epoch of both belief and incredulity.

The first two battles of Panipat mark the beginning of the spread of the Mughals in India, but the third battle, which was fought between the Marathas and the Durrani empire, is etched as one of the biggest and most significant battles in India in the 18th century.

The battle is noteworthy in terms of the war strategies adapted. The Marathas, led by Sadashiv Rao Bhau and his ally Ibrahim Gardi, used European fighting tactics; Abdali's army made up for their lack of field artillery in brutally effective mobile artillery —the tough foot soldiers. The Maratha plan didn't work out well, and soon, the majority of the army was defeated by dwindling resources and grave hunger. The narrative effectively highlights certain aspects like the lack of the Marathas' ability to persuade the masses, the capability of the Afghans to lead from the front and the role of women and children in the entire ritual of war. It also narrates how the great battle changed the power equations in India. Though the Afghans emerged victorious in this war, they couldn't rule the country.

Colour of bloodshed

The war was given a religious colour and the chants that reverberated on the grounds of Panipat embraced the gods in a manner that was more poisonous than spiritual. The distinction between right and wrong had vanished. Vilification campaigns were carried out on a great spree, and there was a possibility, though several attempts were made, of arriving at a truce. The battle did not decide who was to rule India but rather who was not to. This furthered the already existing gaps between different sects, and strong animosities were now built within the armies; and these internal squabbles, in a way, unintentionally paved a clear path for the rise of British power in India in the late 18th century.

If the religious tinge smote hearts, the tales of betrayals deepened the wounds. Ultimately, this turned out to be the Marathas' biggest weakness. Patil strikingly describes how Nature itself seemed to be against the warriors. The Yamuna and her tides become symbolic of the horrific future of the Maratha empire. Not that the Afghans did not suffer because of the vagaries of nature — the scarcity of food and fodder and the depleting treasury of both empires only bore further testimony to the bravery of the soldiers.

The narrative is both authentic and emotionally charged; Patil manages to bring out the wisdom as well as the foolishness of war.

The unhurried and articulate storytelling style grips the attention of the readers. Nadeem Khan, the translator, has done a fine job of retaining the flavour of the original as much as possible. Panipat deserves a read for its meticulous retelling of history through fiction.

Read more at: <https://www.deccanherald.com/sunday-herald/sunday-herald-books/handcuffed-by-history-813286.html>

Exercise:

I. Write a Review on any of the following books:

1. Pride and Prejudice – Jane Austen
2. Life of Pi – Yann Martel
3. To Kill a Mockingbird – Harper Lee
4. The God of Small Things – Arundhati Roy
5. The Catcher in the Rye – J.D. Salinger
6. The Guide – R.K. Narayan
7. The Great Gatsby – F. Scott Fitzgerald
8. The Inheritance of Loss – Kiran Desai
9. The Bluest Eye – Toni Morrison
10. Moby Dick or The Whale by Herman Melville
11. Anne Frank: The Diary of a Young Girl by Anne Frank
12. The Shadow Lines – Amitav Ghosh
13. Jane Eyre – Charlotte Brontë
14. Harry Potter and the Sorcerer's Stone by J.K. Rowling
15. Yayati by Girish Karnad
16. Murder on the Orient Express by Agatha Christie
17. The Fault in Our Stars by John Green
18. Pygmalion by George Bernard Shaw
19. The Wonderful Wizard of OZ by L. Frank Baum
20. Train to Pakistan by Khushwant Singh

II. Answer the following questions:

1. What are the main objectives of writing a book review?
2. What is the key difference between a book review and a book report?
3. What are the '5Ws and 1H' that a reviewer should highlight?
4. Discuss any two tips for writing a review.
5. What should a reviewer do to ensure accuracy and coherence in writing?
6. What is the importance of proofreading in a review?
7. What is the format to present Bibliographic details of a book?
8. What are the features of a good review?
9. How does the title become important in a book?
10. Explain the significance of the evaluative language in the Review Writing.

Points to Remember:

- Do not give away the story.
- Pay attention to language and grammar usage
- Give a summary of the main points of the book, quoting and paraphrasing key phrases from the author
- Combine the skills of describing, analysing and expressing your own reactions to how the book tried to achieve its purpose
- In a critique, you may want to express criticism by saying what the author should have done but did not do.

NOTE:

Book Review exercise is for Internal Assessment only. Any one book from the above given list must be read and reviewed by the students. This activity carries 5 Marks and to be consider while awarding Internal Marks.

SUMMATIVE ASSESSMENT QUESTION PAPER PATTERN
B.C.A. AND OTHER PROGRAMMES UNDER FACULTY OF COMPUTER
APPLICATIONS IV SEMESTER GENERAL ENGLISH

Time: 3 hours

Max. Marks: 80

Instruction: *Read the instructions Answer all the questions*

UNIT – 1 LITERARY SKILLS (NOVELLA)

- | | | |
|-----|---|---------|
| I. | Answer in a page (Two questions out of Three) | 2x5=10 |
| II. | Answer in about Two – Three pages (One question out of Two) | 1x10=10 |

(SHORT STORY, SPEECH and POEM)

- | | | |
|------|---|--------|
| III. | Answer in a page (Four questions out of Five) | 4x5=20 |
|------|---|--------|
- (Answer from all the three literary texts)*

UNIT – 2 COMMUNICATIVE SKILLS

- | | | |
|-------|--|--------|
| IV. | Listening and speaking skills | |
| | a) Interview Skills | 1x5=5 |
| | b) Group Discussion | 1x5=5 |
| V. | Comprehension Passage | 2x5=10 |
| VI. | Report Writing (Events) | 1x5=5 |
| VII. | Summarizing | 1x5=5 |
| VIII. | Email Etiquettes | 1x5=5 |
| IX. | Research Questionnaire (Survey Questions to the respondents) | 1x5=5 |

SUMMATIVE ASSESSMENT
MODEL QUESTION PAPER
B.C.A. AND OTHER PROGRAMMES UNDER THE FACULTY OF COMPUTER
APPLICATIONS
IV SEMESTER

GENERAL ENGLISH

Time:3 hours

Max.Marks:80

Instruction: *Read the instructions*

Answer all the questions

UNIT –I
LITERARY SKILLS
(NOVELLA)

I. Answer any two of the following questions in about a page. (2x5 =10)

1. How does Melville use historical events of mutiny as a backdrop for the novel?
2. What is the significance of the poem “Billy in the Darbies” in the novella’s conclusion?
3. Briefly describe the main traits of John Claggart.

II. Answer any one of the following questions in about two to three pages. (1x10 =10)

1. Examine the theme of justice vs. duty in the novella. How does Melville show the tension between legal obligation and human compassion?
2. Analyze the character of Billy Budd, highlighting how he represents innocence and simplicity in the novella.

III. Answer any four of the following questions in about a page each. (4x5=20)
(Answer from all the three literary texts)

1. How does the story *Friends* address themes of mortality and loss?
2. Write about the three main visions of India that Dr. A. P. J. Abdul Kalam talks about in his speech.
3. What is the significance of the ending Faith’s final reflection after Selena’s death in *Friends*?
4. What is the significance of the repetitive line “But where shall we go to-day my dear, but where shall we go to-day?” the poem *Refugee Blues*?
5. What message does Sarojini Naidu convey through the poem about the lives and works of Indian Weavers?

UNIT II

Communication Skills (LSRW Skills)

IV. Answer the following:

- a) Give a self- introduction as a candidate applying for the post of Web Developer. 5
- b) Write about any FIVE skills required to participate effectively in a Group Discussion. 5

V. Read the following passage and answer the questions given below: (2x5=10)

The great Acharyas have said that, having discovered a great goal, surrender yourself to that goal and act towards it, drawing your inspiration from that goal, whereby you will get a new column of energy. Do not allow this energy to be dissipated in the futile memories of past regrets or failures, nor in the imagined sorrow of the future or the present and thus bring the entire energy focused into activity. That is the creative action in the world outside. Thereby, the individual who is till now considered most inefficient finds his way to the highest achievement and success.

This is said very easily in a second. But in order to train our mind to this attitude, it needs considerable training because we have already trained the mind wrongly to such an extent that we have become perfect in imperfection. Not knowing the art of action, we have been master artists in doing the wrong thing. The totality of activity will bring the country to a wrong end indeed.

If each one is given a car, to achieve an ideal socialist pattern, and nobody knows driving but everybody starts driving, what would be the condition on the road? Everybody has an equal right on the public road. Then each car must necessarily dash against the other, and there is bound to be a jumble. This seems to be the very apt pattern of life that we are heading to. Every one of us is a vehicle. We know how to go forward. The point is that intellect is very powerful and everyone is driving, but nobody seems to know how to control the mental energy and direct it properly or guide it to a proper destination.

1. What do the Acharyas advise individuals to do?
2. What is the highest creative action according to the passage?
3. Why do we need a lot of training to develop the correct attitude of mind?
4. What example does the author use to illustrate the dangers of untrained action?
5. What point does the author make about the nature of intellect?

VI. Answer any One of the following

1x5=5

- a) Your College NSS Wing in association with the Red Cross Society, organised a blood donation camp on 18th September 2019, in your college. Draft an event report using the following (number of donors, preliminary check, and Certificates were given away to the donors)

OR

- b) Write a report on a Field Visit to a Infosys, Mysore. Include details of date, location, observations made, and significance of the visit

VII. Summarize the following passage and suggest a suitable title:

(5)

The increase in global temperatures has led to more frequent and severe weather events, posing a significant threat to ecosystems and human societies. One of the major impacts of climate change is the rise in sea levels, which results from the melting of polar ice caps and glaciers. Coastal areas are particularly vulnerable, as they face higher risks of flooding, storm surges, and erosion. Additionally, the warming atmosphere can hold more moisture, leading to intense and unpredictable precipitation patterns. This variability can cause both severe droughts and devastating floods, affecting agricultural productivity and water resources.

The effects of climate change are widespread, influencing not only the environment but also the socio-economic stability of communities. For example, changing weather patterns can disrupt food supply chains, increase the prevalence of diseases, and force people to migrate from their homes. To mitigate these effects, countries are investing in adaptive infrastructure, developing early warning systems, and implementing policies to reduce greenhouse gas emissions. The collaboration between governments, scientists, and communities is crucial to building resilience against the adverse impacts of climate change. By taking proactive measures, societies can better prepare for the challenges posed by a changing climate and work towards a more sustainable future.

- VIII. Draft a request mail to your college librarian asking for the extension of the return deadline.**

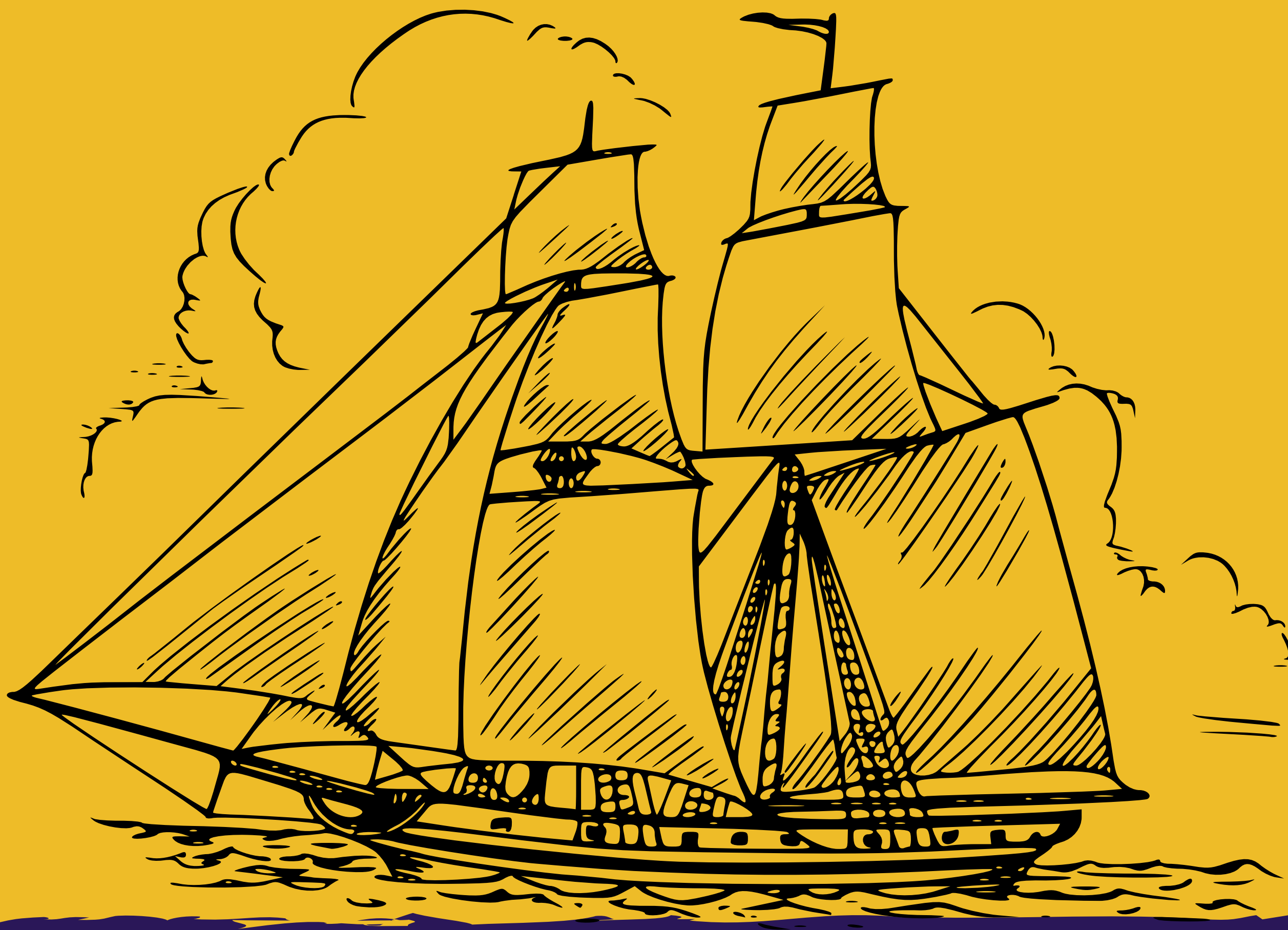
5

Or

Draft a complaint mail to the customer support team at Amazon to replace the defective watch received.

- IX. You are conducting a research study titled "Impact of Social Media on Students' Academic Performance." Frame any five relevant survey questions that you would include in your research questionnaire.**

BILLY BUDD, SAILOR



BY HERMAN MELVILLE

IV SEMESTER BCA TEXTBOOK
(NOVELLA COPY)

Herman Melville

Billy Budd, Sailor

An inside narrative

London Bombay
Constable and Company, Ltd.

1924

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2020

Chapter 1

In the time before steamships, or then more frequently than now, a stroller along the docks of any considerable sea-port would occasionally have his attention arrested by a group of bronzed mariners, man-of-war's men or merchant-sailors in holiday attire ashore on liberty. In certain instances they would flank, or, like a body-guard quite surround some superior figure of their own class, moving along with them like Aldebaran among the lesser lights of his constellation. That signal object was the "Handsome Sailor" of the less prosaic time alike of the military and merchant navies. With no perceptible trace of the vainglorious about him, rather with the off-hand unaffectedness of natural regality, he seemed to accept the spontaneous homage of his shipmates.

A somewhat remarkable instance recurs to me. In Liverpool, now half a century ago, I saw under the shadow of the great dingy street-wall of Prince's Dock (an obstruction long since removed) a common sailor, so intensely black that he must needs have been a native African of the unadulterate blood of Ham. A symmetric figure much above the average height. The two ends of a gay silk handkerchief thrown loose about the neck danced upon the displayed ebony of his chest; in his ears were big hoops of gold, and a Scotch Highland bonnet with a tartan band set off his shapely head. It was a hot noon in July; and his face, lustrous with perspiration, beamed with barbaric good humor. In jovial sallies right and left, his white teeth flashing into he rollicked along, the centre of a company of his shipmates. These were made up of such an assortment of tribes and complexions as would have well fitted them to be marched up by Anacharsis Cloots before the bar of the first French Assembly as Representatives of the Human Race. At each spontaneous tribute rendered by the wayfarers to this black pagod of a fellow—the tribute of a pause and stare, and less frequent an exclamation—the motley retinue showed that they took that sort of pride in the evoker of it which the Assyrian priests doubtless showed for their grand sculptured Bull when the faithful prostrated themselves.

To return. If in some cases a bit of a nautical Murat in setting forth his person ashore, the Handsome Sailor of the period in question evinced nothing of the dandified Billy-be-Damn, an amusing character all but extinct now, but occasionally to be encountered, and in a form yet more amusing than the original, at the tiller of the boats on the tempestuous Erie Canal or, more likely, vaporing in the grogeries along the tow-path. Invariably a proficient in his perilous calling, he was also more or less of a mighty boxer or wrestler. It was strength and beauty. Tales of his prowess were recited. Ashore he was the champion; afloat the spokesman; on every suitable occasion always foremost. Close-reefing top-sails in a gale, there he was, astride the weather yard-arm-end, foot in the Flemish horse as "stirrup," both

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hands tugging at the “earring” as at a bridle, in very much the attitude of young Alexander curbing the fiery Bucephalus. A superb figure, tossed up as by the horns of Taurus against the thunderous sky, cheerily hallooing to the strenuous file along the spar.

The moral nature was seldom out of keeping with the physical make. Indeed, except as toned by the former, the comeliness and power, always attractive in masculine conjunction, hardly could have drawn the sort of honest homage the Handsome Sailor in some examples received from his less gifted associates.

Such a cynosure, at least in aspect, and something such too in nature, though with important variations made apparent as the story proceeds, was welkin-eyed Billy Budd, or Baby Budd, as more familiarly under circumstances hereafter to be given he at last came to be called, aged twenty-one, a foretopman of the British fleet toward the close of the last decade of the eighteenth century. It was not very long prior to the time of the narration that follows that he had entered the King’s Service, having been impressed on the Narrow Seas from a homeward-bound English merchantman into a seventy-four outward-bound, H.M.S. *Indomitable*; which ship, as was not unusual in those hurried days, having been obliged to put to sea short of her proper complement of men. Plump upon Billy at first sight in the gangway the boarding officer Lieutenant Ratcliff pounced, even before the merchantman’s crew was formally mustered on the quarter-deck for his deliberate inspection. And him only he elected. For whether it was because the other men when ranged before him showed to ill advantage after Billy, or whether he had some scruples in view of the merchantman being rather short-handed, however it might be, the officer contented himself with his first spontaneous choice. To the surprise of the ship’s company, though much to the Lieutenant’s satisfaction, Billy made no demur. But, indeed, any demur would have been as idle as the protest of a goldfinch popped into a cage.

Noting this uncomplaining acquiescence, all but cheerful one might say, the shipmates turned a surprised glance of silent reproach at the sailor. The Shipmaster was one of those worthy mortals found in every vocation, even the humbler ones—the sort of person whom everybody agrees in calling “a respectable man.” And—nor so strange to report as it may appear to be—though a ploughman of the troubled waters, life-long contending with the intractable elements, there was nothing this honest soul at heart loved better than simple peace and quiet. For the rest, he was fifty or thereabouts, a little inclined to corpulence, a prepossessing face, unwhiskered, and of an agreeable color—a rather full face, humanely intelligent in expression. On a fair day with a fair wind and all going well, a certain musical chime in his voice seemed to be the veritable unobstructed outcome of the innermost man. He had much prudence, much conscientiousness, and there were occasions when these virtues were the cause of overmuch

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disquietude in him. On a passage, so long as his craft was in any proximity to land, no sleep for Captain Graveling. He took to heart those serious responsibilities not so heavily borne by some shipmasters.

Now while Billy Budd was down in the forecastle getting his kit together, the *Indomitable's* Lieutenant, burly and bluff, nowise disconcerted by Captain Graveling's omitting to proffer the customary hospitalities on an occasion so unwelcome to him, an omission simply caused by preoccupation of thought, unceremoniously invited himself into the cabin, and also to a flask from the spirit-locker, a receptacle which his experienced eye instantly discovered. In fact he was one of those sea-dogs in whom all the hardship and peril of naval life in the great prolonged wars of his time never impaired the natural instinct for sensuous enjoyment. His duty he always faithfully did; but duty is sometimes a dry obligation, and he was for irrigating its aridity, whensoever possible, with a fertilizing decoction of strong waters. For the cabin's proprietor there was nothing left but to play the part of the enforced host with whatever grace and alacrity were practicable. As necessary adjuncts to the flask, he silently placed tumbler and water-jug before the irrepressible guest. But excusing himself from partaking just then, he dismally watched the unembarrassed officer deliberately diluting his grog a little, then tossing it off in three swallows, pushing the empty tumbler away, yet not so far as to be beyond easy reach, at the same time settling himself in his seat and smacking his lips with high satisfaction, looking straight at the host.

These proceedings over, the Master broke the silence; and there lurked a rueful reproach in the tone of his voice: "Lieutenant, you are going to take my best man from me, the jewel of 'em."

"Yes, I know," rejoined the other, immediately drawing back the tumbler preliminary to a replenishing; "Yes, I know. Sorry."

"Beg pardon, but you don't understand, Lieutenant. See here now. Before I shipped that young fellow, my forecastle was a rat-pit of quarrels. It was black times, I tell you, aboard the *Rights* here. I was worried to that degree my pipe had no comfort for me. But Billy came; and it was like a Catholic priest striking peace in an Irish shindy. Not that he preached to them or said or did anything in particular; but a virtue went out of him, sugaring the sour ones. They took to him like hornets to treacle; all but the buffer of the gang, the big shaggy chap with the fire-red whiskers. He indeed out of envy, perhaps, of the newcomer, and thinking such a 'sweet and pleasant fellow,' as he mockingly designated him to the others, could hardly have the spirit of a game-cock, must needs bestir himself in trying to get up an ugly row with him. Billy forebore with him and reasoned with him in a pleasant way—he is something like myself, Lieutenant, to whom aught like a quarrel is hateful—but nothing served. So, in the second dog-watch one day the Red Whiskers in presence of the others, under pretence of showing Billy just whence a sirloin steak was cut—for the fellow had once been a butcher—insultingly gave him a dig under the

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ribs. Quick as lightning Billy let fly his arm. I dare say he never meant to do quite as much as he did, but anyhow he gave the burly fool a terrible drubbing. It took about half a minute, I should think. And, lord bless you, the lubber was astonished at the celerity. And will you believe it, Lieutenant, the Red Whiskers now really loves Billy—loves him, or is the biggest hypocrite that ever I heard of. But they all love him. Some of 'em do his washing, darn his old trousers for him; the carpenter is at odd times making a pretty little chest of drawers for him. Anybody will do anything for Billy Budd; and it's the happy family here. But now, Lieutenant, if that young fellow goes—I know how it will be aboard the *Rights*. Not again very soon shall I, coming up from dinner, lean over the capstan smoking a quiet pipe—no, not very soon again, I think. Ay, Lieutenant, you are going to take away the jewel of 'em; you are going to take away my peacemaker!" And with that the good soul had really some ado in checking a rising sob.

"Well," said the officer who had listened with amused interest to all this, and now waxing merry with his tippie; "Well, blessed are the peacemakers, especially the fighting peacemakers! And such are the seventy-four beauties some of which you see poking their noses out of the port-holes of yonder war-ship lying-to for me," pointing thro' the cabin window at the *Indomitable*. "But courage! don't look so downhearted, man. Why, I pledge you in advance the royal approbation. Rest assured that His Majesty will be delighted to know that in a time when his hard tack is not sought for by sailors with such avidity as should be; a time also when some shipmasters privily resent the borrowing from them a tar or two for the service; His Majesty, I say, will be delighted to learn that one shipmaster at least cheerfully surrenders to the King, the flower of his flock, a sailor who with equal loyalty makes no dissent.—But where's my beauty? Ah," looking through the cabin's open door, "Here he comes; and, by Jove—lugging along his chest—Apollo with his portmanteau!—My man," stepping out to him, "you can't take that big box aboard a war-ship. The boxes there are mostly shot-boxes. Put your duds in a bag, lad. Boot and saddle for the cavalryman, bag and hammock for the man-of-war's man."

The transfer from chest to bag was made. And, after seeing his man into the cutter and then following him down, the Lieutenant pushed off from the *Rights-of-Man*. That was the merchant-ship's name; tho' by her master and crew abbreviated in sailor fashion into *The Rights*. The hard-headed Dundee owner was a staunch admirer of Thomas Paine whose book in rejoinder to Burke's arraignment of the French Revolution had then been published for some time and had gone everywhere. In christening his vessel after the title of Paine's volume, the man of Dundee was something like his contemporary shipowner, Stephen Girard of Philadelphia, whose sympathies, alike with his native land and its liberal philosophers, he evinced by naming his ships after Voltaire, Diderot, and so forth.

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But now, when the boat swept under the merchantman's stern, and officer and oarsmen were noting—some bitterly and others with a grin,—the name emblazoned there; just then it was that the new recruit jumped up from the bow where the coxswain had directed him to sit, and waving his hat to his silent shipmates sorrowfully looking over at him from the taffrail, bade the lads a genial good-bye. Then, making a salutation as to the ship herself, "And good-bye to you too, old *Rights-of-Man*."

"Down, Sir!" roared the Lieutenant, instantly assuming all the rigour of his rank, though with difficulty repressing a smile.

To be sure, Billy's action was a terrible breach of naval decorum. But in that decorum he had never been instructed; in consideration of which the Lieutenant would hardly have been so energetic in reproof but for the concluding farewell to the ship. This he rather took as meant to convey a covert sally on the new recruit's part, a sly slur at impressment in general, and that of himself in especial. And yet, more likely, if satire it was in effect, it was hardly so by intention, for Billy, tho' happily endowed with the gayety of high health, youth, and a free heart, was yet by no means of a satirical turn. The will to it and the sinister dexterity were alike wanting. To deal in double meanings and insinuations of any sort was quite foreign to his nature.

As to his enforced enlistment, that he seemed to take pretty much as he was wont to take any vicissitude of weather. Like the animals, though no philosopher, he was, without knowing it, practically a fatalist. And, it may be, that he rather liked this adventurous turn in his affairs, which promised an opening into novel scenes and martial excitements.

Aboard the *Indomitable* our merchant-sailor was forthwith rated as an able-seaman and assigned to the starboard watch of the fore-top. He was soon at home in the service, not at all disliked for his unpretentious good looks and a sort of genial happy-go-lucky air. No merrier man in his mess: in marked contrast to certain other individuals included like himself among the impressed portion of the ship's company; for these when not actively employed were sometimes, and more particularly in the last dog-watch when the drawing near of twilight induced revery, apt to fall into a saddish mood which in some partook of sullenness. But they were not so young as our foretopman, and no few of them must have known a hearth of some sort; others may have had wives and children left, too probably, in uncertain circumstances, and hardly any but must have had acknowledged kith and kin, while for Billy, as will shortly be seen, his entire family was practically invested in himself.

Chapter 2

Though our new-made foretopman was well received in the top

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and on the gun decks, hardly here was he that cynosure he had previously been among those minor ship's companies of the merchant marine, with which companies only had he hitherto consorted.

He was young; and despite his all but fully developed frame, in aspect looked even younger than he really was, owing to a lingering adolescent expression in the as yet smooth face, all but feminine in purity of natural complexion, but where, thanks to his seagoing, the lily was quite suppressed and the rose had some ado visibly to flush through the tan.

To one essentially such a novice in the complexities of factitious life, the abrupt transition from his former and simpler sphere to the ampler and more knowing world of a great war-ship; this might well have abashed him had there been any conceit or vanity in his composition. Among her miscellaneous multitude, the *Indomitable* mustered several individuals who, however inferior in grade, were of no common natural stamp, sailors more signally susceptible of that air which continuous martial discipline and repeated presence in battle can in some degree impart even to the average man. As the Handsome Sailor, Billy Budd's position aboard the seventy-four was something analogous to that of a rustic beauty transplanted from the provinces and brought into competition with the highborn dames of the court. But this change of circumstances he scarce noted. As little did he observe that something about him provoked an ambiguous smile in one or two harder faces among the blue-jackets. Nor less unaware was he of the peculiar favorable effect his person and demeanour had upon the more intelligent gentlemen of the quarter-deck. Nor could this well have been otherwise. Cast in a mould peculiar to the finest physical examples of those Englishmen in whom the Saxon strain would seem not at all to partake of any Norman or other admixture, he showed in face that humane look of reposeful good nature which the Greek sculptor in some instances gave to his heroic strong man, Hercules. But this again was subtly modified by another and pervasive quality. The ear, small and shapely, the arch of the foot, the curve in mouth and nostril, even the indurated hand dyed to the orange-tawny of the toucan's bill, a hand telling alike of the halyards and tar-bucket; but, above all, something in the mobile expression, and every chance attitude and movement, something suggestive of a mother eminently favored by Love and the Graces; all this strangely indicated a lineage in direct contradiction to his lot. The mysteriousness here became less mysterious through a matter-of-fact elicited when Billy, at the capstan, was being formally mustered into the service. Asked by the officer, a small brisk little gentleman, as it chanced among other questions, his place of birth, he replied, "Please, Sir, I don't know."

"Don't know where you were born?—Who was your father?"

"God knows, Sir."

Struck by the straightforward simplicity of these replies, the officer next asked, "Do you know anything about your beginning?"

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"No, Sir. But I have heard that I was found in a pretty silklined basket hanging one morning from the knocker of a good man's door in Bristol."

"Found say you? Well," throwing back his head and looking up and down the new recruit; "Well, it turns out to have been a pretty good find. Hope they'll find some more like you, my man; the fleet sadly needs them."

Yes, Billy Budd was a foundling, a presumable by-blow, and, evidently, no ignoble one. Noble descent was as evident in him as in a blood horse.

For the rest, with little or no sharpness of faculty or any trace of the wisdom of the serpent, nor yet quite a dove, he possessed that kind and degree of intelligence going along with the unconventional rectitude of a sound human creature, one to whom not yet has been proffered the questionable apple of knowledge. He was illiterate; he could not read, but he could sing, and like the illiterate nightingale was sometimes the composer of his own song.

Of self-consciousness he seemed to have little or none, or about as much as we may reasonably impute to a dog of Saint Bernard's breed.

Habitually living with the elements and knowing little more of the land than as a beach, or, rather, that portion of the terraqueous globe providentially set apart for dance-houses, doxies and tapsters, in short what sailors call a "fiddlers'-green," his simple nature remained unsophisticated by those moral obliquities which are not in every case incompatible with that manufacturable thing known as respectability. But are sailors, frequenters of "fiddlers'-greens," without vices? No; but less often than with landsmen do their vices, so called, partake of crookedness of heart, seeming less to proceed from viciousness than exuberance of vitality after long constraint; frank manifestations in accordance with natural law. By his original constitution aided by the cooperating influences of his lot, Billy in many respects was little more than a sort of upright barbarian, much such perhaps as Adam presumably might have been ere the urbane Serpent wriggled himself into his company.

And here be it submitted that apparently going to corroborate the doctrine of man's fall, a doctrine now popularly ignored, it is observable that where certain virtues pristine and unadulterate peculiarly characterize anybody in the external uniform of civilization, they will upon scrutiny seem not to be derived from custom or convention, but rather to be out of keeping with these, as if indeed exceptionally transmitted from a period prior to Cain's city and citified man. The character marked by such qualities has to an unvitiated taste an untampered-with flavor like that of berries, while the man thoroughly civilized, even in a fair specimen of the breed, has to the same moral palate a questionable smack as of a compounded wine. To any stray

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inheritor of these primitive qualities found, like Caspar Hauser, wandering dazed in any Christian capital of our time, the good-natured poet's famous invocation, near two thousand years ago, of the good rustic out of his latitude in the Rome of the Cesars, still appropriately holds:—

“Honest and poor, faithful in word and thought,
What has thee, Fabian, to the city brought?”

Though our Handsome Sailor had as much of masculine beauty as one can expect anywhere to see; nevertheless, like the beautiful woman in one of Hawthorne's minor tales, there was just one thing amiss in him. No visible blemish, indeed, as with the lady; no, but an occasional liability to a vocal defect. Though in the hour of elemental uproar or peril he was everything that a sailor should be, yet under sudden provocation of strong heart-feeling, his voice otherwise singularly musical, as if expressive of the harmony within, was apt to develop an organic hesitancy, in fact, more or less of a stutter or even worse. In this particular Billy was a striking instance that the arch interferer, the envious marplot of Eden, still has more or less to do with every human consignment to this planet of earth. In every case, one way or another he is sure to slip in his little card, as much as to remind us—I too have a hand here.

The avowal of such an imperfection in the Handsome Sailor should be evidence not alone that he is not presented as a conventional hero, but also that the story in which he is the main figure is no romance.

Chapter 3

At the time of Billy Budd's arbitrary enlistment into the *Indomitable* that ship was on her way to join the Mediterranean fleet. No long time elapsed before the junction was effected. As one of that fleet the seventy-four participated in its movements, tho' at times, on account of her superior sailing qualities, in the absence of frigates, despatched on separate duty as a scout and at times on less temporary service. But with all this the story has little concernment, restricted as it is to the inner life of one particular ship and the career of an individual sailor.

It was the summer of 1797. In the April of that year had occurred the commotion at Spithead followed in May by a second and yet more serious outbreak in the fleet at the Nore. The latter is known, and without exaggeration in the epithet, as the Great Mutiny. It was indeed a demonstration more menacing to England than the contemporary manifestoes and conquering and proselyting armies of the French Directory. To the British Empire the Nore Mutiny was what a strike in

the fire-brigade would be to London threatened by general arson. In a crisis when the kingdom might well have anticipated the famous signal that some years later published along the naval line of battle what it was that upon occasion England expected of Englishmen; that was the time when at the mast-heads of the three-deckers and seventy-fours moored in her own roadstead—a fleet, the right arm of a Power then all but the sole free conservative one of the Old World—the blue-jackets, to be numbered by thousands, ran up with huzzas the British colors with the union and cross wiped out; by that cancellation transmuting the flag of founded law and freedom defined, into the enemy's red meteor of unbridled and unbounded revolt. Reasonable discontent growing out of practical grievances in the fleet had been ignited into irrational combustion, as by live cinders blown across the Channel from France in flames.

The event converted into irony for a time those spirited strains of Dibdin—as a song-writer no mean auxiliary to the English Government at the European conjuncture—strains celebrating, among other things, the patriotic devotion of the British tar: “And as for my life, ’tis the King’s!”

Such an episode in the Island's grand naval story her naval historians naturally abridge; one of them (G.P.R. James) candidly acknowledging that fain would he pass it over did not “impartiality forbid fastidiousness.” And yet his mention is less a narration than a reference, having to do hardly at all with details. Nor are these readily to be found in the libraries. Like some other events in every age befalling states everywhere, including America, the Great Mutiny was of such character that national pride along with views of policy would fain shade it off into the historical background. Such events can not be ignored, but there is a considerate way of historically treating them. If a well-constituted individual refrains from blazoning aught amiss or calamitous in his family, a nation in the like circumstance may without reproach be equally discreet.

Though after parleyings between Government and the ringleaders, and concessions by the former as to some glaring abuses, the first uprising—that at Spithead—with difficulty was put down, or matters for the time pacified; yet at the Nore the unforeseen renewal of insurrection on a yet larger scale, and emphasized in the conferences that ensued by demands deemed by the authorities not only inadmissible but aggressively insolent, indicated—if the Red Flag did not sufficiently do so—what was the spirit animating the men. Final suppression, however, there was; but only made possible perhaps by the unswerving loyalty of the marine corps and voluntary resumption of loyalty among influential sections of the crews.

To some extent the Nore Mutiny may be regarded as analogous to the distempering irruption of contagious fever in a frame constitutionally sound, and which anon throws it off.

At all events, of these thousands of mutineers were some of the

tars who not so very long afterwards—whether wholly prompted thereto by patriotism, or pugnacious instinct, or by both—helped to win a coronet for Nelson at the Nile, and the naval crown of crowns for him at Trafalgar. To the mutineers those battles, and especially Trafalgar, were a plenary absolution and a grand one: For all that goes to make up scenic naval display, heroic magnificence in arms, those battles, especially Trafalgar, stand unmatched in human annals.

Chapter 4

In this matter of writing, resolve as one may to keep to the main road, some by-paths have an enticement not readily to be withstood. I am going to err into such a by-path. If the reader will keep me company I shall be glad. At the least we can promise ourselves that pleasure which is wickedly said to be in sinning, for a literary sin the divergence will be.

Very likely it is no new remark that the inventions of our time have at last brought about a change in sea-warfare in degree corresponding to the revolution in all warfare effected by the original introduction from China into Europe of gunpowder. The first European fire-arm, a clumsy contrivance, was, as is well known, scouted by no few of the knights as a base implement, good enough peradventure for weavers too craven to stand up crossing steel with steel in frank fight. But as ashore, knightly valor, tho' shorn of its blazonry, did not cease with the knights, neither on the seas, though nowadays in encounters there a certain kind of displayed gallantry be fallen out of date as hardly applicable under changed circumstances, did the nobler qualities of such naval magnates as Don John of Austria, Doria, Van Tromp, Jean Bart, the long line of British Admirals and the American Decatur of 1812 become obsolete with their wooden walls.

Nevertheless, to anybody who can hold the Present at its worth without being inappreciative of the Past, it may be forgiven, if to such an one the solitary old hulk at Portsmouth, Nelson's *Victory*, seems to float there, not alone as the decaying monument of a fame incorruptible, but also as a poetic reproach, softened by its picturesqueness, to the *Monitors* and yet mightier hulls of the European iron-clads. And this not altogether because such craft are unsightly, unavoidably lacking the symmetry and grand lines of the old battle-ships, but equally for other reasons.

There are some, perhaps, who while not altogether inaccessible to that poetic reproach just alluded to, may yet on behalf of the new order, be disposed to parry it; and this to the extent of iconoclasm, if need be. For example, prompted by the sight of the star inserted in the *Victory's* quarter-deck designating the spot where the Great Sailor fell, these martial utilitarians may suggest considerations implying that

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Nelson's ornate publication of his person in battle was not only unnecessary, but not military, nay, savored of foolhardiness and vanity. They may add, too, that at Trafalgar it was in effect nothing less than a challenge to death; and death came; and that but for his bravado the victorious Admiral might possibly have survived the battle; and so, instead of having his sagacious dying injunctions overruled by his immediate successor in command, he himself, when the contest was decided, might have brought his shattered fleet to anchor, a proceeding which might have averted the deplorable loss of life by shipwreck in the elemental tempest that followed the martial one.

Well, should we set aside the more disputable point whether for various reasons it was possible to anchor the fleet, then plausibly enough the Benthamites of war may urge the above. But the might-have-been is but boggy ground to build on. And, certainly, in foresight as to the larger issue of an encounter, and anxious preparations for it—buoying the deadly way and mapping it out, as at Copenhagen—few commanders have been so painstakingly circumspect as this same reckless declarer of his person in fight.

Personal prudence even when dictated by quite other than selfish considerations surely is no special virtue in a military man; while an excessive love of glory, impassioning a less burning impulse, the honest sense of duty, is the first. If the name Wellington is not so much of a trumpet to the blood as the simpler name Nelson, the reason for this may perhaps be inferred from the above. Alfred in his funeral ode on the victor of Waterloo ventures not to call him the greatest soldier of all time, tho' in the same ode he invokes Nelson as "the greatest sailor since our world began."

At Trafalgar, Nelson, on the brink of opening the fight, sat down and wrote his last brief will and testament. If under the presentiment of the most magnificent of all victories to be crowned by his own glorious death, a sort of priestly motive led him to dress his person in the jewelled vouchers of his own shining deeds; if thus to have adorned himself for the altar and the sacrifice were indeed vainglory, then affectation and fustian is each more heroic line in the great epics and dramas, since in such lines the poet but embodies in verse those exaltations of sentiment that a nature like Nelson, the opportunity being given, vitalizes into acts.

Chapter 5

Yes, the outbreak at the Nore was put down. But not every grievance was redressed. If the contractors, for example, were no longer permitted to ply some practices peculiar to their tribe everywhere, such as providing shoddy cloth, rations not sound, or false in the measure, not the less impressment, for one thing, went on. By custom

sanctioned for centuries, and judicially maintained by a Lord Chancellor as late as Mansfield, that mode of manning the fleet, a mode now fallen into a sort of abeyance but never formally renounced, it was not practicable to give up in those years. Its abrogation would have crippled the indispensable fleet, one wholly under canvas, no steam-power, its innumerable sails and thousands of cannon, everything in short, worked by muscle alone; a fleet the more insatiate in demand for men, because then multiplying its ships of all grades against contingencies present and to come of the convulsed Continent.

Discontent foreran the Two Mutinies, and more or less it lurk-ingly survived them. Hence it was not unreasonable to apprehend some return of trouble, sporadic or general. One instance of such apprehensions: In the same year with this story, Nelson, then Vice-Admiral Sir Horatio, being with the fleet off the Spanish coast, was directed by the Admiral in command to shift his pennant from the *Captain* to the *Theseus*; and for this reason: that the latter ship having newly arrived on the station from home where it had taken part in the Great Mutiny, danger was apprehended from the temper of the men; and it was thought that an officer like Nelson was the one, not indeed to terrorize the crew into base subjection, but to win them, by force of his mere presence, back to an allegiance if not as enthusiastic as his own, yet as true.

So it was that for a time on more than one quarter-deck anxiety did exist. At sea precautionary vigilance was strained against relapse. At short notice an engagement might come on. When it did, the lieutenants assigned to batteries felt it incumbent on them, in some instances, to stand with drawn swords behind the men working the guns.

Chapter 6

But on board the seventy-four in which Billy now swung his hammock, very little in the manner of the men and nothing obvious in the demeanour of the officers would have suggested to an ordinary observer that the Great Mutiny was a recent event. In their general bearing and conduct the commissioned officers of a warship naturally take their tone from the Commander, that is if he have that ascendancy of character that ought to be his.

Captain the Honorable Edward Fairfax Vere, to give his full title, was a bachelor of forty or thereabouts, a sailor of distinction even in a time prolific of renowned seamen. Though allied to the higher nobility, his advancement had not been altogether owing to influences connected with that circumstance. He had seen much service, been in various engagements, always acquitting himself as an officer mindful of the welfare of his men, but never tolerating an infraction of dis-

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cipline; thoroughly versed in the science of his profession, and intrepid to the verge of temerity, though never injudiciously so. For his gallantry in the West Indian waters as Flag-Lieutenant under Rodney in that Admiral's crowning victory over De Grasse, he was made a Post-Captain.

Ashore in the garb of a civilian, scarce anyone would have taken him for a sailor, more especially that he never garnished unprofessional talk with nautical terms, and grave in his bearing, evinced little appreciation of mere humor. It was not out of keeping with these traits that on a passage when nothing demanded his paramount action, he was the most undemonstrative of men. Any landsman observing this gentleman, not conspicuous by his stature and wearing no pronounced insignia, emerging from his cabin to the open deck, and noting the silent deference of the officers retiring to leeward, might have taken him for the King's guest, a civilian aboard the King's-ship, some highly honorable discreet envoy on his way to an important post. But in fact this unobtrusiveness of demeanour may have proceeded from a certain unaffected modesty of manhood sometimes accompanying a resolute nature, a modesty evinced at all times not calling for pronounced action, and which shown in any rank of life suggests a virtue aristocratic in kind. As with some others engaged in various departments of the world's more heroic activities, Captain Vere, though practical enough upon occasion, would at times betray a certain dreaminess of mood. Standing alone on the weather-side of the quarter-deck, one hand holding by the rigging, he would absently gaze off at the blank sea. At the presentation to him then of some minor matter interrupting the current of his thoughts he would show more or less irascibility; but instantly he would control it.

In the navy he was popularly known by the appellation—Starry Vere. How such a designation happened to fall upon one who, whatever his sterling qualities, was without any brilliant ones was in this wise: A favorite kinsman, Lord Denton, a free-hearted fellow, had been the first to meet and congratulate him upon his return to England from his West Indian cruise; and but the day previous turning over a copy of Andrew Marvell's poems, had lighted, not for the first time however, upon the lines entitled *Appleton House*, the name of one of the seats of their common ancestor, a hero in the German wars of the seventeenth century, in which poem occur the lines,

"This 'tis to have been from the first
In a domestic heaven nursed,
Under the discipline severe
Of Fairfax and the starry Vere."

And so, upon embracing his cousin fresh from Rodney's great victory wherein he had played so gallant a part, brimming over with

just family pride in the sailor of their house, he exuberantly exclaimed, "Give ye joy, Ed; give ye joy, my starry Vere!" This got currency, and the novel prefix serving in familiar parlance readily to distinguish the *Indomitable's* Captain from another Vere his senior, a distant relative, an officer of like rank in the navy, it remained permanently attached to the surname.

Chapter 7

In view of the part that the Commander of the *Indomitable* plays in scenes shortly to follow, it may be well to fill out that sketch of his outlined in the previous chapter.

Aside from his qualities as a sea-officer, Captain Vere was an exceptional character. Unlike no few of England's renowned sailors, long and arduous service with signal devotion to it, had not resulted in absorbing and salting the entire man. He had a marked leaning toward everything intellectual. He loved books, never going to sea without a newly replenished library, compact but of the best. The isolated leisure, in some cases so wearisome, falling at intervals to commanders even during a war-cruise, never was tedious to Captain Vere. With nothing of that literary taste which less heeds the thing conveyed than the vehicle, his bias was toward those books to which every serious mind of superior order occupying any active post of authority in the world naturally inclines; books treating of actual men and events no matter of what era—history, biography and unconventional writers, who, free from cant and convention, like Montaigne, honestly and in the spirit of common sense philosophize upon realities. In this line of reading he found confirmation of his own more reasoned thoughts—confirmation which he had vainly sought in social converse, so that as touching most fundamental topics, there had got to be established in him some positive convictions, which he forefelt would abide in him essentially unmodified so long as his intelligent part remained unimpaired. In view of the troubled period in which his lot was cast this was well for him. His settled convictions were as a dyke against those invading waters of novel opinion, social, political and otherwise, which carried away as in a torrent no few minds in those days, minds by nature not inferior to his own. While other members of that aristocracy to which by birth he belonged were incensed at the innovators mainly because their theories were inimical to the privileged classes, not alone Captain Vere disinterestedly opposed them because they seemed to him incapable of embodiment in lasting institutions, but at war with the peace of the world and the true welfare of mankind.

With minds less stored than his and less earnest, some officers of his rank, with whom at times he would necessarily consort, found him lacking in the companionable quality, a dry and bookish gentleman, as they deemed. Upon any chance withdrawal from their company

one would be apt to say to another, something like this: "Vere is a noble fellow, Starry Vere. Spite the gazettes, Sir Horatio" (meaning him with the Lord title) "is at bottom scarce a better seaman or fighter. But between you and me now, don't you think there is a queer streak of the pedantic running thro' him? Yes, like the King's yarn in a coil of navy-rope?"

Some apparent ground there was for this sort of confidential criticism; since not only did the Captain's discourse never fall into the jocosely familiar, but in illustrating of any point touching the stirring personages and events of the time he would be as apt to cite some historic character or incident of antiquity as that he would cite from the moderns. He seemed unmindful of the circumstance that to his bluff company such remote allusions, however pertinent they might really be, were altogether alien to men whose reading was mainly confined to the journals. But considerateness in such matters is not easy to natures constituted like Captain Vere's. Their honesty prescribes to them directness, sometimes far-reaching like that of a migratory fowl that in its flight never heeds when it crosses a frontier.

Chapter 8

The lieutenants and other commissioned gentlemen forming Captain Vere's staff it is not necessary here to particularize, nor needs it to make any mention of any of the warrant-officers. But among the petty-officers was one who having much to do with the story, may as well be forthwith introduced. His portrait I essay, but shall never hit it. This was John Claggart, the Master-at-arms. But that sea-title may to landsmen seem somewhat equivocal. Originally, doubtless, that petty-officer's function was the instruction of the men in the use of arms, sword or cutlas. But very long ago, owing to the advance in gunnery making hand-to-hand encounters less frequent and giving to nitre and sulphur the preeminence over steel, that function ceased; the Master-at-arms of a great war-ship becoming a sort of Chief of Police, charged among other matters with the duty of preserving order on the populous lower gun decks.

Claggart was a man about five and thirty, somewhat spare and tall, yet of no ill figure upon the whole. His hand was too small and shapely to have been accustomed to hard toil. The face was a notable one; the features all except the chin cleanly cut as those on a Greek medallion; yet the chin, beardless as Tecumseh's, had something of strange protuberant heaviness in its make that recalled the prints of the Rev. Dr. Titus Oates, the historic deponent with the clerical drawl in the time of Charles II and the fraud of the alleged Popish Plot. It served Claggart in his office that his eye could cast a tutoring glance. His brow was of the sort phrenologically associated with more than average intellect; silken jet curls partly clustering over it, making a foil

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to the pallor below, a pallor tinged with a faint shade of amber akin to the hue of time-tinted marbles of old. This complexion, singularly contrasting with the red or deeply bronzed visages of the sailors, and in part the result of his official seclusion from the sunlight, tho' it was not exactly displeasing, nevertheless seemed to hint of something defective or abnormal in the constitution and blood. But his general aspect and manner were so suggestive of an education and career incongruous with his naval function that when not actively engaged in it he looked a man of high quality, social and moral, who for reasons of his own was keeping incog. Nothing was known of his former life. It might be that he was an Englishman; and yet there lurked a bit of accent in his speech suggesting that possibly he was not such by birth, but through naturalization in early childhood. Among certain grizzled sea-gossips of the gun decks and forecastle went a rumor perdue that the Master-at-arms was a chevalier who had volunteered into the King's Navy by way of compounding for some mysterious swindle whereof he had been arraigned at the King's Bench. The fact that nobody could substantiate this report was, of course, nothing against its secret currency. Such a rumor once started on the gun decks in reference to almost anyone below the rank of a commissioned officer would, during the period assigned to this narrative, have seemed not altogether wanting in credibility to the tarry old wiseacres of a man-of-war crew. And indeed a man of Claggart's accomplishments, without prior nautical experience, entering the navy at mature life, as he did, and necessarily allotted at the start to the lowest grade in it; a man, too, who never made allusion to his previous life ashore; these were circumstances which in the dearth of exact knowledge as to his true antecedents opened to the invidious a vague field for unfavorable surmise.

But the sailors' dog-watch gossip concerning him derived a vague plausibility from the fact that now for some period the British Navy could so little afford to be squeamish in the matter of keeping up the muster-rolls, that not only were press-gangs notoriously abroad both afloat and ashore, but there was little or no secret about another matter, namely that the London police were at liberty to capture any able-bodied suspect, any questionable fellow at large and summarily ship him to dockyard or fleet. Furthermore, even among voluntary enlistments there were instances where the motive thereto partook neither of patriotic impulse nor yet of a random desire to experience a bit of sea-life and martial adventure. Insolvent debtors of minor grade, together with the promiscuous lame ducks of morality found in the Navy a convenient and secure refuge. Secure, because once enlisted aboard a King's-ship, they were as much in sanctuary, as the transgressor of the Middle Ages harboring himself under the shadow of the altar. Such sanctioned irregularities, which for obvious reasons the Government would hardly think to parade at the time, and which consequently, and as affecting the least influential class of mankind, have

all but dropped into oblivion, lend color to something for the truth whereof I do not vouch, and hence have some scruple in stating; something I remember having seen in print, though the book I can not recall; but the same thing was personally communicated to me now more than forty years ago by an old pensioner in a cocked hat with whom I had a most interesting talk on the terrace at Greenwich, a Baltimore Negro, a Trafalgar man. It was to this effect: In the case of a war-ship short of hands whose speedy sailing was imperative, the deficient quota in lack of any other way of making it good, would be eked out by draughts culled direct from the jails. For reasons previously suggested it would not perhaps be easy at the present day directly to prove or disprove the allegation. But allowed as a verity, how significant would it be of England's straits at the time, confronted by those wars which like a flight of harpies rose shrieking from the din and dust of the fallen Bastille. That era appears measurably clear to us who look back at it, and but read of it. But to the grandfathers of us graybeards, the more thoughtful of them, the genius of it presented an aspect like that of Camoëns' Spirit of the Cape, an eclipsing menace mysterious and prodigious. Not America was exempt from apprehension. At the height of Napoleon's unexampled conquests, there were Americans who had fought at Bunker Hill who looked forward to the possibility that the Atlantic might prove no barrier against the ultimate schemes of this French upstart from the revolutionary chaos who seemed in act of fulfilling judgement prefigured in the Apocalypse.

But the less credence was to be given to the gun-deck talk touching Claggart, seeing that no man holding his office in a man-of-war can ever hope to be popular with the crew. Besides, in derogatory comments upon anyone against whom they have a grudge, or for any reason or no reason mislike, sailors are much like landsmen; they are apt to exaggerate or romance it.

About as much was really known to the *Indomitable's* tars of the Master-at-arms' career before entering the service as an astronomer knows about a comet's travels prior to its first observable appearance in the sky. The verdict of the sea quid-nuncs has been cited only by way of showing what sort of moral impression the man made upon rude uncultivated natures whose conceptions of human wickedness were necessarily of the narrowest, limited to ideas of vulgar rascality—a thief among the swinging hammocks during a night-watch, or the man brokers and land-sharks of the sea-ports.

It was no gossip, however, but fact, that though, as before hinted, Claggart upon his entrance into the navy was, as a novice, assigned to the least honourable section of a man-of-war's crew, embracing the drudgery, he did not long remain there. The superior capacity he immediately evinced, his constitutional sobriety, ingratiating deference to superiors, together with a peculiar ferreting genius manifested on a

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singular occasion; all this capped by a certain austere patriotism abruptly advanced him to the position of Master-at-arms.

Of this maritime Chief of Police the ship's-corporals, so called, were the immediate subordinates, and compliant ones; and this, as is to be noted in some business departments ashore, almost to a degree inconsistent with entire moral volition. His place put various converging wires of underground influence under the Chief's control, capable when astutely worked thro' his understrappers, of operating to the mysterious discomfort, if nothing worse, of any of the sea-commonalty.

Chapter 9

Life in the fore-top well agreed with Billy Budd. There, when not actually engaged on the yards yet higher aloft, the topmen, who as such had been picked out for youth and activity, constituted an aerial club lounging at ease against the smaller stunsails rolled up into cushions, spinning yarns like the lazy gods, and frequently amused with what was going on in the busy world of the decks below. No wonder then that a young fellow of Billy's disposition was well content in such society. Giving no cause of offence to anybody, he was always alert at a call. So in the merchant service it had been with him. But now such a punctiliousness in duty was shown that his topmates would sometimes good-naturedly laugh at him for it. This heightened alacrity had its cause, namely, the impression made upon him by the first formal gangway-punishment he had ever witnessed, which befell the day following his impressment. It had been incurred by a little fellow, young, a novice, an afterguardsman absent from his assigned post when the ship was being put about; a dereliction resulting in a rather serious hitch to that manoeuvre, one demanding instantaneous promptitude in letting go and making fast. When Billy saw the culprit's naked back under the scourge gridironed with red welts, and worse; when he marked the dire expression on the liberated man's face as with his woolen shirt flung over him by the executioner he rushed forward from the spot to bury himself in the crowd, Billy was horrified. He resolved that never through remissness would he make himself liable to such a visitation or do or omit aught that might merit even verbal reproof. What then was his surprise and concern when ultimately he found himself getting into petty trouble occasionally about such matters as the stowage of his bag or something amiss in his hammock, matters under the police oversight of the ship's-corporals of the lower decks, and which brought down on him a vague threat from one of them.

So heedful in all things as he was, how could this be? He could not understand it, and it more than vexed him. When he spoke to his young topmates about it they were either lightly incredulous or found something comical in his unconcealed anxiety. "Is it your bag, Billy?"

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said one. "Well, sew yourself up in it, bully boy, and then you'll be sure to know if anybody meddles with it."

Now there was a veteran aboard who because his years began to disqualify him for more active work had been recently assigned duty as mainmastman in his watch, looking to the gear belayed at the rail roundabout that great spar near the deck. At off-times the Foretopman had picked up some acquaintance with him, and now in his trouble it occurred to him that he might be the sort of person to go to for wise counsel. He was an old Dansker long anglicized in the service, of few words, many wrinkles and some honorable scars. His wizened face, time-tinted and weather-stained to the complexion of an antique parchment, was here and there peppered blue by the chance explosion of a gun-cartridge in action.

He was an *Agamemnon* man; some two years prior to the time of this story having served under Nelson, when but Sir Horatio, in that ship immortal in naval memory, and which, dismantled and in part broken up to her bare ribs, is seen a grand skeleton in Haydon's etching. As one of a boarding-party from the *Agamemnon* he had received a cut slantwise along one temple and cheek, leaving a long scar like a streak of dawn's light falling athwart the dark visage. It was on account of that scar and the affair in which it was known that he had received it, as well as from his blue-peppered complexion, that the Dansker went among the *Indomitable's* crew by the name of "Board-her-in-the-smoke."

Now the first time that his small weazel-eyes happened to light on Billy Budd, a certain grim internal merriment set all his ancient wrinkles into antic play. Was it that his eccentric unsentimental old sapience, primitive in its kind, saw or thought it saw something which, in contrast with the war-ship's environment, looked oddly incongruous in the Handsome Sailor? But after slyly studying him at intervals, the old Merlin's equivocal merriment was modified; for now when the twain would meet, it would start in his face a quizzing sort of look, but it would be but momentary and sometimes replaced by an expression of speculative query as to what might eventually befall a nature like that, dropped into a world not without some man-traps and against whose subtleties simple courage, lacking experience and address and without any touch of defensive ugliness, is of little avail; and where such innocence as man is capable of does yet in a moral emergency not always sharpen the faculties or enlighten the will.

However it was, the Dansker in his ascetic way rather took to Billy. Nor was this only because of a certain philosophic interest in such a character. There was another cause. While the old man's eccentricities, sometimes bordering on the ursine, repelled the juniors, Billy, undeterred thereby, revering him as a salt hero, would make advances, never passing the old *Agamemnon* man without a salutation marked by that respect which is seldom lost on the aged however crabbed at times or whatever their station in life.

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There was a vein of dry humor, or what not, in the mast-man; and, whether in freak of patriarchal irony touching Billy's youth and athletic frame, or for some other and more recondite reason, from the first in addressing him he always substituted Baby for Billy. The Dansker in fact being the originator of the name by which the Foretopman eventually became known aboard ship.

Well then, in his mysterious little difficulty, going in quest of the wrinkled one, Billy found him off duty in a dog-watch ruminating by himself, seated on a shot-box of the upper gun deck, now and then surveying with a somewhat cynical regard certain of the more swaggering promenaders there. Billy recounted his trouble, again wondering how it all happened. The salt seer attentively listened, accompanying the Foretopman's recital with queer twitchings of his wrinkles and problematical little sparkles of his small ferret eyes. Making an end of his story, the Foretopman asked, "And now, Dansker, do tell me what you think of it."

The old man, shoving up the front of his tarpaulin and deliberately rubbing the long slant scar at the point where it entered the thin hair, laconically said, "Baby Budd, Jimmy Legs" (meaning the Master-at-arms) "is down on you."

"Jimmy Legs!" ejaculated Billy, his welkin eyes expanding; "what for? Why he calls me the sweet and pleasant fellow, they tell me."

"Does he so?" grinned the grizzled one; then said, "Ay, Baby Lad, a sweet voice has Jimmy Legs."

"No, not always. But to me he has. I seldom pass him but there comes a pleasant word."

"And that's because he's down upon you, Baby Budd."

Such reiteration along with the manner of it, incomprehensible to a novice, disturbed Billy almost as much as the mystery for which he had sought explanation. Something less unpleasingly oracular he tried to extract; but the old sea-Chiron, thinking perhaps that for the nonce he had sufficiently instructed his young Achilles, pursed his lips, gathered all his wrinkles together and would commit himself to nothing further.

Years, and those experiences which befall certain shrewder men subordinated life-long to the will of superiors, all this had developed in the Dansker the pithy guarded cynicism that was his leading characteristic.

Chapter 10

The next day an incident served to confirm Billy Budd in his incredulity as to the Dansker's strange summing-up of the case submitted. The ship at noon, going large before the wind, was rolling on her course, and he, below at dinner and engaged in some sportful talk with the members of his mess, chanced in a sudden lurch to spill the

entire contents of his soup-pan upon the new scrubbed deck. Claggart, the Master-at-arms, official rattan in hand, happened to be passing along the battery in a bay of which the mess was lodged, and the greasy liquid streamed just across his path. Stepping over it, he was proceeding on his way without comment, since the matter was nothing to take notice of under the circumstances, when he happened to observe who it was that had done the spilling. His countenance changed. Pausing, he was about to ejaculate something hasty at the sailor, but checked himself, and pointing down to the streaming soup, playfully tapped him from behind with his rattan, saying in a low musical voice peculiar to him at times, "Handsomely done, my lad! And handsome is as handsome did it too!" And with that passed on. Not noted by Billy, as not coming within his view, was the involuntary smile, or rather grimace, that accompanied Claggart's equivocal words. Aridly it drew down the thin corners of his shapely mouth. But everybody taking his remark as meant for humourous, and at which therefore as coming from a superior they were bound to laugh "with counterfeited glee," acted accordingly; and Billy tickled, it may be, by the allusion to his being the handsome sailor, merrily joined in; then addressing his messmates exclaimed, "There now, who says that Jimmy Legs is down on me!"

"And who said he was, Beauty?" demanded one Donald with some surprise. Whereat the Foretopman looked a little foolish, recalling that it was only one person, Board-her-in-the-smoke, who had suggested what to him was the smoky idea that this Master-at-arms was in any peculiar way hostile to him. Meantime that functionary, resuming his path, must have momentarily worn some expression less guarded than that of the bitter smile, and usurping the face from the heart, some distorting expression perhaps; for a drummer-boy heedlessly frolicking along from the opposite direction and chancing to come into light collision with his person was strangely disconcerted by his aspect. Nor was the impression lessened when the official, impulsively giving him a sharp cut with the rattan, vehemently exclaimed, "Look where you go!"

Chapter 11

What was the matter with the Master-at-arms? And, be the matter what it might, how could it have direct relation to Billy Budd with whom, prior to the affair of the spilled soup, he had never come into any special contact, official or otherwise? What indeed could the trouble have to do with one so little inclined to give offence as the merchant-ship's peacemaker, even him who in Claggart's own phrase was "the sweet and pleasant young fellow"? Yes, why should Jimmy Legs, to borrow the Dansker's expression, be down on the Handsome Sailor? But, at heart and not for nothing, as the late chance encounter

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may indicate to the discerning, down on him, secretly down on him, he assuredly was.

Now to invent something touching the more private career of Claggart, something involving Billy Budd, of which something the latter should be wholly ignorant, some romantic incident implying that Claggart's knowledge of the young blue-jacket began at some period anterior to catching sight of him on board the seventy-four—all this, not so difficult to do, might avail in a way more or less interesting to account for whatever of enigma may appear to lurk in the case. But in fact there was nothing of the sort. And yet the cause, necessarily to be assumed as the sole one assignable, is in its very realism as much charged with that prime element of Radcliffian romance, the mysterious, as any that the ingenuity of the author of the *Mysteries of Udolpho* could devise. For what can more partake of the mysterious than an antipathy spontaneous and profound, such as is evoked in certain exceptional mortals by the mere aspect of some other mortal, however harmless he may be, if not called forth by this very harmlessness itself?

Now there can exist no irritating juxtaposition of dissimilar personalities comparable to that which is possible aboard a great war-ship fully manned and at sea. There, every day among all ranks almost every man comes into more or less of contact with almost every other man. Wholly there to avoid even the sight of an aggravating object one must needs give it Jonah's toss or jump overboard himself. Imagine how all this might eventually operate on some peculiar human creature the direct reverse of a saint?

But for the adequate comprehending of Claggart by a normal nature, these hints are insufficient. To pass from a normal nature to him one must cross "the deadly space between." And this is best done by indirection.

Long ago an honest scholar my senior, said to me in reference to one who like himself is now no more, a man so unimpeachably respectable that against him nothing was ever openly said though among the few something was whispered, "Yes, X— is a nut not to be cracked by the tap of a lady's fan. You are aware that I am the adherent of no organized religion much less of any philosophy built into a system. Well, for all that, I think that to try and get into X—, enter his labyrinth and get out again, without a clue derived from some source other than what is known as "knowledge of the world"—that were hardly possible, at least for me."

"Why," said I, "X—, however singular a study to some, is yet human, and knowledge of the world assuredly implies the knowledge of human nature, and in most of its varieties."

"Yes, but a superficial knowledge of it, serving ordinary purposes. But for anything deeper, I am not certain whether to know the world and to know human nature be not two distinct branches of knowledge, which while they may coexist in the same heart, yet either may

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exist with little or nothing of the other. Nay, in an average man of the world, his constant rubbing with it blunts that fine spiritual insight indispensable to the understanding of the essential in certain exceptional characters, whether evil ones or good. In a matter of some importance I have seen a girl wind an old lawyer about her little finger. Nor was it the dotage of senile love. Nothing of the sort. But he knew law better than he knew the girl's heart. Coke and Blackstone hardly shed so much light into obscure spiritual places as the Hebrew prophets. And who were they? Mostly recluses."

At the time my inexperience was such that I did not quite see the drift of all this. It may be that I see it now. And, indeed, if that lexicon which is based on Holy Writ were any longer popular, one might with less difficulty define and denominate certain phenomenal men. As it is, one must turn to some authority not liable to the charge of being tinctured with the Biblical element.

In a list of definitions included in the authentic translation of Plato, a list attributed to him, occurs this: "Natural Depravity: a depravity according to nature." A definition which tho' savoring of Calvinism, by no means involves Calvin's dogmas as to total mankind. Evidently its intent makes it applicable but to individuals. Not many are the examples of this depravity which the gallows and jail supply. At any rate for notable instances, since these have no vulgar alloy of the brute in them, but invariably are dominated by intellectuality, one must go elsewhere. Civilization, especially if of the austerer sort, is auspicious to it. It folds itself in the mantle of respectability. It has its certain negative virtues serving as silent auxiliaries. It never allows wine to get within its guard. It is not going too far to say that it is without vices or small sins. There is a phenomenal pride in it that excludes them from anything mercenary or avaricious. In short the depravity here meant partakes nothing of the sordid or sensual. It is serious, but free from acerbity. Though no flatterer of mankind it never speaks ill of it.

But the thing which in eminent instances signalizes so exceptional a nature is this: though the man's even temper and discreet bearing would seem to intimate a mind peculiarly subject to the law of reason, not the less in his heart he would seem to riot in complete exemption from that law, having apparently little to do with reason further than to employ it as an ambidexter implement for effecting the irrational. That is to say: Toward the accomplishment of an aim which in wantonness of malignity would seem to partake of the insane, he will direct a cool judgement sagacious and sound. These men are true madmen, and of the most dangerous sort, for their lunacy is not continuous but occasional, evoked by some special object; it is probably secretive, which is as much to say it is self-contained, so that when moreover, most active, it is to the average mind not distinguishable from sanity, and for the reason above suggested that whatever its aims may

be—and the aim is never declared—the method and the outward proceeding are always perfectly rational.

Now something such an one was Claggart, in whom was the mania of an evil nature, not engendered by vicious training or corrupting books or licentious living, but born with him and innate, in short “a depravity according to nature.”

By the way, can it be the phenomenon, disowned or at least concealed, that in some criminal cases puzzles the courts? For this cause have our juries at times not only to endure the prolonged contentions of lawyers with their fees, but also the yet more perplexing strife of the medical experts with theirs? But why leave it to them? Why not subpoena as well the clerical proficient? Their vocation bringing them into peculiar contact with so many human beings, and sometimes in their least guarded hour, in interviews very much more confidential than those of physician and patient; this would seem to qualify them to know something about those intricacies involved in the question of moral responsibility; whether in a given case, say, the crime proceeded from mania in the brain or rabies of the heart. As to any differences among themselves these clerical proficient might develop on the stand, these could hardly be greater than the direct contradictions exchanged between the remunerated medical experts.

Dark sayings are these, some will say. But why? Is it because they somewhat savor of Holy Writ in its phrase “mysteries of iniquity”? If they do, such savor was far from being intended, for little will it commend these pages to many a reader of to-day.

The point of the present story turning on the hidden nature of the Master-at-arms has necessitated this chapter. With an added hint or two in connection with the incident at the mess, the resumed narrative must be left to vindicate, as it may, its own credibility.

Chapter 12

That Claggart’s figure was not amiss, and his face, save the chin, well moulded, has already been said. Of these favorable points he seemed not insensible, for he was not only neat but careful in his dress. But the form of Billy Budd was heroic; and if his face was without the intellectual look of the pallid Claggart’s, not the less was it lit, like his, from within, though from a different source. The bonfire in his heart made luminous the rose-tan in his cheek.

In view of the marked contrast between the persons of the twain, it is more than probable that when the Master-at-arms in the scene last given applied to the sailor the proverb Handsome is as handsome does, he there let escape an ironic inkling, not caught by the young sailors who heard it, as to what it was that had first moved him against Billy, namely, his significant personal beauty.

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Now envy and antipathy, passions irreconcilable in reason, nevertheless in fact may spring conjoined like Chang and Eng in one birth. Is Envy then such a monster? Well, though many an arraigned mortal has in hopes of mitigated penalty pleaded guilty to horrible actions, did ever anybody seriously confess to envy? Something there is in it universally felt to be more shameful than even felonious crime. And not only does everybody disown it, but the better sort are inclined to incredulity when it is in earnest imputed to an intelligent man. But since its lodgement is in the heart not the brain, no degree of intellect supplies a guarantee against it. But Claggart's was no vulgar form of the passion. Nor, as directed toward Billy Budd, did it partake of that streak of apprehensive jealousy that marred Saul's visage perturbedly brooding on the comely young David. Claggart's envy struck deeper. If askance he eyed the good looks, cheery health and frank enjoyment of young life in Billy Budd, it was because these went along with a nature that, as Claggart magnetically felt, had in its simplicity never willed malice or experienced the reactionary bite of that serpent. To him, the spirit lodged within Billy, and looking out from his welkin eyes as from windows, that ineffability it was which made the dimple in his dyed cheek, supplanted his joints, and dancing in his yellow curls made him preeminently the Handsome Sailor. One person excepted, the Master-at-arms was perhaps the only man in the ship intellectually capable of adequately appreciating the moral phenomenon presented in Billy Budd. And the insight but intensified his passion, which assuming various secret forms within him, at times assumed that of cynic disdain—disdain of innocence. To be nothing more than innocent! Yet in an aesthetic way he saw the charm of it, the courageous free-and-easy temper of it, and fain would have shared it, but he despaired of it.

With no power to annul the elemental evil in him, tho' readily enough he could hide it; apprehending the good, but powerless to be it; a nature like Claggart's surcharged with energy as such natures almost invariably are, what recourse is left to it but to recoil upon itself and like the scorpion for which the Creator alone is responsible, act out to the end the part allotted it.

Chapter 13

Passion, and passion in its profoundest, is not a thing demanding a palatial stage whereon to play its part. Down among the groundlings, among the beggars and rakers of the garbage, profound passion is enacted. And the circumstances that provoke it, however trivial or mean, are no measure of its power. In the present instance the stage is a scrubbed gun deck, and one of the external provocations a man-of-war's-man's spilled soup.

Now when the Master-at-arms noticed whence came that greasy

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fluid streaming before his feet, he must have taken it—to some extent wilfully, perhaps—not for the mere accident it assuredly was, but for the sly escape of a spontaneous feeling on Billy's part more or less answering to the antipathy on his own. In effect a foolish demonstration he must have thought, and very harmless, like the futile kick of a heifer, which yet were the heifer a shod stallion, would not be so harmless. Even so was it that into the gall of Claggart's envy he infused the vitriol of his contempt. But the incident confirmed to him certain tell-tale reports purveyed to his ear by Squeak, one of his more cunning Corporals, a grizzled little man, so nicknamed by the sailors on account of his squeaky voice, and sharp visage ferreting about the dark corners of the lower decks after interlopers, satirically suggesting to them the idea of a rat in a cellar.

From his Chief's employing him as an implicit tool in laying little traps for the worriment of the Foretopman—for it was from the Master-at-arms that the petty persecutions heretofore adverted to had proceeded—the Corporal having naturally enough concluded that his master could have no love for the sailor, made it his business, faithful understrapper that he was, to foment the ill blood by perverting to his Chief certain innocent frolics of the goodnatured Foretopman, besides inventing for his mouth sundry contumelious epithets he claimed to have overheard him let fall. The Master-at-arms never suspected the veracity of these reports, more especially as to the epithets, for he well knew how secretly unpopular may become a master-at-arms, at least a master-at-arms of those days zealous in his function, and how the blue-jackets shoot at him in private their raillery and wit; the nickname by which he goes among them (Jimmy Legs) implying under the form of merriment their cherished disrespect and dislike. But in view of the greediness of hate for patrolmen, it hardly needed a purveyor to feed Claggart's passion.

An uncommon prudence is habitual with the subtler depravity, for it has everything to hide. And in case of an injury but suspected, its secretiveness voluntarily cuts it off from enlightenment or disillusion; and, not unreluctantly, action is taken upon surmise as upon certainty. And the retaliation is apt to be in monstrous disproportion to the supposed offence; for when in anybody was revenge in its exactions aught else but an inordinate usurer? But how with Claggart's conscience? For though consciences are unlike as foreheads, every intelligence, not excluding the Scriptural devils who "believe and tremble," has one. But Claggart's conscience being but the lawyer to his will, made ogres of trifles, probably arguing that the motive imputed to Billy in spilling the soup just when he did, together with the epithets alleged, these, if nothing more, made a strong case against him; nay, justified animosity into a sort of retributive righteousness. The Pharisee is the Guy Fawkes prowling in the hid chambers underlying the Claggarts. And they can really form no conception of an un-

reciprocated malice. Probably, the Master-at-arms' clandestine persecution of Billy was started to try the temper of the man; but it had not developed any quality in him that enmity could make official use of or even pervert into plausible self-justification; so that the occurrence at the mess, petty if it were, was a welcome one to that peculiar conscience assigned to be the private mentor of Claggart. And, for the rest, not improbably it put him upon new experiments.

Chapter 14

Not many days after the last incident narrated, something befell Billy Budd that more gravelled him than aught that had previously occurred.

It was a warm night for the latitude; and the Foretopman, whose watch at the time was properly below, was dozing on the uppermost deck whither he had ascended from his hot hammock, one of hundreds suspended so closely wedged together over a lower gun deck that there was little or no swing to them. He lay as in the shadow of a hill-side, stretched under the lee of the booms, a piled ridge of spare spars amidships between fore-mast and mainmast and among which the ship's largest boat, the launch, was stowed. Alongside of three other slumberers from below, he lay near that end of the booms which approaches the fore-mast; his station aloft on duty as a foretopman being just over the deckstation of the forecastlemen, entitling him according to usage to make himself more or less at home in that neighbourhood.

Presently he was stirred into semi-consciousness by somebody, who must have previously sounded the sleep of the others, touching his shoulder, and then as the Foretopman raised his head, breathing into his ear in a quick whisper, "Slip into the lee forechains, Billy; there is something in the wind. Don't speak. Quick, I will meet you there"; and disappeared.

Now Billy like sundry other essentially good-natured ones had some of the weaknesses inseparable from essential good-nature; and among these was a reluctance, almost an incapacity of plumply saying no to an abrupt proposition not obviously absurd, on the face of it, nor obviously unfriendly, nor iniquitous. And being of warm blood he had not the phlegm tacitly to negative any proposition by unresponsive inaction. Like his sense of fear, his apprehension as to aught outside of the honest and natural was seldom very quick. Besides, upon the present occasion, the drowse from his sleep still hung upon him.

However it was, he mechanically rose, and sleepily wondering what could be in the wind, betook himself to the designated place, a narrow platform, one of six, outside of the high bulwarks and screened by the great dead-eyes and multiple columned lanyards of

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the shrouds and back-stays; and, in a great war-ship of that time, of dimensions commensurate with the hull's magnitude; a tarry balcony, in short, overhanging the sea, and so secluded that one mariner of the *Indomitable*, a non-conformist old tar of a serious turn, made it even in daytime his private oratory.

In this retired nook the stranger soon joined Billy Budd. There was no moon as yet; a haze obscured the star-light. He could not distinctly see the stranger's face. Yet from something in the outline and carriage, Billy took him to be, and correctly, one of the afterguard.

"Hist! Billy," said the man in the same quick cautionary whisper as before; "You were impressed, weren't you? Well, so was I!"; and he paused, as to mark the effect. But Billy, not knowing exactly what to make of this, said nothing. Then the other: "We are not the only impressed ones, Billy. There's a gang of us.—Couldn't you—help—at a pinch?"

"What do you mean?" demanded Billy, here thoroughly shaking off his drowse.

"Hist, hist!" the hurried whisper now growing husky, "see here"; and the man held up two small objects faintly twinkling in the night-light; "see, they are yours, Billy, if you'll only—"

But Billy broke in, and in his resentful eagerness to deliver himself his vocal infirmity somewhat intruded: "D—D-Damme, I don't know what you are d-d-driving at, or what you mean, but you had better g-g-go where you belong!" For the moment the fellow, as confounded, did not stir; and Billy springing to his feet, said, "If you d-don't start I'll t-t-toss you back over the r-r-rail!" There was no mistaking this and the mysterious emissary decamped disappearing in the direction of the main-mast in the shadow of the booms.

"Hallo, what's the matter?" here came growling from a forecastleman awakened from his deck-doze by Billy's raised voice. And as the Foretopman reappeared and was recognized by him; "Ah, Beauty, is it you? Well, something must have been the matter for you st-st-stuttered."

"Oh," rejoined Billy, now mastering the impediment; "I found an afterguardsman in our part of the ship here and I bid him be off where he belongs."

"And is that all you did about it, Foretopman?" gruffly demanded another, an irascible old fellow of brick-colored visage and hair, and who was known to his associate forecastlemen as Red Pepper; "Such sneaks I should like to marry to the gunner's daughter!" by that expression meaning that he would like to subject them to disciplinary castigation over a gun.

However, Billy's rendering of the matter satisfactorily accounted to these inquirers for the brief commotion, since of all the sections of a ship's company, the forecastlemen, veterans for the most part and bigoted in their sea-prejudices, are the most jealous in resenting territorial encroachments, especially on the part of any of the afterguard,

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of whom they have but a sorry opinion, chiefly landsmen, never going aloft except to reef or furl the mainsail and in no wise competent to handle a marlinspike or turn in a dead-eye, say.

Chapter 15

This incident sorely puzzled Billy Budd. It was an entirely new experience; the first time in his life that he had ever been personally approached in underhand intriguing fashion. Prior to this encounter he had known nothing of the afterguardsman, the two men being stationed wide apart, one forward and aloft during his watch, the other on deck and aft.

What could it mean? And could they really be guineas, those two glittering objects the interloper had held up to his eyes? Where could the fellow get guineas? Why even spare buttons are not so plentiful at sea. The more he turned the matter over, the more he was non-plussed, and made uneasy and discomforted. In his disgustful recoil from an overture which tho' he but ill comprehended he instinctively knew must involve evil of some sort, Billy Budd was like a young horse fresh from the pasture suddenly inhaling a vile whiff from some chemical factory, and by repeated snortings tries to get it out of his nostrils and lungs. This frame of mind barred all desire of holding further parley with the fellow, even were it but for the purpose of gaining some enlightenment as to his design in approaching him. And yet he was not without natural curiosity to see how such a visitor in the dark would look in broad day.

He espied him the following afternoon, in his first dog-watch, below, one of the smokers on that forward part of the upper gun deck allotted to the pipe. He recognized him by his general cut and build, more than by his round freckled face and glassy eyes of pale blue, veiled with lashes all but white. And yet Billy was a bit uncertain whether indeed it were he—yonder chap about his own age chatting and laughing in free-hearted way, leaning against a gun; a genial young fellow enough to look at, and something of a rattlebrain, to all appearance. Rather chubby too for a sailor, even an afterguardsman. In short the last man in the world, one would think, to be overburthened with thoughts, especially those perilous thoughts that must needs belong to a conspirator in any serious project, or even to the underling of such a conspirator.

Altho' Billy was not aware of it, the fellow, with a sidelong watchful glance had perceived Billy first, and then noting that Billy was looking at him, thereupon nodded a familiar sort of friendly recognition as to an old acquaintance, without interrupting the talk he was engaged in with the group of smokers. A day or two afterwards, chancing in the evening promenade on a gun deck to pass Billy, he offered a flying word of good-fellowship, as it were, which by its unexpectedness, and

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equivocalness under the circumstances so embarrassed Billy that he knew not how to respond to it, and let it go unnoticed.

Billy was now left more at a loss than before. The ineffectual speculation into which he was led was so disturbingly alien to him, that he did his best to smother it. It never entered his mind that here was a matter which from its extreme questionableness, it was his duty as a loyal blue-jacket to report in the proper quarter. And, probably, had such a step been suggested to him, he would have been deterred from taking it by the thought, one of novice-magnanimity, that it would savor overmuch of the dirty work of a telltale. He kept the thing to himself. Yet upon one occasion, he could not forbear a little disburthening himself to the old Dansker, tempted thereto perhaps by the influence of a balmy night when the ship lay becalmed; the twain, silent for the most part, sitting together on deck, their heads propped against the bulwarks. But it was only a partial and anonymous account that Billy gave, the unfounded scruples above referred to preventing full disclosure to anybody. Upon hearing Billy's version, the sage Dansker seemed to divine more than he was told; and after a little meditation during which his wrinkles were pursed as into a point, quite effacing for the time that quizzing expression his face sometimes wore, "Didn't I say so, Baby Budd?"

"Say what?" demanded Billy.

"Why, Jimmy Legs is down on you."

"And what," rejoined Billy in amazement, "has Jimmy Legs to do with that cracked afterguardsman?"

"Ho, it was an afterguardsman then. A cat's-paw, a cat's-paw!" And with that exclamation, which, whether it had reference to a light puff of air just then coming over the calm sea, or subtler relation to the afterguardsman there is no telling, the old Merlin gave a twisting wrench with his black teeth at his plug of tobacco, vouchsafing no reply to Billy's impetuous question, tho' now repeated, for it was his wont to relapse into grim silence when interrogated in skeptical sort as to any of his sententious oracles, not always very clear ones, rather partaking of that obscurity which invests most Delphic deliverances from any quarter.

Long experience had very likely brought this old man to that bitter prudence which never interferes in aught and never gives advice.

Chapter 16

Yes, despite the Dansker's pithy insistence as to the Master-at-arms being at the bottom of these strange experiences of Billy on board the *Indomitable*, the young sailor was ready to ascribe them to almost anybody but the man who, to use Billy's own expression, "always had a pleasant word for him." This is to be wondered at. Yet not so much to be wondered at. In certain matters, some sailors even in

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mature life remain unsophisticated enough. But a young seafarer of the disposition of our athletic Foretopman, is much of a child-man. And yet a child's utter innocence is but its blank ignorance, and the innocence more or less wanes as intelligence waxes. But in Billy Budd intelligence, such as it was, had advanced, while yet his simplemindedness remained for the most part unaffected. Experience is a teacher indeed; yet did Billy's years make his experience small. Besides, he had none of that intuitive knowledge of the bad which in natures not good or incompletely so foreruns experience, and therefore may pertain, as in some instances it too clearly does pertain, even to youth.

And what could Billy know of man except of man as a mere sailor? And the old-fashioned sailor, the veritable man-before-the-mast, the sailor from boyhood up, he, tho' indeed of the same species as a landsman, is in some respects singularly distinct from him. The sailor is frankness, the landsman is finesse. Life is not a game with the sailor, demanding the long head; no intricate game of chess where few moves are made in straightforwardness, and ends are attained by indirection; an oblique, tedious, barren game hardly worth that poor candle burnt out in playing it.

Yes, as a class, are in character a juvenile race. Even their deviations are marked by true juvenility. And this more especially holding true with the sailors of Billy's time. Then, too, certain things which apply to all sailors, do more pointedly operate, here and there, upon the junior one. Every sailor, too, is accustomed to obey orders without debating them; his life afloat is externally ruled for him; he is not brought into that promiscuous commerce with mankind where unobstructed free agency on equal terms—equal superficially, at least—soon teaches one that unless upon occasion he exercise a distrust keen in proportion to the fairness of the appearance, some foul turn may be served him. A ruled undemonstrative distrustfulness is so habitual, not with business-men so much, as with men who know their kind in less shallow relations than business, namely, certain men-of-the-world, that they come at last to employ it all but unconsciously; and some of them would very likely feel real surprise at being charged with it as one of their general characteristics.

Chapter 17

But after the little matter at the mess Billy Budd no more found himself in strange trouble at times about his hammock or his clothes-bag or what not. While, as to that smile that occasionally sunned him, and the pleasant passing word, these were if not more frequent, yet if anything, more pronounced than before.

But for all that, there were certain other demonstrations now. When Claggart's unobserved glance happened to light on belted Billy rolling along the upper gun deck in the leisure of the second dog-

watch, exchanging passing broadsides of fun with other young promenaders in the crowd; that glance would follow the cheerful sea-Hyperion with a settled meditative and melancholy expression, his eyes strangely suffused with incipient feverish tears. Then would Claggart look like the man of sorrows. Yes, and sometimes the melancholy expression would have in it a touch of soft yearning, as if Claggart could even have loved Billy but for fate and ban. But this was an evanescence, and quickly repented of, as it were, by an inimitable look, pinching and shrivelling the visage into the momentary semblance of a wrinkled walnut. But sometimes catching sight in advance of the Foretopman coming in his direction, he would, upon their nearing, step aside a little to let him pass, dwelling upon Billy for the moment with the glittering dental satire of a Guise. But upon any abrupt unforeseen encounter a red light would flash forth from his eye like a spark from an anvil in a dusk smithy. That quick fierce light was a strange one, darted from orbs which in repose were of a color nearest approaching a deeper violet, the softest of shades.

Tho' some of these caprices of the pit could not but be observed by their object, yet were they beyond the construing of such a nature. And the thews of Billy were hardly compatible with that sort of sensitive spiritual organisation which in some cases instinctively conveys to ignorant innocence an admonition of the proximity of the malign. He thought the Master-at-arms acted in a manner rather queer at times. That was all. But the occasional frank air and pleasant word went for what they purported to be, the young sailor never having heard as yet of the "too fair-spoken man."

Had the Foretopman been conscious of having done or said anything to provoke the ill will of the official, it would have been different with him, and his sight might have been purged if not sharpened. As it was, innocence was his blinder.

So was it with him in yet another matter. Two minor officers—the Armorer and Captain of the Hold, with whom he had never exchanged a word, his position in the ship not bringing him into contact with them; these men now for the first began to cast upon Billy when they chanced to encounter him, that peculiar glance which evidences that the man from whom it comes has been some way tampered with and to the prejudice of him upon whom the glance lights. Never did it occur to Billy as a thing to be noted or a thing suspicious, tho' he well knew the fact, that the Armorer and Captain of the Hold, with the ship's-yeoman, apothecary, and others of that grade, were by naval usage, messmates of the Master-at-arms, men with ears convenient to his confidential tongue.

But the general popularity that our Handsome Sailor's manly forwardness bred upon occasion, and his irresistible good-nature, indicating no mental superiority tending to excite an invidious feeling, this good will on the part of most of his shipmates made him the less to concern himself about such mute aspects toward him as those

whereto allusion has just been made, aspects he could not fathom as to infer their whole import.

As to the afterguardsman, tho' Billy for reasons already given necessarily saw little of him, yet when the two did happen to meet, invariably came the fellow's off-hand cheerful recognition, sometimes accompanied by a passing pleasant word or two. Whatever that equivocal young person's original design may really have been, or the design of which he might have been the deputy, certain it was from his manner upon these occasions, that he had wholly dropped it.

It was as if his precocity of crookedness (and every vulgar villain is precocious) had for once deceived him, and the man he had sought to entrap as a simpleton had, through his very simplicity, ignominiously baffled him.

But shrewd ones may opine that it was hardly possible for Billy to refrain from going up to the afterguardsman and bluntly demanding to know his purpose in the initial interview, so abruptly closed in the fore-chains. Shrewd ones may also think it but natural in Billy to set about sounding some of the other impressed men of the ship in order to discover what basis, if any, there was for the emissary's obscure suggestions as to plotting disaffection aboard. Yes, the shrewd may so think. But something more, or rather, something else than mere shrewdness is perhaps needful for the due understanding of such a character as Billy Budd's.

As to Claggart, the monomania in the man—if that indeed it were—as involuntarily disclosed by starts in the manifestations detailed, yet in general covered over by his self-contained and rational demeanour; this, like a subterranean fire was eating its way deeper and deeper in him. Something decisive must come of it.

Chapter 18

After the mysterious interview in the fore-chains—the one so abruptly ended there by Billy—nothing especially german to the story occurred until the events now about to be narrated.

Elsewhere it has been said that in the lack of frigates (of course better sailers than line-of-battle ships) in the English squadron up the Straits at that period, the *Indomitable* was occasionally employed not only as an available substitute for a scout, but at times on detached service of more important kind. This was not alone because of her sailing qualities, not common in a ship of her rate, but quite as much, probably, that the character of her commander, it was thought, specially adapted him for any duty where under unforeseen difficulties a prompt initiative might have to be taken in some matter demanding knowledge and ability in addition to those qualities implied in good seamanship. It was on an expedition of the latter sort, a somewhat

distant one, and when the *Indomitable* was almost at her furthest remove from the fleet, that in the latter part of an afternoon-watch she unexpectedly came in sight of a ship of the enemy. It proved to be a frigate. The latter perceiving thro' the glass that the weight of men and metal would be heavily against her, invoking her light heels, crowded sail to get away. After a chase urged almost against hope and lasting until about the middle of the first dog-watch, she signally succeeded in effecting her escape.

Not long after the pursuit had been given up, and ere the excitement thereto had altogether waned away, the Master-at-arms, ascending from his cavernous sphere, made his appearance cap in hand by the main-mast, respectfully waiting the notice of Captain Vere then solitary walking the weather-side of the quarterdeck, doubtless somewhat chafed at the failure of the pursuit. The spot where Claggart stood was the place allotted to men of lesser grades seeking some more particular interview either with the officer-of-the-deck or the Captain himself. But from the latter it was not often that a sailor or petty-officer of those days would seek a hearing; only some exceptional cause, would, according to established custom, have warranted that.

Presently, just as the Commander absorbed in his reflections was on the point of turning aft in his promenade, he became sensible of Claggart's presence, and saw the doffed cap held in deferential expectancy. Here be it said that Captain Vere's personal knowledge of this petty-officer had only begun at the time of the ship's last sailing from home, Claggart then for the first, in transfer from a ship detained for repairs, supplying on board the *Indomitable* the place of a previous master-at-arms disabled and ashore.

No sooner did the Commander observe who it was that deferentially stood awaiting his notice, than a peculiar expression came over him. It was not unlike that which uncontrollably will flit across the countenance of one at unawares encountering a person who, though known to him indeed, has hardly been long enough known for thorough knowledge, but something in whose aspect nevertheless now for the first provokes a vaguely repellent distaste. But coming to a stand, and resuming much of his wonted official manner, save that a sort of impatience lurked in the intonation of the opening word, he said, "Well? what is it, Master-at-arms?"

With the air of a subordinate grieved at the necessity of being a messenger of ill tidings, and while conscientiously determined to be frank, yet equally resolved upon shunning overstatement, Claggart, at this invitation or rather summons to disburthen, spoke up. What he said, conveyed in the language of no uneducated man, was to the effect following, if not altogether in these words, namely, that during the chase and preparations for the possible encounter he had seen enough to convince him that at least one sailor aboard was a dangerous character in a ship mustering some who not only had taken a

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guilty part in the late serious troubles, but others also who, like the man in question, had entered His Majesty's service under another form than enlistment.

At this point Captain Vere with some impatience interrupted him: "Be direct, man; say impressed men."

Claggart made a gesture of subservience, and proceeded. Quite lately he (Claggart) had begun to suspect that on the gun decks some sort of movement prompted by the sailor in question was covertly going on, but he had not thought himself warranted in reporting the suspicion so long as it remained indistinct. But from what he had that afternoon observed in the man referred to, the suspicion of something clandestine going on had advanced to a point less removed from certainty. He deeply felt, he added, the serious responsibility assumed in making a report involving such possible consequences to the individual mainly concerned, besides tending to augment those natural anxieties which every naval commander must feel in view of extraordinary outbreaks so recent as those which, he sorrowfully said it, it needed not to name.

Now at the first broaching of the matter Captain Vere, taken by surprise, could not wholly dissemble his disquietude. But as Claggart went on, the former's aspect changed into restiveness under something in the witness' manner in giving his testimony. However, he refrained from interrupting him. And Claggart, continuing, concluded with this: "God forbid, Your Honor, that the *Indomitable's* should be the experience of the—"

"Never mind that!" here peremptorily broke in the superior, his face altering with anger, instinctively divining the ship that the other was about to name, one in which the Nore Mutiny had assumed a singularly tragical character that for a time jeopardized the life of its commander. Under the circumstances he was indignant at the purposed allusion. When the commissioned officers themselves were on all occasions very heedful how they referred to the recent events, for a petty-officer unnecessarily to allude to them in the presence of his Captain, this struck him as a most immodest presumption. Besides, to his quick sense of self-respect, it even looked under the circumstances something like an attempt to alarm him. Nor at first was he without some surprise that one who so far as he had hitherto come under his notice had shown considerable tact in his function should in this particular evince such lack of it.

But these thoughts and kindred dubious ones flitting across his mind were suddenly replaced by an intuitional surmise which, though as yet obscure in form, served practically to affect his reception of the ill tidings. Certain it is, that long versed in everything pertaining to the complicated gun-deck life, which like every other form of life, has its secret mines and dubious side, the side popularly disclaimed, Captain Vere did not permit himself to be unduly disturbed by the general tenor of his subordinate's report.

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Furthermore, if in view of recent events prompt action should be taken at the first palpable sign of recurring insubordination, for all that, not judicious would it be, he thought, to keep the idea of lingering disaffection alive by undue forwardness in crediting an informer, even if his own subordinate, and charged among other things with police surveillance of the crew. This feeling would not perhaps have so prevailed with him were it not that upon a prior occasion the patriotic zeal officially evinced by Claggart had somewhat irritated him as appearing rather supersensible and strained. Furthermore, something even in the official's self-possessed and somewhat ostentatious manner in making his specifications strangely reminded him of a bandsman, a perjurious witness in a capital case before a courtmartial ashore of which when a lieutenant, he, Captain Vere, had been a member.

Now the peremptory check given to Claggart in the matter of the arrested allusion was quickly followed up by this: "You say that there is at least one dangerous man aboard. Name him."

"William Budd. A foretopman, Your Honor—"

"William Budd," repeated Captain Vere with unfeigned astonishment; "and mean you the man that Lieutenant Ratcliff took from the merchantman not very long ago—the young fellow who seems to be so popular with the men—Billy, the 'Handsome Sailor,' as they call him?"

"The same, Your Honor; but for all his youth and good looks, a deep one. Not for nothing does he insinuate himself into the good will of his shipmates, since at the least all hands will at a pinch say a good word for him at all hazards. Did Lieutenant Ratcliff happen to tell Your Honor of that adroit fling of Budd's, jumping up in the cutter's bow under the merchantman's stern when he was being taken off? It is even masqued by that sort of good-humoured air that at heart he resents his impressment. You have but noted his fair cheek. A man-trap may be under his ruddy-tipped daisies."

Now the Handsome Sailor, as a signal figure among the crew, had naturally enough attracted the Captain's attention from the first. Tho' in general not very demonstrative to his officers, he had congratulated Lieutenant Ratcliff upon his good fortune in lighting on such a fine specimen of the genus homo, who in the nude might have posed for a statue of young Adam before the Fall. As to Billy's adieu to the ship *Rights-of-Man*, which the boarding lieutenant had indeed reported to him, but in a deferential way more as a good story than aught else, Captain Vere, tho' mistakenly understanding it as a satiric sally, had but thought so much the better of the impressed man for it; as a military sailor, admiring the spirit that could take an arbitrary enlistment so merrily and sensibly. The Foretopman's conduct, too, so far as it had fallen under the Captain's notice, had confirmed the first happy augury, while the new recruit's qualities as a sailor-man seemed to be such that he had thought of recommending him to the executive officer for promotion to a place that would more frequently bring him

under his own observation, namely, the captaincy of the mizzen-top, replacing there in the starboard watch a man not so young whom partly for that reason he deemed less fitted for the post. Be it parenthesized here that since the mizzen-topmen having not to handle such breadths of heavy canvas as the lower sails on the main-mast and fore-mast, a young man if of the right stuff not only seems best adapted to duty there, but in fact is generally selected for the captaincy of that top, and the company under him are light hands and often but stripplings. In sum, Captain Vere had from the beginning deemed Billy Budd to be what in the naval parlance of the time was called a "King's bargain," that is to say, for His Britannic Majesty's Navy a capital investment at small outlay or none at all.

After a brief pause during which the reminiscences above mentioned passed vividly through his mind and he weighed the import of Claggart's last suggestion conveyed in the phrase "man-trap under his daisies," and the more he weighed it the less reliance he felt in the informer's good faith, suddenly he turned upon him and in a low voice: "Do you come to me, Master-at-arms, with so foggy a tale? As to Budd, cite me an act or spoken word of his confirmatory of what you in general charge against him. Stay," drawing nearer to him, "heed what you speak. Just now, and in a case like this, there is a yard-arm-end for the false-witness."

"Ah, Your Honor!" sighed Claggart, mildly shaking his shapely head as in sad deprecation of such unmerited severity of tone. Then, bristling—erecting himself as in virtuous self-assertion—he circumstantially alleged certain words and acts, which collectively, if credited, led to presumptions mortally inculcating Budd. And for some of these averments, he added, substantiating proof was not far.

With gray eyes impatient and distrustful essaying to fathom to the bottom Claggart's calm violet ones, Captain Vere again heard him out; then for the moment stood ruminating. The mood he evinced, Claggart—himself for the time liberated from the other's scrutiny—steadily regarded with a look difficult to render—a look curious of the operation of his tactics, a look such as might have been that of the spokesman of the envious children of Jacob deceptively imposing upon the troubled patriarch the blood-dyed coat of young Joseph.

Though something exceptional in the moral quality of Captain Vere made him, in earnest encounter with a fellow-man, a veritable touch-stone of that man's essential nature, yet now as to Claggart and what was really going on in him, his feeling partook less of intuitional conviction than of strong suspicion clogged by strange dubieties. The perplexity he evinced proceeded less from aught touching the man informed against—as Claggart doubtless opined—than from considerations how best to act in regard to the informer. At first indeed he was naturally for summoning that substantiation of his allegations which Claggart said was at hand. But such a proceeding would result in the matter at once getting abroad, which in the present stage of it, he

thought, might undesirably affect the ship's company. If Claggart was a false witness—that closed the affair. And therefore before trying the accusation, he would first practically test the accuser; and he thought this could be done in a quiet undemonstrative way.

The measure he determined upon involved a shifting of the scene, a transfer to a place less exposed to observation than the broad quarter-deck. For although the few gun-room officers there at the time had, in due observance of naval etiquette, withdrawn to leeward the moment Captain Vere had begun his promenade on the deck's weather-side; and tho' during the colloquy with Claggart they of course ventured not to diminish the distance; and though throughout the interview Captain Vere's voice was far from high, and Claggart's silvery and low; and the wind in the cordage and the wash of the sea helped the more to put them beyond earshot; nevertheless, the interview's continuance already had attracted observation from some top-men aloft and other sailors in the waist or further forward.

Having determined upon his measures, Captain Vere forthwith took action. Abruptly turning to Claggart he asked, "Master-at-arms, is it now Budd's watch aloft?"

"No, Your Honor."

Whereupon, "Mr. Wilkes!" summoning the nearest midshipman, "tell Albert to come to me." Albert was the Captain's hammock-boy, a sort of sea-valet in whose discretion and fidelity his master had much confidence. The lad appeared.

"You know Budd the Foretopman?"

"I do, Sir."

"Go find him. It is his watch off. Manage to tell him out of earshot that he is wanted aft. Contrive it that he speaks to nobody. Keep him in talk yourself. And not till you get well aft here, not till then let him know that the place where he is wanted is my cabin. You understand. Go.—Master-at-arms, show yourself on the decks below, and when you think it time for Albert to be coming with his man, stand by quietly to follow the sailor in."

Chapter 19

Now when the Foretopman found himself closeted there, as it were, in the cabin with the Captain and Claggart, he was surprised enough. But it was a surprise unaccompanied by apprehension or distrust. To an immature nature essentially honest and humane, forewarning intimations of subtler danger from one's kind come tardily if at all. The only thing that took shape in the young sailor's mind was this: Yes, the Captain, I have always thought, looks kindly upon me. Wonder if he's going to make me his coxswain. I should like that. And maybe now he is going to ask the Master-at-arms about me.

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"Shut the door there, sentry," said the Commander; "stand without, and let nobody come in.—Now, Master-at-arms, tell this man to his face what you told of him to me;" and stood prepared to scrutinize the mutually confronting visages.

With the measured step and calm collected air of an asylum-physician approaching in the public hall some patient beginning to show indications of a coming paroxysm, Claggart deliberately advanced within short range of Billy, and mesmerically looking him in the eye, briefly recapitulated the accusation.

Not at first did Billy take it in. When he did, the rose-tan of his cheek looked struck as by white leprosy. He stood like one impaled and gagged. Meanwhile the accuser's eyes removing not as yet from the blue dilated ones, underwent a phenomenal change, their wonted rich violet color blurring into a muddy purple. Those lights of human intelligence losing human expression, gelidly protruding like the alien eyes of certain uncatalogued creatures of the deep. The first mesmeric glance was one of serpent fascination; the last was as the hungry lurch of the torpedo-fish.

"Speak, man!" said Captain Vere to the transfixed one, struck by his aspect even more than by Claggart's, "Speak! defend yourself." Which appeal caused but a strange dumb gesturing and gurgling in Billy; amazement at such an accusation so suddenly sprung on inexperienced nonage; this, and, it may be, horror of the accuser, serving to bring out his lurking defect and in this instance for the time intensifying it into a convulsed tongue-tie; while the intent head and entire form straining forward in an agony of ineffectual eagerness to obey the injunction to speak and defend himself, gave an expression to the face like that of a condemned Vestal priestess in the moment of being buried alive, and in the first struggle against suffocation.

Though at the time Captain Vere was quite ignorant of Billy's liability to vocal impediment, he now immediately divined it, since vividly Billy's aspect recalled to him that of a bright young schoolmate of his whom he had once seen struck by much the same startling impotence in the act of eagerly rising in the class to be foremost in response to a testing question put to it by the master. Going close up to the young sailor, and laying a soothing hand on his shoulder, he said, "There is no hurry, my boy. Take your time, take your time." Contrary to the effect intended, these words so fatherly in tone, doubtless touching Billy's heart to the quick, prompted yet more violent efforts at utterance—efforts soon ending for the time in confirming the paralysis, and bringing to his face an expression which was as a crucifixion to behold. The next instant, quick as the flame from a discharged cannon at night, his right arm shot out, and Claggart dropped to the deck. Whether intentionally or but owing to the young athlete's superior height, the blow had taken effect fully upon the forehead, so shapely and intellectual-looking a feature in the Master-at-arms; so

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that the body fell over lengthwise, like a heavy plank tilted from erectness. A gasp or two, and he lay motionless.

"Fated boy," breathed Captain Vere in tone so low as to be almost a whisper, "what have you done! But here, help me."

The twain raised the felled one from the loins up into a sitting position. The spare form flexibly acquiesced, but inertly. It was like handling a dead snake. They lowered it back. Regaining erectness Captain Vere with one hand covering his face stood to all appearance as impassive as the object at his feet. Was he absorbed in taking in all the bearings of the event and what was best not only now at once to be done, but also in the sequel? Slowly he uncovered his face; and the effect was as if the moon emerging from eclipse should reappear with quite another aspect than that which had gone into hiding. The father in him, manifested towards Billy thus far in the scene, was replaced by the military disciplinarian. In his official tone he bade the Foretopman retire to a state-room aft (pointing it out), and there remain till thence summoned. This order Billy in silence mechanically obeyed. Then going to the cabin-door where it opened on the quarter-deck, Captain Vere said to the sentry without, "Tell somebody to send Albert here." When the lad appeared his master so contrived it that he should not catch sight of the prone one. "Albert," he said to him, "tell the Surgeon I wish to see him. You need not come back till called."

When the Surgeon entered—a self-poised character of that grave sense and experience that hardly anything could take him aback—Captain Vere advanced to meet him, thus unconsciously intercepting his view of Claggart, and interrupting the other's wonted ceremonious salutation, said, "Nay, tell me how it is with yonder man," directing his attention to the prostrate one.

The Surgeon looked, and for all his self-command, somewhat started at the abrupt revelation. On Claggart's always pallid complexion, thick black blood was now oozing from nostril and ear. To the gazer's professional eye it was unmistakably no living man that he saw.

"Is it so then?" said Captain Vere intently watching him. "I thought it. But verify it." Whereupon the customary tests confirmed the Surgeon's first glance, who now looking up in unfeigned concern, cast a look of intense inquisitiveness upon his superior. But Captain Vere, with one hand to his brow, was standing motionless. Suddenly, catching the Surgeon's arm convulsively, he exclaimed, pointing down to the body—"It is the divine judgement on Ananias! Look!"

Disturbed by the excited manner he had never before observed in the *Indomitable's* Captain, and as yet wholly ignorant of the affair, the prudent Surgeon nevertheless held his peace, only again looking an earnest interrogation as to what it was that had resulted in such a tragedy.

But Captain Vere was now again motionless standing absorbed in thought. But again starting, he vehemently exclaimed—"Struck dead

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by an angel of God! Yet the angel must hang!"

At these passionate interjections, mere incoherences to the listener as yet unapprised of the antecedents, the Surgeon was profoundly discomposed. But now as recollecting himself, Captain Vere in less passionate tone briefly related the circumstances leading up to the event.

"But come; we must despatch," he added, "help me to remove him" (meaning the body) "to yonder compartment," designating one opposite that where the Foretopman remained immured. Anew disturbed by a request that as implying a desire for secrecy, seemed unaccountably strange to him, there was nothing for the subordinate to do but comply.

"Go now," said Captain Vere with something of his wonted manner—"Go now. I shall presently call a drum-head court. Tell the lieutenants what has happened, and tell Mr. Mordant," meaning the Captain of Marines, "and charge them to keep the matter to themselves."

Chapter 20

Full of disquietude and misgiving the Surgeon left the cabin. Was Captain Vere suddenly affected in his mind, or was it but a transient excitement, brought about by so strange and extraordinary a happening? As to the drum-head court, it struck the Surgeon as impolitic, if nothing more. The thing to do, he thought, was to place Billy Budd in confinement and in a way dictated by usage, and postpone further action in so extraordinary a case to such time as they should rejoin the squadron, and then refer it to the Admiral. He recalled the unwonted agitation of Captain Vere and his excited exclamations so at variance with his normal manner. Was he unhinged?

But assuming that he is, it is not so susceptible of proof. What then can he do? No more trying situation is conceivable than that of an officer subordinate under a Captain whom he suspects to be, not mad indeed, but yet not quite unaffected in his intellect. To argue his order to him would be insolence. To resist him would be mutiny.

In obedience to Captain Vere he communicated what had happened to the lieutenants and Captain of Marines; saying nothing as to the Captain's state. They fully shared his own surprise and concern. Like him too they seemed to think that such a matter should be referred to the Admiral.

Chapter 21

Who in the rainbow can draw the line where the violet tint ends

and the orange tint begins? Distinctly we see the difference of the colors, but where exactly does the one first blendingly enter into the other? So with sanity and insanity. In pronounced cases there is no question about them. But in some supposed cases, in various degrees supposedly less pronounced, to draw the exact line of demarkation few will undertake tho' for a fee some professional experts will. There is nothing namable but that some men will undertake to do it for pay.

Whether Captain Vere, as the Surgeon professionally and privately surmised, was really the sudden victim of any degree of aberration, one must determine for himself by such light as this narrative may afford.

That the unhappy event which has been narrated could not have happened at a worse juncture was but too true. For it was close on the heel of the suppressed insurrections, an aftertime very critical to naval authority, demanding from every English sea-commander two qualities not readily interfusable—prudence and rigour. Moreover there was something crucial in the case.

In the jugglery of circumstances preceding and attending the event on board the *Indomitable*, and in the light of that martial code whereby it was formally to be judged, innocence and guilt personified in Claggart and Budd in effect changed places. In a legal view the apparent victim of the tragedy was he who had sought to victimize a man blameless; and the indisputable deed of the latter, navally regarded, constituted the most heinous of military crimes. Yet more. The essential right and wrong involved in the matter, the clearer that might be, so much the worse for the responsibility of a loyal sea-commander inasmuch as he was not authorized to determine the matter on that primitive basis.

Small wonder then that the *Indomitable's* Captain, though in general a man of rapid decision, felt that circumspectness not less than promptitude was necessary. Until he could decide upon his course, and in each detail; and not only so, but until the concluding measure was upon the point of being enacted, he deemed it advisable, in view of all the circumstances, to guard as much as possible against publicity. Here he may or may not have erred. Certain it is, however, that subsequently in the confidential talk of more than one or two gun-rooms and cabins he was not a little criticized by some officers, a fact imputed by his friends and vehemently by his cousin, Jack Denton, to professional jealousy of Starry Vere. Some imaginative ground for invidious comment there was. The maintenance of secrecy in the matter, the confining all knowledge of it for a time to the place where the homicide occurred, the quarter-deck cabin; in these particulars lurked some resemblance to the policy adopted in those tragedies of the palace which have occurred more than once in the capital founded by Peter the Barbarian.

The case indeed was such that fain would the *Indomitable's* Captain have deferred taking any action whatever respecting it further

than to keep the Foretopman a close prisoner till the ship rejoined the squadron, and then submitting the matter to the judgement of his Admiral.

But a true military officer is in one particular like a true monk. Not with more of self-abnegation will the latter keep his vows of monastic obedience than the former his vows of allegiance to martial duty.

Feeling that unless quick action was taken on it, the deed of the Foretopman, so soon as it should be known on the gun decks, would tend to awaken any slumbering embers of the Nore among the crew, a sense of the urgency of the case overruled in Captain Vere every other consideration. But tho' a conscientious disciplinarian, he was no lover of authority for mere authority's sake. Very far was he from embracing opportunities for monopolizing to himself the perils of moral responsibility, none at least that could properly be referred to an official superior, or shared with him by his official equals or even subordinates. So thinking, he was glad it would not be at variance with usage to turn the matter over to a summary court of his own officers, reserving to himself as the one on whom the ultimate accountability would rest, the right of maintaining a supervision of it, or formally or informally interposing at need. Accordingly a drum-head court was summarily convened, he electing the individuals composing it, the First Lieutenant, the Captain of Marines, and the Sailing Master.

In associating an officer of marines with the sea-lieutenants in a case having to do with a sailor, the Commander perhaps deviated from general custom. He was prompted thereto by the circumstance that he took that soldier to be a judicious person, thoughtful, and not altogether incapable of grappling with a difficult case unprecedented in his prior experience. Yet even as to him he was not without some latent misgiving, for withal he was an extremely goodnatured man, an enjoyer of his dinner, a sound sleeper, and inclined to obesity, a man who tho' he would always maintain his manhood in battle might not prove altogether reliable in a moral dilemma involving aught of the tragic. As to the First Lieutenant and the Sailing Master, Captain Vere could not but be aware that though honest natures, of approved gallantry upon occasion, their intelligence was mostly confined to the matter of active seamanship and the fighting demands of their profession.

The court was held in the same cabin where the unfortunate affair had taken place. This cabin, the Commander's, embraced the entire area under the poopdeck. Aft, and on either side, was a small state-room; the one room temporarily a jail and the other a dead-house, and a yet smaller compartment leaving a space between, expanding forward into a goodly oblong of length coinciding with the ship's beam. A skylight of moderate dimension was overhead and at each end of the oblong space were two sashed port-hole windows easily convertible back into embrasures for short carronades.

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All being quickly in readiness, Billy Budd was arraigned, Captain Vere necessarily appearing as the sole witness in the case, and as such, temporarily sinking his rank, though singularly maintaining it in a matter apparently trivial, namely, that he testified from the ship's weather-side, with that object having caused the court to sit on the lee-side. Concisely he narrated all that had led up to the catastrophe, omitting nothing in Claggart's accusation and deposing as to the manner in which the prisoner had received it. At this testimony the three officers glanced with no little surprise at Billy Budd, the last man they would have suspected either of the mutinous design alleged by Claggart or the undeniable deed he himself had done. The First Lieutenant, taking judicial primacy and turning toward the prisoner, said, "Captain Vere has spoken. Is it or is it not as Captain Vere says?"

In response came syllables not so much impeded in the utterance as might have been anticipated. They were these: "Captain Vere tells the truth. It is just as Captain Vere says, but it is not as the Master-at-arms said. I have eaten the King's bread and I am true to the King."

"I believe you, my man," said the witness, his voice indicating a suppressed emotion not otherwise betrayed.

"God will bless you for that, Your Honor!" not without stammering said Billy, and all but broke down. But immediately was recalled to self-control by another question, to which with the same emotional difficulty of utterance he said, "No, there was no malice between us. I never bore malice against the Master-at-arms. I am sorry that he is dead. I did not mean to kill him. Could I have used my tongue I would not have struck him. But he foully lied to my face and in presence of my Captain, and I had to say something, and I could only say it with a blow, God help me!"

In the impulsive above-board manner of the frank one, the court saw confirmed all that was implied in words that just previously had perplexed them, coming as they did from the testifier to the tragedy and promptly following Billy's impassioned disclaimer of mutinous intent—Captain Vere's words, "I believe you, my man."

Next it was asked of him whether he knew of or suspected aught savoring of incipient trouble (meaning mutiny, tho' the explicit term was avoided) going on in any section of the ship's company.

The reply lingered. This was naturally imputed by the court to the same vocal embarrassment which had retarded or obstructed previous answers. But in main it was otherwise here; the question immediately recalling to Billy's mind the interview with the afterguardsman in the fore-chains. But an innate repugnance to playing a part at all approaching that of an informer against one's own shipmates—the same erring sense of uninstructed honor which had stood in the way of his reporting the matter at the time though as a loyal man-of-warman it was incumbent on him, and failure so to do if charged against him and proven, would have subjected him to the heaviest of penalties; this, with the blind feeling now his, that nothing really was being

hatched, prevailed with him. When the answer came it was a negative.

"One question more," said the officer of marines now first speaking and with a troubled earnestness. "You tell us that what the Master-at-arms said against you was a lie. Now why should he have so lied, so maliciously lied, since you declare there was no malice between you?"

At that question unintentionally touching on a spiritual sphere wholly obscure to Billy's thoughts, he was nonplussed, evincing a confusion indeed that some observers, such as can readily be imagined, would have construed into involuntary evidence of hidden guilt. Nevertheless he strove some way to answer, but all at once relinquished the vain endeavor, at the same time turning an appealing glance towards Captain Vere as deeming him his best helper and friend. Captain Vere who had been seated for a time rose to his feet, addressing the interrogator. "The question you put to him comes naturally enough. But how can he rightly answer it? or anybody else? unless indeed it be he who lies within there," designating the compartment where lay the corpse. "But the prone one there will not rise to our summons. In effect, tho', as it seems to me, the point you make is hardly material. Quite aside from any conceivable motive actuating the Master-at-arms, and irrespective of the provocation to the blow, a martial court must needs in the present case confine its attention to the blow's consequence, which consequence justly is to be deemed not otherwise than as the striker's deed."

This utterance, the full significance of which it was not at all likely that Billy took in, nevertheless caused him to turn a wistful interrogative look toward the speaker, a look in its dumb expressiveness not unlike that which a dog of generous breed might turn upon his master seeking in his face some elucidation of a previous gesture ambiguous to the canine intelligence. Nor was the same utterance without marked effect upon the three officers, more especially the soldier. Couched in it seemed to them a meaning unanticipated, involving a prejudgement on the speaker's part. It served to augment a mental disturbance previously evident enough.

The soldier once more spoke; in a tone of suggestive dubiety addressing at once his associates and Captain Vere: "Nobody is present—none of the ship's company, I mean—who might shed lateral light, if any is to be had, upon what remains mysterious in this matter."

"That is thoughtfully put," said Captain Vere; "I see your drift. Ay, there is a mystery; but, to use a Scriptural phrase, it is 'a mystery of iniquity,' a matter for psychologic theologians to discuss. But what has a military court to do with it? Not to add that for us any possible investigation of it is cut off by the lasting tongue-tie of—him—in yonder," again designating the mortuary stateroom. "The prisoner's deed—with that alone we have to do."

To this, and particularly the closing reiteration, the marine soldier knowing not how aptly to reply, sadly abstained from saying aught. The First Lieutenant who at the outset had not unnaturally assumed

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primacy in the court, now overrulingly instructed by a glance from Captain Vere, a glance more effective than words, resumed that primacy. Turning to the prisoner, "Budd," he said, and scarce in equable tones, "Budd, if you have aught further to say for yourself, say it now."

Upon this the young sailor turned another quick glance toward Captain Vere; then, as taking a hint from that aspect, a hint confirming his own instinct that silence was now best, replied to the Lieutenant, "I have said all, Sir."

The marine—the same who had been the sentinel without the cabin-door at the time that the Foretopman followed by the Master-at-arms, entered it—he, standing by the sailor throughout these judicial proceedings, was now directed to take him back to the after compartment originally assigned to the prisoner and his custodian. As the twain disappeared from view, the three officers as partially liberated from some inward constraint associated with Billy's mere presence, simultaneously stirred in their seats. They exchanged looks of troubled indecision, yet feeling that decide they must and without long delay. As for Captain Vere, he for the time stood unconsciously with his back toward them, apparently in one of his absent fits, gazing out from a sashed port-hole to windward upon the monotonous blank of the twilight sea. But the court's silence continuing, broken only at moments by brief consultations in low earnest tones, this seemed to arm him and energize him. Turning, he to-and-fro paced the cabin athwart; in the returning ascent to windward, climbing the slant deck in the ship's lee roll; without knowing it symbolizing thus in his action a mind resolute to surmount difficulties even if against primitive instincts strong as the wind and the sea. Presently he came to a stand before the three. After scanning their faces he stood less as mustering his thoughts for expression, than as one inly deliberating how best to put them to well-meaning men not intellectually mature, men with whom it was necessary to demonstrate certain principles that were axioms to himself. Similar impatience as to talking is perhaps one reason that deters some minds from addressing any popular assemblies.

When speak he did, something both in the substance of what he said and his manner of saying it, showed the influence of unshared studies modifying and tempering the practical training of an active career. This, along with his phraseology, now and then was suggestive of the grounds whereon rested that imputation of a certain pedantry socially alleged against him by certain naval men of wholly practical cast, captains who nevertheless would frankly concede that His Majesty's Navy mustered no more efficient officer of their grade than Starry Vere.

What he said was to this effect: "Hitherto I have been but the witness, little more; and I should hardly think now to take another tone, that of your coadjutor, for the time, did I not perceive in you—at the crisis too—a troubled hesitancy, proceeding, I doubt not, from

the clash of military duty with moral scruple—scruple vitalized by compassion. For the compassion, how can I otherwise than share it? But, mindful of paramount obligations I strive against scruples that may tend to enervate decision. Not, gentlemen, that I hide from myself that the case is an exceptional one. Speculatively regarded, it well might be referred to a jury of casuists. But for us here acting not as casuists or moralists, it is a case practical, and under martial law practically to be dealt with.

“But your scruples: do they move as in a dusk? Challenge them. Make them advance and declare themselves. Come now: do they import something like this? If, mindless of palliating circumstances, we are bound to regard the death of the Master-at-arms as the prisoner’s deed, then does that deed constitute a capital crime whereof the penalty is a mortal one? But in natural justice is nothing but the prisoner’s overt act to be considered? How can we adjudge to summary and shameful death a fellow-creature innocent before God, and whom we feel to be so?—Does that state it aright? You sign sad assent. Well, I too feel that, the full force of that. It is Nature. But do these buttons that we wear attest that our allegiance is to Nature? No, to the King. Though the ocean, which is inviolate Nature primeval, tho’ this be the element where we move and have our being as sailors, yet as the King’s officers lies our duty in a sphere correspondingly natural? So little is that true, that in receiving our commissions we in the most important regards ceased to be natural free-agents. When war is declared are we the commissioned fighters previously consulted? We fight at command. If our judgements approve the war, that is but coincidence. So in other particulars. So now. For suppose condemnation to follow these present proceedings. Would it be so much we ourselves that would condemn as it would be martial law operating through us? For that law and the rigour of it, we are not responsible. Our avowed responsibility is in this: That however pitilessly that law may operate, we nevertheless adhere to it and administer it.

“But the exceptional in the matter moves the hearts within you. Even so too is mine moved. But let not warm hearts betray heads that should be cool. Ashore in a criminal case will an upright judge allow himself off the bench to be waylaid by some tender kinswoman of the accused seeking to touch him with her tearful plea? Well the heart here denotes the feminine in man is as that piteous woman, and hard tho’ it be, she must here be ruled out.”

He paused, earnestly studying them for a moment; then resumed.

“But something in your aspect seems to urge that it is not solely the heart that moves in you, but also the conscience, the private conscience. But tell me whether or not, occupying the position we do, private conscience should not yield to that imperial one formulated in the code under which alone we officially proceed?”

Here the three men moved in their seats, less convinced than ag-

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itated by the course of an argument troubling but the more the spontaneous conflict within.

Perceiving which, the speaker paused for a moment; then abruptly changing his tone, went on.

"To steady us a bit, let us recur to the facts.—In war-time at sea a man-of-war's-man strikes his superior in grade, and the blow kills. Apart from its effect, the blow itself is, according to the Articles of War, a capital crime. Furthermore—"

"Ay, Sir," emotionally broke in the officer of marines, "in one sense it was. But surely Budd purposed neither mutiny nor homicide."

"Surely not, my good man. And before a court less arbitrary and more merciful than a martial one, that plea would largely extenuate. At the Last Assizes it shall acquit. But how here? We proceed under the law of the Mutiny Act. In feature no child can resemble his father more than that Act resembles in spirit the thing from which it derives—War. In His Majesty's service—in this ship indeed—there are Englishmen forced to fight for the King against their will. Against their conscience, for aught we know. Tho' as their fellow-creatures some of us may appreciate their position, yet as navy officers, what reck we of it? Still less recks the enemy. Our impressed men he would fain cut down in the same swath with our volunteers. As regards the enemy's naval conscripts, some of whom may even share our own abhorrence of the regicidal French Directory, it is the same on our side. War looks but to the frontage, the appearance. And the Mutiny Act, War's child, takes after the father. Budd's intent or non-intent is nothing to the purpose.

"But while, put to it by these anxieties in you which I can not but respect, I only repeat myself—while thus strangely we prolong proceedings that should be summary—the enemy may be sighted and an engagement result. We must do; and one of two things must we do—condemn or let go."

"Can we not convict and yet mitigate the penalty?" asked the junior Lieutenant here speaking, and falteringly, for the first.

"Lieutenant, were that clearly lawful for us under the circumstances, consider the consequences of such clemency. The people," (meaning the ship's company) "have native-sense; most of them are familiar with our naval usage and tradition; and how would they take it? Even could you explain to them—which our official position forbids—they, long moulded by arbitrary discipline have not that kind of intelligent responsiveness that might qualify them to comprehend and discriminate. No, to the people the Foretopman's deed, however it be worded in the announcement, will be plain homicide committed in a flagrant act of mutiny. What penalty for that should follow, they know. But it does not follow. Why? they will ruminate. You know what sailors are. Will they not revert to the recent outbreak at the Nore? Ay. They know the well-founded alarm—the panic it struck

throughout England. Your clement sentence they would account pusillanimous. They would think that we flinch, that we are afraid of them—afraid of practising a lawful rigour singularly demanded at this juncture lest it should provoke new troubles. What shame to us such a conjecture on their part, and how deadly to discipline. You see then, whither, prompted by duty and the law, I steadfastly drive. But I beseech you, my friends, do not take me amiss. I feel as you do for this unfortunate boy. But did he know our hearts, I take him to be of that generous nature that he would feel even for us on whom in this military necessity so heavy a compulsion is laid.”

With that, crossing the deck he resumed his place by the sashed port-hole, tacitly leaving the three to come to a decision. On the cabin’s opposite side the troubled court sat silent. Loyal lieges, plain and practical, though at bottom they dissented from some points Captain Vere had put to them, they were without the faculty, hardly had the inclination, to gainsay one whom they felt to be an earnest man, one too not less their superior in mind than in naval rank. But it is not improbable that even such of his words as were not without influence over them, less came home to them than his closing appeal to their instinct as sea-officers in the forethought he threw out as to the practical consequences to discipline, considering the unconfirmed tone of the fleet at the time, should a man-of-war’s-man’s violent killing at sea of a superior in grade be allowed to pass for aught else than a capital crime demanding prompt infliction of the penalty.

Not unlikely they were brought to something more or less akin to that harassed frame of mind which in the year 1842 actuated the Commander of the U.S. brig-of-war *Somers* to resolve, under the so-called Articles of War, Articles modelled upon the English Mutiny Act, to resolve upon the execution at sea of a midshipman and two petty-officers as mutineers designing the seizure of the brig. Which resolution was carried out though in a time of peace and within not many days of home. An act vindicated by a naval court of inquiry subsequently convened ashore. History, and here cited without comment. True, the circumstances on board the *Somers* were different from those on board the *Indomitable*. But the urgency felt, well-warranted or otherwise, was much the same.

Says a writer whom few know, “Forty years after a battle it is easy for a non-combatant to reason about how it ought to have been fought. It is another thing personally and under fire to direct the fighting while involved in the obscuring smoke of it. Much so with respect to other emergencies involving considerations both practical and moral, and when it is imperative promptly to act. The greater the fog the more it imperils the steamer, and speed is put on tho’ at the hazard of running somebody down. Little ween the snug card-players in the cabin of the responsibilities of the sleepless man on the bridge.”

In brief, Billy Budd was formally convicted and sentenced to be hung at the yard-arm in the early morning watch, it being now night.

Otherwise, as is customary in such cases, the sentence would forthwith have been carried out. In war-time on the field or in the fleet, a mortal punishment decreed by a drum-head court—on the field sometimes decreed by but a nod from the General—follows without delay on the heel of conviction without appeal.

Chapter 22

It was Captain Vere himself who of his own motion communicated the finding of the court to the prisoner; for that purpose going to the compartment where he was in custody and bidding the marine there to withdraw for the time.

Beyond the communication of the sentence what took place at this interview was never known. But in view of the character of the twain briefly closeted in that state-room, each radically sharing in the rarer qualities of our nature—so rare indeed as to be all but incredible to average minds however much cultivated—some conjectures may be ventured.

It would have been in consonance with the spirit of Captain Vere should he on this occasion have concealed nothing from the condemned one—should he indeed have frankly disclosed to him the part he himself had played in bringing about the decision, at the same time revealing his actuating motives. On Billy's side it is not improbable that such a confession would have been received in much the same spirit that prompted it. Not without a sort of joy indeed he might have appreciated the brave opinion of him implied in his Captain's making such a confidant of him. Nor, as to the sentence itself could he have been insensible that it was imparted to him as to one not afraid to die. Even more may have been. Captain Vere in the end may have developed the passion sometimes latent under an exterior stoical or indifferent. He was old enough to have been Billy's father. The austere devotee of military duty, letting himself melt back into what remains primeval in our formalized humanity, may in the end have caught Billy to his heart even as Abraham may have caught young Isaac on the brink of resolutely offering him up in obedience to the exacting behest. But there is no telling the sacrament, seldom if in any case revealed to the gadding world, wherever under circumstances at all akin to those here attempted to be set forth, two of great Nature's nobler order embrace. There is privacy at the time, inviolable to the survivor, and holy oblivion, the sequel to each diviner magnanimity, providentially covers all at last.

The first to encounter Captain Vere in act of leaving the compartment was the senior Lieutenant. The face he beheld, for the moment one expressive of the agony of the strong, was to that officer, tho' a man of fifty, a startling revelation. That the condemned one suffered

less than he who mainly had effected the condemnation was apparently indicated by the former's exclamation in the scene soon perforce to be touched upon.

Chapter 23

Of a series of incidents within a brief term rapidly following each other, the adequate narration may take up a term less brief, especially if explanation or comment here and there seem requisite to the better understanding of such incidents. Between the entrance into the cabin of him who never left it alive, and him who when he did leave it left it as one condemned to die; between this and the closeted interview just given, less than an hour and a half had elapsed. It was an interval long enough however to awaken speculations among no few of the ship's company as to what it was that could be detaining in the cabin the Master-at-arms and the sailor; for a rumor that both of them had been seen to enter it and neither of them had been seen to emerge, this rumor had got abroad upon the gun decks and in the tops; the people of a great war-ship being in one respect like villagers taking microscopic note of every outward movement or non-movement going on. When therefore in weather not at all tempestuous all hands were called in the second dog-watch, a summons under such circumstances not usual in those hours, the crew were not wholly unprepared for some announcement extraordinary, one having connection too with the continued absence of the two men from their wonted haunts.

There was a moderate sea at the time; and the moon, newly risen and near to being at its full, silvered the white spar-deck wherever not blotted by the clear-cut shadows horizontally thrown of fixtures and moving men. On either side of the quarter-deck, the marine guard under arms was drawn up; and Captain Vere standing in his place surrounded by all the ward-room officers, addressed his men. In so doing his manner showed neither more nor less than that properly pertaining to his supreme position aboard his own ship. In clear terms and concise he told them what had taken place in the cabin; that the Master-at-arms was dead; that he who had killed him had been already tried by a summary court and condemned to death; and that the execution would take place in the early morning watch. The word mutiny was not named in what he said. He refrained too from making the occasion an opportunity for any preachment as to the maintenance of discipline, thinking perhaps that under existing circumstances in the navy the consequence of violating discipline should be made to speak for itself.

Their Captain's announcement was listened to by the throng of standing sailors in a dumbness like that of a seated congregation of believers in hell listening to the clergyman's announcement of his Calvinistic text.

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At the close, however, a confused murmur went up. It began to wax. All but instantly, then, at a sign, it was pierced and suppressed by shrill whistles of the Boatswain and his Mates piping down one watch.

To be prepared for burial Claggart's body was delivered to certain petty-officers of his mess. And here, not to clog the sequel with lateral matters, it may be added that at a suitable hour, the Master-at-arms was committed to the sea with every funeral honor properly belonging to his naval grade.

In this proceeding as in every public one growing out of the tragedy, strict adherence to usage was observed. Nor in any point could it have been at all deviated from, either with respect to Claggart or Billy Budd, without begetting undesirable speculations in the ship's company, sailors, and more particularly men-of-war's-men, being of all men the greatest sticklers for usage. For similar cause, all communication between Captain Vere and the condemned one ended with the closeted interview already given, the latter being now surrendered to the ordinary routine preliminary to the end. This transfer under guard from the Captain's quarters was effected without unusual precautions—at least no visible ones. If possible, not to let the men so much as surmise that their officers anticipate aught amiss from them is the tacit rule in a military ship. And the more that some sort of trouble should really be apprehended the more do the officers keep that apprehension to themselves; tho' not the less unostentatious vigilance may be augmented. In the present instance the sentry placed over the prisoner had strict orders to let no one have communication with him but the Chaplain. And certain unobtrusive measures were taken absolutely to insure this point.

Chapter 24

In a seventy-four of the old order the deck known as the upper gun deck was the one covered over by the spar-deck which last though not without its armament was for the most part exposed to the weather. In general it was at all hours free from hammocks; those of the crew swinging on the lower gun deck, and berth-deck, the latter being not only a dormitory but also the place for the stowing of the sailors' bags, and on both sides lined with the large chests or movable pantries of the many messes of the men.

On the starboard side of the *Indomitable's* upper gun deck, behold Billy Budd under sentry, lying prone in irons, in one of the bays formed by the regular spacing of the guns comprising the batteries on either side. All these pieces were of the heavier calibre of that period. Mounted on lumbering wooden carriages they were hampered with cumbersome harness of breechen and strong side-tackles for running them out. Guns and carriages, together with the long rammers and

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shorter lintstocks lodged in loops overhead—all these, as customary, were painted black; and the heavy hempen bre-echens, tarred to the same tint, wore the like livery of the undertakers. In contrast with the funereal hue of these surroundings the prone sailor's exterior apparel, white jumper and white duck trousers, each more or less soiled, dimly glimmered in the obscure light of the bay like a patch of discolored snow in early April lingering at some upland cave's black mouth. In effect he is already in his shroud or the garments that shall serve him in lieu of one. Over him, but scarce illuminating him, two battle-lanterns swing from two massive beams of the deck above. Fed with the oil supplied by the war-contractors (whose gains, honest or otherwise, are in every land an anticipated portion of the harvest of death), with flickering splashes of dirty yellow light they pollute the pale moonshine all but ineffectually struggling in obstructed flecks thro' the open ports from which the tompioned cannon protrude. Other lanterns at intervals serve but to bring out somewhat the obscurer bays which, like small confessionals or side-chapels in a cathedral, branch from the long dim-vistaed broad aisle between the two batteries of that covered tier.

Such was the deck where now lay the Handsome Sailor. Through the rose-tan of his complexion, no pallor could have shown. It would have taken days of sequestration from the winds and the sun to have brought about the effacement of that. But the skeleton in the cheekbone at the point of its angle was just beginning delicately to be defined under the warm-tinted skin. In fervid hearts self-contained, some brief experiences devour our human tissue as secret fire in a ship's hold consumes cotton in the bale.

But now lying between the two guns, as nipped in the vice of fate, Billy's agony, mainly proceeding from a generous young heart's virgin experience of the diabolical incarnate and effective in some men—the tension of that agony was over now. It survived not the something healing in the closeted interview with Captain Vere. Without movement, he lay as in a trance. That adolescent expression previously noted as his, taking on something akin to the look of a slumbering child in the cradle when the warm hearth-glow of the still chamber at night plays on the dimples that at whiles mysteriously form in the cheek, silently coming and going there. For now and then in the gyved one's trance a serene happy light born of some wandering reminiscence or dream would diffuse itself over his face, and then wane away only anew to return.

The Chaplain coming to see him and finding him thus, and perceiving no sign that he was conscious of his presence, attentively regarded him for a space, then slipping aside, withdrew for the time, peradventure feeling that even he the minister of Christ, tho' receiving his stipend from Mars, had no consolation to proffer which could result in a peace transcending that which he beheld. But in the small

hours he came again. And the prisoner, now awake to his surroundings, noticed his approach, and civilly, all but cheerfully, welcomed him. But it was to little purpose that in the interview following the good man sought to bring Billy Budd to some godly understanding that he must die, and at dawn. True, Billy himself freely referred to his death as a thing close at hand; but it was something in the way that children will refer to death in general, who yet among their other sports will play a funeral with hearse and mourners.

Not that like children Billy was incapable of conceiving what death really is. No, but he was wholly without irrational fear of it, a fear more prevalent in highly civilized communities than those so-called barbarous ones which in all respects stand nearer to unadulterate Nature. And, as elsewhere said, a barbarian Billy radically was; as much so, for all the costume, as his countrymen the British captives, living trophies, made to march in the Roman triumph of Germanicus. Quite as much so as those later barbarians, young men probably, and picked specimens among the earlier British converts to Christianity, at least nominally such, and taken to Rome (as to-day converts from lesser isles of the sea may be taken to London), of whom the Pope of that time, admiring the strangeness of their personal beauty so unlike the Italian stamp, their clear ruddy complexion and curled flaxen locks, exclaimed, "Angles" (meaning English the modern derivative) "Angles do you call them? And is it because they look so like angels?" Had it been later in time one would think that the Pope had in mind Fra Angelico's seraphs some of whom, plucking apples in gardens of the Hesperides, have the faint rose-bud complexion of the more beautiful English girls.

If in vain the good Chaplain sought to impress the young barbarian with ideas of death akin to those conveyed in the skull, dial, and cross-bones on old tombstones; equally futile to all appearance were his efforts to bring home to him the thought of salvation and a Saviour. Billy listened, but less out of awe or reverence perhaps than from a certain natural politeness; doubtless at bottom regarding all that in much the same way that most mariners of his class take any discourse abstract or out of the common tone of the work-a-day world. And this sailor-way of taking clerical discourse is not wholly unlike the way in which the pioneer of Christianity full of transcendent miracles was received long ago on tropic isles by any superior savage so called—a Tahitian say of Captain Cook's time or shortly after that time. Out of natural courtesy he received, but did not appropriate. It was like a gift placed in the palm of an outreached hand upon which the fingers do not close.

But the *Indomitable's* Chaplain was a discreet man possessing the good sense of a good heart. So he insisted not in his vocation here. At the instance of Captain Vere, a lieutenant had apprised him of pretty much everything as to Billy; and since he felt that innocence was even a better thing than religion wherewith to go to Judgement,

he reluctantly withdrew; but in his emotion not without first performing an act strange enough in an Englishman, and under the circumstances yet more so in any regular priest. Stooping over, he kissed on the fair cheek his fellow-man, a felon in martial law, one who though on the confines of death he felt he could never convert to a dogma; nor for all that did he fear for his future.

Marvel not that having been made acquainted with the young sailor's essential innocence (an irruption of heretic thought hard to suppress) the worthy man lifted not a finger to avert the doom of such a martyr to martial discipline. So to do would not only have been as idle as invoking the desert, but would also have been an audacious transgression of the bounds of his function, one as exactly prescribed to him by military law as that of the boatswain or any other naval officer. Bluntly put, a chaplain is the minister of the Prince of Peace serving in the host of the God of War—Mars. As such, he is as incongruous as a musket would be on the altar at Christmas. Why then is he there? Because he indirectly subserves the purpose attested by the cannon; because too he lends the sanction of the religion of the meek to that which practically is the abrogation of everything but brute Force.

Chapter 25

The night, so luminous on the spar-deck, but otherwise on the cavernous ones below, levels so like the tiered galleries in a coal-mine—the luminous night passed away. But, like the prophet in the chariot disappearing in heaven and dropping his mantle to Elisha, the withdrawing night transferred its pale robe to the breaking day. A meek shy light appeared in the East, where stretched a diaphanous fleece of white furrowed vapor. That light slowly waxed. Suddenly eight bells was struck aft, responded to by one louder metallic stroke from forward. It was four o'clock in the morning. Instantly the silver whistles were heard summoning all hands to witness punishment. Up through the great hatchways rimmed with racks of heavy shot, the watch below came pouring, overspreading with the watch already on deck the space between the main-mast and fore-mast including that occupied by the capacious launch and the black booms tiered on either side of it, boat and booms making a summit of observation for the powder-boys and younger tars. A different group comprising one watch of topmen leaned over the rail of that sea-balcony, no small one in a seventy-four, looking down on the crowd below. Man or boy, none spake but in whisper, and few spake at all. Captain Vere—as before, the central figure among the assembled commissioned officers—stood nigh the break of the poop-deck facing forward. Just below him on the quarter-deck the marines in full equipment were drawn up much as at the scene of the promulgated sentence.

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At sea in the old time, the execution by halter of a military sailor was generally from the fore-yard. In the present instance, for special reasons the main-yard was assigned. Under an arm of that lee-yard the prisoner was presently brought up, the Chaplain attending him. It was noted at the time and remarked upon afterwards, that in this final scene the good man evinced little or nothing of the perfunctory. Brief speech indeed he had with the condemned one, but the genuine Gospel was less on his tongue than in his aspect and manner towards him. The final preparations personal to the latter being speedily brought to an end by two boatswain's mates, the consummation impended. Billy stood facing aft. At the penultimate moment, his words, his only ones, words wholly unobstructed in the utterance were these—"God bless Captain Vere!" Syllables so unanticipated coming from one with the ignominious hemp about his neck—a conventional felon's benediction directed aft towards the quarters of honor; syllables too delivered in the clear melody of a singing-bird on the point of launching from the twig, had a phenomenal effect, not unenhanced by the rare personal beauty of the young sailor spiritualized now thro' late experiences so poignantly profound.

Without volition as it were, as if indeed the ship's populace were but the vehicles of some vocal current electric, with one voice from aloft and aloft came a resonant sympathetic echo—"God bless Captain Vere!" And yet at that instant Billy alone must have been in their hearts, even as he was in their eyes.

At the pronounced words and the spontaneous echo that voluminously rebounded them, Captain Vere, either thro' stoic self-control or a sort of momentary paralysis induced by emotional shock, stood erectly rigid as a musket in the ship-armorer's rack.

The hull deliberately recovering from the periodic roll to leeward was just regaining an even keel, when the last signal, a preconcerted dumb one, was given. At the same moment it chanced that the vapory fleece hanging low in the East, was shot thro' with a soft glory as of the fleece of the Lamb of God seen in mystical vision, and simultaneously therewith, watched by the wedged mass of upturned faces, Billy ascended; and, ascending, took the full rose of the dawn.

In the pinioned figure, arrived at the yard-end, to the wonder of all no motion was apparent, none save that created by the ship's motion, in moderate weather so majestic in a great ship ponderously canoned.

Chapter 26

When some days afterward in reference to the singularity just mentioned, the Purser, a rather ruddy rotund person more accurate as an accountant than profound as a philosopher, said at mess to the

Surgeon, "What testimony to the force lodged in will-power," the latter—saturnine, spare and tall, one in whom a discreet causticity went along with a manner less genial than polite, replied, "Your pardon, Mr. Purser. In a hanging scientifically conducted—and under special orders I myself directed how Budd's was to be effected—any movement following the completed suspension and originating in the body suspended, such movement indicates mechanical spasm in the muscular system. Hence the absence of that is no more attributable to will-power as you call it than to horse-power—begging your pardon."

"But this muscular spasm you speak of, is not that in a degree more or less invariable in these cases?"

"Assuredly so, Mr. Purser."

"How then, my good sir, do you account for its absence in this instance?"

"Mr. Purser, it is clear that your sense of the singularity in this matter equals not mine. You account for it by what you call will-power, a term not yet included in the lexicon of science. For me I do not, with my present knowledge, pretend to account for it at all. Even should we assume the hypothesis that at the first touch of the halyards the action of Budd's heart, intensified by extraordinary emotion at its climax, abruptly stopt—much like a watch when in carelessly winding it up you strain at the finish, thus snapping the chain—even under that hypothesis, how account for the phenomenon that followed?"

"You admit then that the absence of spasmodic movement was phenomenal."

"It was phenomenal, Mr. Purser, in the sense that it was an appearance the cause of which is not immediately to be assigned."

"But tell me, my dear Sir," pertinaciously continued the other, "was the man's death effected by the halter, or was it a species of euthanasia?"

"Euthanasia, Mr. Purser, is something like your will-power: I doubt its authenticity as a scientific term—begging your pardon again. It is at once imaginative and metaphysical—in short, Greek. But," abruptly changing his tone, "there is a case in the sick-bay that I do not care to leave to my assistants. Beg your pardon, but excuse me." And rising from the mess he formally withdrew.

Chapter 27

The silence at the moment of execution and for a moment or two continuing thereafter, a silence but emphasized by the regular wash of the sea against the hull or the flutter of a sail caused by the helmsman's eyes being tempted astray, this emphasized silence was gradually disturbed by a sound not easily to be verbally rendered. Whoever has heard the freshet-wave of a torrent suddenly swelled by pouring

showers in tropical mountains, showers not shared by the plain; whoever has heard the first muffled murmur of its sloping advance through precipitous woods, may form some conception of the sound now heard. The seeming remoteness of its source was because of its murmurous indistinctness since it came from close-by, even from the men massed on the ship's open deck. Being inarticulate, it was dubious in significance further than it seemed to indicate some capricious revulsion of thought or feeling such as mobs ashore are liable to, in the present instance possibly implying a sullen revocation on the men's part of their involuntary echoing of Billy's benediction. But ere the murmur had time to wax into clamour it was met by a strategic command, the more telling that it came with abrupt unexpectedness. "Pipe down the starboard watch, Boatswain, and see that they go."

Shrill as the shriek of the sea-hawk the whistles of the Boatswain and his Mates pierced that ominous low sound, dissipating it; and yielding to the mechanism of discipline, the throng was thinned by one half. For the remainder most of them were set to temporary employments connected with trimming the yards and so forth, business readily to be got up to serve occasion by any officer-of-the-deck.

Now each proceeding that follows a mortal sentence pronounced at sea by a drum-head court is characterised by promptitude not perceptibly merging into hurry, tho' bordering that. The hammock, the one which had been Billy's bed when alive, having already been ballasted with shot and otherwise prepared to serve for his canvas coffin, the last offices of the sea-undertakers, the Sail-Maker's Mates, were now speedily completed. When everything was in readiness a second call for all hands made necessary by the strategic movement before mentioned was sounded and now to witness burial.

The details of this closing formality it needs not to give. But when the tilted plank let slide its freight into the sea, a second strange human murmur was heard, blended now with another inarticulate sound proceeding from certain larger sea-fowl, whose attention having been attracted by the peculiar commotion in the water resulting from the heavy sloped dive of the shotted hammock into the sea, flew screaming to the spot. So near the hull did they come, that the stridor or bony creak of their gaunt double-jointed pinions was audible. As the ship under light airs passed on, leaving the burial-spot astern, they still kept circling it low down with the moving shadow of their outstretched wings and the croaked requiem of their cries.

Upon sailors as superstitious as those of the age preceding ours, men-of-war's-men too who had just beheld the prodigy of repose in the form suspended in air and now foundering in the deeps; to such mariners the action of the sea-fowl, tho' dictated by mere animal greed for prey, was big with no prosaic significance. An uncertain movement began among them, in which some encroachment was made. It was tolerated but for a moment. For suddenly the drum beat to quarters, which familiar sound happening at least twice every day,

had upon the present occasion a signal peremptoriness in it. True martial discipline long continued superinduces in average man a sort of impulse of docility whose operation at the official sound of command much resembles in its promptitude the effect of an instinct.

The drum-beat dissolved the multitude, distributing most of them along the batteries of the two covered gun decks. There, as wont, the guns' crews stood by their respective cannon erect and silent. In due course the First Officer, sword under arm and standing in his place on the quarter-deck, formally received the successive reports of the sworded Lieutenants commanding the sections of batteries below; the last of which reports being made, the summed report he delivered with the customary salute to the Commander. All this occupied time, which in the present case, was the object of beating to quarters at an hour prior to the customary one. That such variance from usage was authorized by an officer like Captain Vere, a martinet as some deemed him, was evidence of the necessity for unusual action implied in what he deemed to be temporarily the mood of his men. "With mankind," he would say, "forms, measured forms are everything; and that is the import couched in the story of Orpheus with his lyre spell-binding the wild denizens of the wood." And this he once applied to the disruption of forms going on across the Channel and the consequences thereof.

At this unwonted muster at quarters, all proceeded as at the regular hour. The band on the quarter-deck played a sacred air. After which the Chaplain went thro' the customary morning service. That done, the drum beat the retreat, and toned by music and religious rites subserving the discipline and purpose of war, the men in their wonted orderly manner, dispersed to the places allotted them when not at the guns.

And now it was full day. The fleece of low-hanging vapor had vanished, licked up by the sun that late had so glorified it. And the circumambient air in the clearness of its serenity was like smooth marble in the polished block not yet removed from the marble-dealer's yard.

Chapter 28

The symmetry of form attainable in pure fiction can not so readily be achieved in a narration essentially having less to do with fable than with fact. Truth uncompromisingly told will always have its ragged edges; hence the conclusion of such a narration is apt to be less finished than an architectural finial.

How it fared with the Handsome Sailor during the year of the Great Mutiny has been faithfully given. But tho' properly the story ends with his life, something in way of sequel will not be amiss. Three brief chapters will suffice.

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In the general re-christening under the Directory of the craft originally forming the navy of the French monarchy, the St. Louis line-of-battle ship was named the *Atheiste*. Such a name, like some other substituted ones in the Revolutionary fleet, while proclaiming the infidel audacity of the ruling power was yet, tho' not so intended to be, the aptest name, if one consider it, ever given to a war-ship; far more so indeed than the *Devastation*, the *Erebus* (the *Hell*) and similar names bestowed upon fighting-ships.

On the return-passage to the English fleet from the detached cruise during which occurred the events already recorded, the *Indomitable* fell in with the *Atheiste*. An engagement ensued; during which Captain Vere, in the act of putting his ship alongside the enemy with a view of throwing his boarders across her bulwarks, was hit by a musket-ball from a port-hole of the enemy's main cabin. More than disabled he dropped to the deck and was carried below to the same cockpit where some of his men already lay. The senior Lieutenant took command. Under him the enemy was finally captured and though much crippled was by rare good fortune successfully taken into Gibraltar, an English port not very distant from the scene of the fight. There, Captain Vere with the rest of the wounded was put ashore. He lingered for some days, but the end came. Unhappily he was cut off too early for the Nile and Trafalgar. The spirit that spite its philosophic austerity may yet have indulged in the most secret of all passions, ambition, never attained to the fulness of fame.

Not long before death, while lying under the influence of that magical drug which soothing the physical frame mysteriously operates on the subtler element in man, he was heard to murmur words inexplicable to his attendant—"Billy Budd, Billy Budd." That these were not the accents of remorse, would seem clear from what the attendant said to the *Indomitable's* senior officer of marines who, as the most reluctant to condemn of the members of the drum-head court, too well knew, tho' here he kept the knowledge to himself, who Billy Budd was.

Chapter 29

Some few weeks after the execution, among other matters under the head of News from the Mediterranean, there appeared in a naval chronicle of the time, an authorized weekly publication, an account of the affair. It was doubtless for the most part written in good faith, tho' the medium, partly rumor, through which the facts must have reached the writer, served to deflect and in part falsify them. The account was as follows:—

"On the tenth of the last month a deplorable occurrence took place on board H.M.S. *Indomitable*. John Claggart, the ship's Master-at-arms, discovering that some sort of plot was incipient among an

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inferior section of the ship's company, and that the ringleader was one William Budd; he, Claggart, in the act of arraigning the man before the Captain was vindictively stabbed to the heart by the suddenly drawn sheath-knife of Budd.

"The deed and the implement employed, sufficiently suggest that tho' mustered into the service under an English name the assassin was no Englishman, but one of those aliens adopting English cognomens whom the present extraordinary necessities of the Service have caused to be admitted into it in considerable numbers.

"The enormity of the crime and the extreme depravity of the criminal, appear the greater in view of the character of the victim, a middle-aged man respectable and discreet, belonging to that official grade, the petty-officers, upon whom, as none know better than the commissioned gentlemen, the efficiency of His Majesty's Navy so largely depends. His function was a responsible one, at once onerous & thankless, and his fidelity in it the greater because of his strong patriotic impulse. In this instance as in so many other instances in these days, the character of this unfortunate man signally refutes, if refutation were needed, that peevish saying attributed to the late Dr. Johnson, that patriotism is the last refuge of a scoundrel.

"The criminal paid the penalty of his crime. The promptitude of the punishment has proved salutary. Nothing amiss is now apprehended aboard H.M.S. *Indomitable*."

The above, appearing in a publication now long ago superannuated and forgotten, is all that hitherto has stood in human record to attest what manner of men respectively were John Claggart and Billy Budd.

Chapter 30

Everything is for a term remarkable in navies. Any tangible object associated with some striking incident of the service is converted into a monument. The spar from which the Foretopman was suspended, was for some few years kept trace of by the blue-jackets. Their knowledge followed it from ship to dock-yard and again from dock-yard to ship, still pursuing it even when at last reduced to a mere dock-yard boom. To them a chip of it was as a piece of the Cross. Ignorant tho' they were of the secret facts of the tragedy, and not thinking but that the penalty was somehow unavoidably inflicted from the naval point of view, for all that they instinctively felt that Billy was a sort of man as incapable of mutiny as of wilfull murder. They recalled the fresh young image of the Handsome Sailor, that face never deformed by a sneer or subtler vile freak of the heart within. Their impression of him was doubtless deepened by the fact that he was gone, and in a measure mysteriously gone. At the time, on the gun decks of the *In-*

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domitable, the general estimate of his nature and its unconscious simplicity eventually found rude utterance from another foretopman, one of his own watch, gifted, as some sailors are, with an artless poetic temperament; the tarry hands made some lines which after circulating among the shipboard crew for a while, finally got rudely printed at Portsmouth as a ballad. The title given to it was the sailor's.

BILLY IN THE DARBIES

Good of the Chaplain to enter Lone Bay
And down on his marrow-bones here and pray
For the likes just o' me, Billy Budd.—But look:
Through the port comes the moon-shine astray!
It tips the guard's cutlas and silvers this nook;
But 'twill die in the dawning of Billy's last day.
A jewel-block they'll make of me to-morrow,
Pendant pearl from the yard-arm-end
Like the ear-drop I gave to Bristol Molly—
O, 'tis me, not the sentence they'll suspend.
Ay, Ay, Ay, all is up; and I must up too
Early in the morning, aloft from alow.
On an empty stomach, now, never it would do.
They'll give me a nibble—bit o' biscuit ere I go.
Sure, a messmate will reach me the last parting cup;
But, turning heads away from the hoist and the belay,
Heaven knows who will have the running of me up!
No pipe to those halyards.—But aren't it all sham?
A blur's in my eyes; it is dreaming that I am.
A hatchet to my hawser? all adrift to go?
The drum roll to grog, and Billy never know?
But Donald he has promised to stand by the plank;
So I'll shake a friendly hand ere I sink.
But—no! It is dead then I'll be, come to think.
I remember Taff the Welshman when he sank.
And his cheek it was like the budding pink.
But me they'll lash me in hammock, drop me deep.
Fathoms down, fathoms down, how I'll dream fast asleep.
I feel it stealing now. Sentry, are you there?
Just ease this darbies at the wrist, and roll me over fair,
I am sleepy, and the oozy weeds about me twist.

THE END